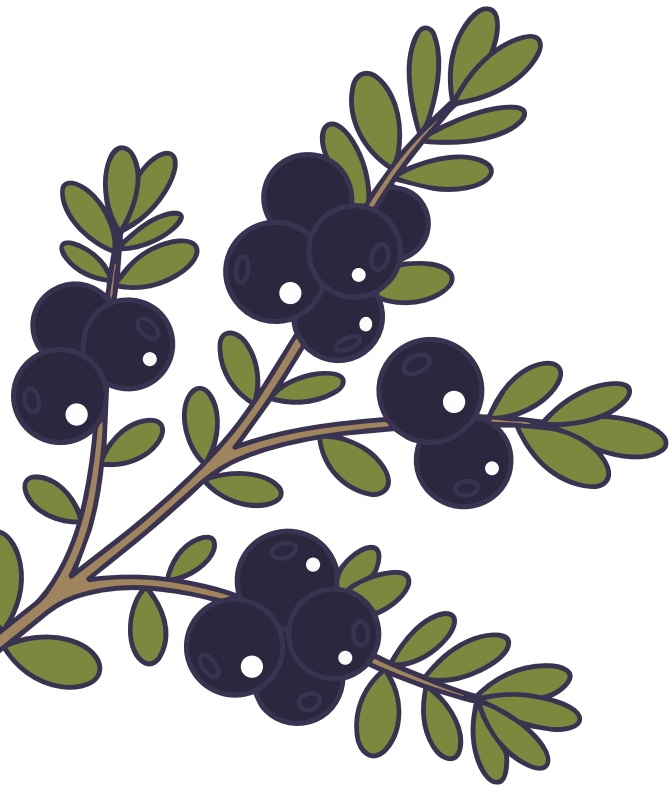
Strengthening food access in Nunavut



Lessons from the Inuit Child First Initiative funded Grocery Supports and the Hamlet Food Voucher Program

ᖃᑯᓂᓇᖅ
Qupanuaq



Research team members over the lifetime of the project

Boulder

Vandna Sinha

Kelly Mitchell

Nga Hoang

Danielle N. Aguilar

Toronto Metropolitan University

Nicholas Li

Raymond Morgan

Jessica Penney*

Qupanuaq

Sindu Govindapillai

Dheeksha Reddy

Carolyn Tapardjuk

Carmen Rowsell

HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Sappho Z. Gilbert

LAURIER WILFRID LAURIER UNIVERSITY

David Wheatley

Zhenni Gu

Han Jiang

Tashfia Kawakib

Wasif Mukadam

Xiaoye Li

University of Manitoba

Mohammad N. Khan

Judith K. Darkey

Josee G. Lavoie**

BetterCart ANALYTICS

Melanie Morrison

Victor Phung

Nam Tram

UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO

Tracey Galloway

ichr Institute for Circumpolar Health Research

Sophie Roher

Translation/interpretation

Lisa Ipeelie

Sabrina Maniapik

Aimo Amelie Akulukjuk

Advisory committee members over the lifetime of the project

Jeneca Fanjoy, Qupanuaq

Opal McInnis, Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated

Ekua Agyemang, Department of Health, Government of Nunavut

Amber Aglukark, Department of Education, Government of Nunavut

Arielle Stockdale,* Department of Education, Government of Nunavut

Taya Tootoo,* Arctic Children and Youth Foundation

Rachel Blais,* Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre

Jesse Mike,** Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated

Karen Beddard,** Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated

Emesong Njabnjem,** South Baffin Child and Family Services

Adam Arreak Lightstone,** Legislative Assembly of Nunavut

* Participated through first phase of data collection and analysis

** Participated during design phase

Funders: Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated, Social Sciences & Humanities Research Council, Arctic Children & Youth Foundation, University of Colorado (Boulder)

Sinha, V., Li, N., Hoang, N., Morgan, R., Reddy, D., Darkey, J.K., Mitchell, K., Gilbert, S.Z., Wheatley, D., Govindapillai, S., Roher, S., Khan, M.N., Galloway, T. (2026) Strengthening Food Access in Nunavut: Lessons from the Inuit Child First Initiative funded Grocery Supports and the Hamlet Food Voucher Program. Qupanuaq. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p9eseau

Report design by Loop: Design for Social Good

Contents

Inuit Parents Speak
Hunger, Caring for Each Other, and Making Ends Meet **1**

Executive Summary **7**

Inuit Parents Speak
Hunger, Caring for Each Other, and Making Ends Meet **14**

About this Report
Project, Data, and Key Limitations **17**

- Data 19
- Key limitations 19

Inuit Parents Speak
Hunger, Caring for Each Other, and Making Ends Meet **21**

Food Insecurity in Nunavut
Withered Leaves, Physical and Psychological Harm **25**

- Individual budget stretching strategies 32
- Collective strategies – caring for each other to make ends meet 34
- Collective strategies – sharing country food 36
- Accessing formal supports 38
- Calculated hunger 39

Stem and Root Causes of Food Insecurity
Colonial Impacts and Structural Inequities **40**

- Colonial impacts on Inuit life 41
- Infrastructure gaps and the high cost of living 41

Strengthening Stems
Increasing Food Access Through ICFI Food Supports **51**

- The Inuit Child First Initiative 52
- National ICFI timeline 53
- From Individual requests to the Hamlet Food Voucher (HFV) and back again 57

Growing Leaves and Berries
Positive Impacts of the HFV **63**

Reduced hunger 65
Increased nutrition 68
Improved physical health 70
Improved mental health and quality of life 72
Greater resources for other things 75

Keeping Stems Strong
Understanding the Economic Impacts of the HFV **77**

Grocery price inflation 78
"Displacing" Income Assistance 87

Keeping Stems Strong
Learning from the ICFI Approach to Food Supports **91**

A temporary, discretionary structure 93
HFV design considerations 94
HFV implementation challenges 101

Sustaining Strong Stems While Feeding Firm Roots
Future Directions **105**

Immediate possibilities – policy options 107
Interview participants recommendations 113
Addressing structural inequity and supporting food sovereignty 113

Appendix 1
The Difference in Food Prices in Qikiqtaaluk and Canada by Community and NNC Category **116**

Appendix 2
Possible Mechanisms for Increasing Food Access **117**

References **122**



Inuit Parents Speak

Hunger, Caring for Each Other, and Making Ends Meet

In October 2025 and January 2026, we interviewed 47 caregivers, parents and grandparents of Inuit children, in 3 Qikiqtaaluk hamlets, about daily food practices and Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI) funded supports. Interview participants were recruited through Facebook posts and word of mouth by community-based coordinators. They were a diverse group with children of different ages, different sources of income and resources (e.g., paid employment, additional activities that brought in income, income support and Canada Child Benefits, or having a hunter in the home) and households ranging from 4–16 people. Interviews were conducted in English or English and Inuktitut, with community coordinators acting as interpreters. We open this report with interview participants' words about food, hunger, caring for each other, and making ends meet in Qikiqtaaluk.

"We may only be a percentage of the entire Canadian population, but we are a people, and we matter. These are real struggles.

This is what happens.

Hear us out."

As Inuit, our rights are not yet equal to those of white people because we're still experiencing colonization. And what was put in place to suppress and change the native in the Inuit, some of it is still the same today...If Canada were a whole, you'd think that there wouldn't be no crazy shipping prices up here.
You would think that you would have the same amount of resources available up here.
We may only be a percentage of the entire Canadian population, but we are a people, and we matter. These are real struggles. This is what happens. Hear us out.

[When we don't have enough food,] I don't mind not going with a meal for a day, as long as my girls eat.

INTERVIEW 8, COMMUNITY 1

At the end of the month, we barely have food to eat. We eat less to make ends meet.

Life was great when we had that [Hamlet Food Voucher] funding. We used to have healthy food. My son would have snacks ... And I used to make broccoli salad once in a while, so we could eat that. I would also make macaroni salad ... Everything was perfect.

INTERVIEW 2, COMMUNITY 1

There are days when we don't have anything to eat, 2 to 3 days in a month.

If there's enough food, we'll invite someone for a meal.

INTERVIEW 11, COMMUNITY 2

Now, everybody, like all of us [even the kids], go without food, [for] most likely a couple days.

My late parents taught me to share with everybody who's in one place, even whoever's visiting ... even though if it's not enough for anybody ... So, I try and share with everybody who's at my place, like if we have enough food. But when it's not enough, it's like, my heart breaks.

INTERVIEW 7, COMMUNITY 3

Because if we have nothing to eat, we will just grab just a bite and that's it. At least we have coffee, tea and flour for bannock. I don't mind if I don't eat, at least [my son is] eating.

When I worked there [at a soup kitchen] ... I used to try and cook all by myself, clean all by myself, go shopping all by myself. ... [I] was heartbroken to see people going hungry.

INTERVIEW 10, COMMUNITY 2

I was trying to stretch the food where we could have at least lunch every day. But sometimes I would have to skip a lunch in order for [the children] to eat for a few days.

I usually try and have rice, vegetable and a meat in one. Just so they'll have at least three good foods in one.

INTERVIEW 4, COMMUNITY 1

[My kid and I go without food] two days a week.

This time around, what I applied for [through Inuit Child First Initiative/Jordan's Principle] is mostly ... groceries, diapers, and milk, and furniture and bedding is what I'm trying to apply for if it's acceptable. But they haven't notified me yet through my email and they're just waiting, and I'm waiting.

INTERVIEW 3, COMMUNITY 3

There are times when either my mom or my sister or me don't eat so that the kids can eat.

The first time I received [Inuit Child First Initiative/Jordan's Principle] funds ... my mom cried of happiness because she knew she was not going to be hungry during those few weeks when we were getting help.

INTERVIEW 9, COMMUNITY 1

[The grocery prices] never went down. And now, I'm basically struggling to keep food on the table.

My family's managing with the help of my family ... I have two sisters, my dad, they're willing to help me all the time.

INTERVIEW 1, COMMUNITY 1

It's embarrassing to look for food. Especially when we are hungry. It's hard. Especially when you don't have family to turn to. It's really hard.

When somebody comes to my place, if there's any [food] on the table, we share.

INTERVIEW 2, COMMUNITY 2

[We] don't always have food to eat, cause there's a lot of people in that house. [11 people in a 2-bedroom house]

We have heard before that the prices will go higher ... Our great-grandmother will tell us that the price, it will go higher in the future, to prepare us.

INTERVIEW 5, COMMUNITY 2

We haven't been getting enough to eat for a while now, since the program stopped, and it's been very hard. [We eat] smaller meals ... we miss a lot of meals.

[With the food vouchers] we bought much better food for our children ... Healthy food. Like vegetables and meats and healthy stuff ... and fruits. We were able to pay off our housing bills and a little bit of power bills.

INTERVIEW 14, COMMUNITY 2

We eat once a day.

[With the Hamlet Food Voucher program] we got to eat every day, I mean, more than once a day … I was so thankful … I was practicing the cinnamon roll and lemon pie and cookies and all that.

INTERVIEW 3, COMMUNITY 1

A week or like five days before my pay … it would get hard for me to feed my kids, so we usually go to my parents' to eat.

The fruits and vegetables … Strawberry, blueberry, banana, apple, orange. And frozen vegetables … and with [the Hamlet Food Voucher] I noticed so much of my kids eating healthy food, and it was like really good.

INTERVIEW 5, COMMUNITY 1

Sometimes I would leave myself out for the kids to get by. As long as the kids are eating, then I'm okay. If I'm drinking something at least, if the boys have something in their stomach at least. … I make sure I have coffee so that I don't get hungry.

I would have days where I feel like I have a little too much in my freezer or the cupboards, and I would end up gathering a little bit and ask somebody who is in need to pick it up. But, of course, I have my days where I struggle too.

INTERVIEW 14, COMMUNITY 1

We eat a bit less food. I thawed out four pork chops for five of us, and we're going to cut them into cubes, make them try to look bigger.

I stopped buying meat from here. They're so expensive. One time, there was this little ground beef, and it costed $11.99 … After that, I did a little bit of research where to order. This is insane. I can't afford this.

INTERVIEW 9, COMMUNITY 2

It stresses me out sometimes when they [the kids] go hungry and I can't do anything except wait until payday.

It would help a lot if there's a soup kitchen, like in Iqaluit. For the ones that don't have food to eat, they can go to a soup kitchen. That would help a lot.

INTERVIEW 1, COMMUNITY 2

Where Jordan's Principle was a real bonus to us... was because of the food prices that we felt we had enough support to at least go for a number of days, if not the week, to ... feed [our son] during mealtimes.

So, when we first started taking him [our disabled child] down south ... [we saw that] everything is set down there. You have the paved roads, streets, and whatever, and then you have the ramps, elevators, and whatnot. You come back up, and it's like, 'Okay, what do we do?' Those things are not available.

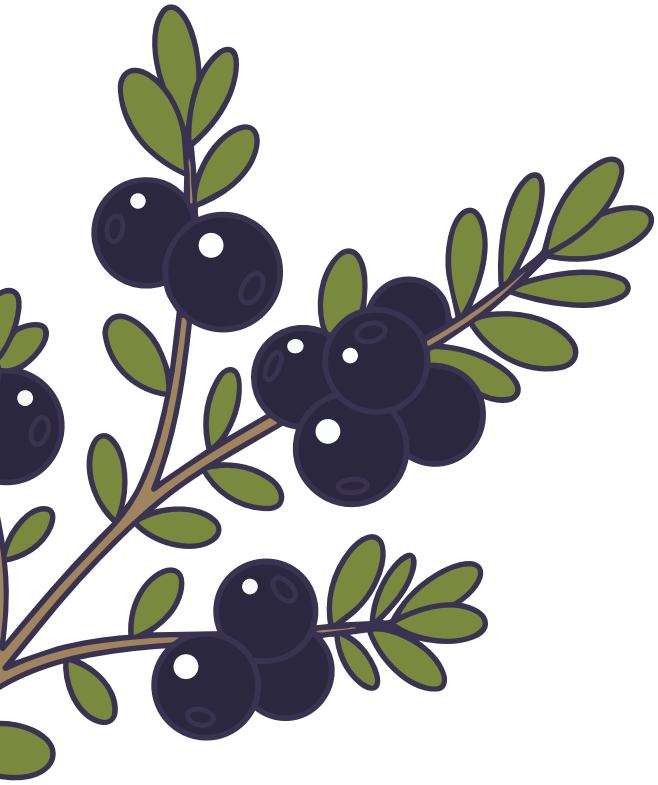
INTERVIEW 15, COMMUNITY 2

[We are falling short] every month, at least a couple of days. We always try to buy food enough for the week, because I get paid, and then the week after, my husband gets paid. Even still, there's at least one day where we only live on bread and milk.

We have a big family. So, there's always people at our place, or we always invite other people, like mainly our siblings. ... But then if I see someone's struggling or going hungry, that's when I always buy extra and gift them, gift to other people...And so I think [community name] is a very close-knit, caring community. People are always watching out for others.

INTERVIEW 17, COMMUNITY 2

Executive Summary



This is the final report from a project that brought together researchers who study and think about community well-being in very different ways to better understand the current state of food insecurity[a] in Nunavut. The project started as an evaluation of individual Grocery Supports. These were funds to buy groceries provided by the federal Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI) — also locally known as Jordan's Principle (the parallel program for First Nations children) — to some Inuit families starting in 2020–2021. The study evolved when, in 2023 and 2024, the ICFI approach to food supports shifted to Hamlet Food Voucher (HFV) programs, which provided the families of all Inuit children in a hamlet with monthly support to purchase food. The study continued after March of 2025, when the federal government ended funding for the HFV program and narrowed the eligibility criteria for Grocery Supports; very few families have since been approved for individual Grocery Supports.

[a] Food security/insecurity is sometimes characterized in terms of the 5As: availability, accessibility, (nutritional) adequacy, acceptability, and agency (the ability for people to make choices about what they eat). *The Inuit Nunangat Food Security Strategy* (Inuit Tapiirit Kanatami, 2021) states that "food security exists when all people, at all times, have physical and economic access to sufficient, safe and nutritious food to meet their dietary needs and food preferences for an active and healthy life."

In this report, we document the state of food insecurity and the impact of ICFI-funded food supports for families in Nunavut. Existing research demonstrates that nearly 8 out of 10 Inuit children were food insecure before the start of the HFV, that food insecurity is linked to serious physical and psychological harm and that food insecurity in Nunavut is driven by deep structural inequities. The HFV provided temporary relief. Our research suggests that it reduced hunger and increased nutrition, contributed to improved physical and mental health, and improved quality of life. We find that it did this without substantially increasing grocery prices – the primary driver of recent grocery price inflation is increased freight costs. In addition, the HFV does not seem to have shifted pre-existing trends in Income Assistance use.

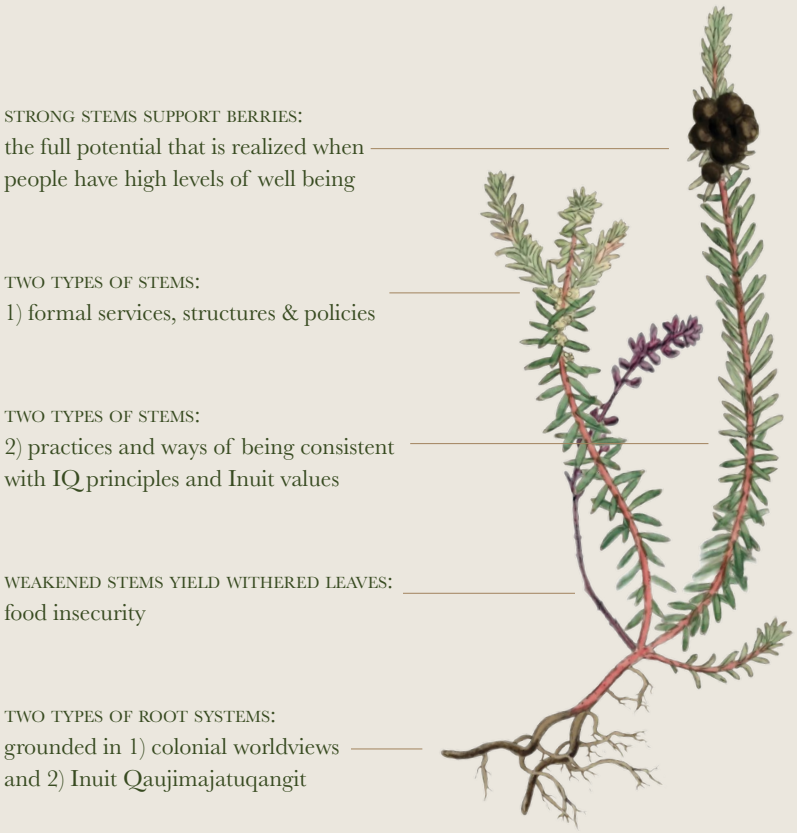
After the end of the HFV, no new policies or programs have similarly narrowed the gap between income and the high cost of living in Nunavut. Our research shows that Inuit families are drawing on their individual and collective strengths, and a sophisticated range of budget-stretching strategies, to try to ensure access to food with dignity for everyone in the community. However, in a context shaped by a high cost of living, limited employment opportunities and (recent) steep increases in grocery prices, this is not enough. The Inuit families we interviewed also had to plan for hunger: regularly eating less or going without food.

Long-term, comprehensive measures to remedy the structural inequities that drive food insecurity in the region will take time, creativity and collaboration across governments and governance bodies. However, the hunger of Inuit in Nunavut is urgent. Immediate and sustained measures to increase food access are needed. We close this report with an analysis of policies that might be used to increase access to food while the long-term, comprehensive work to eliminate structural inequities and support food sovereignty[b] in Nunavut is ongoing.

We present the findings of our study in eight chapters:

In Chapter 1, we draw on existing research and interviews conducted with 47 Inuit caregivers after the end of the HFV program to describe **Food Insecurity in Nunavut: Withered Leaves, Lasting Harm**. We find that Inuit in Nunavut face an urgent food security crisis. Existing survey data show that 7 in 10 Inuit children in the territory live in households that make sacrifices — skipping meals, eating less, and/or eating lower-quality food — to make ends meet. Food insecurity surveys usually ask about events during the year, but families in Nunavut faced much more consistent challenges: 8 out of 10 families we interviewed faced daily, weekly or monthly struggles to make ends meet. At the end of this chapter, we summarize existing research on the serious, and sometimes lasting, physical and psychological harm of food insecurity for children, youth and adults.

[b] Food sovereignty extends beyond food security to focus on who has control over the food system and centre community-based economies that ensure the availability of and access to foods that are both healthy and culturally valued.



Throughout this report, we use the image of berry plants to illustrate the context of food insecurity in Nunavut. We think of this context as being rooted in two worldviews that give rise co-existing and intertwined systems: a colonial system that is relatively new to the region and an older system grounded in Inuit Qaujimajatuqangit (IQ) or traditional knowledge.[c]

The stems of the plant with colonial roots are formal services, structures, and policies. The stems that grow from IQ roots are practices and ways of being that are consistent with IQ principles and Inuit values. In both systems, strong stems are needed to support the development of fruit, or situations in which people have high levels of well-being and can reach their full potential.

[c] Tagalik, S. (2009) Inuit Qaujimajatuqangit: The role of Indigenous knowledge in supporting wellness in Inuit communities in Nunavut. National Collaborating Centre for Indigenous Health. https://www.ccnsa-nccih.ca/docs/health/FS-InuitQaujimajatuqangitWellnessNunavut-Tagalik-EN.pdf

The withered leaves of food insecurity are an outcome of weakened stems in either system.

Discussion of Inuit strengths is woven throughout this report, in the quotations that are featured throughout and highlighted in Chapter 2, where we discuss the many ways in which Inuit, individually and collectively, work to support each other and make ends meet. However, because our goal was to study ICFI funded supports that increased access to food in the retail market, we focus primarily on the system with colonial roots.

Some members of our research team use the term *structural violence* to describe food insecurity in the context of this system. *Structural violence* is physical and psychological harm resulting from inequities so profound that they keep Inuit in Nunavut from "having the resources necessary to help them reach their full potential while sparing other groups the same treatment."[d] We establish the basis for viewing food insecurity as structural violence in the early chapters of this report. In Chapter 1, we summarize a large body of literature that documents the severe and long-term physical and psychological harm associated with food insecurity. In Chapter 3, we outline a number of interlocking structural inequities that give rise to food insecurity. People writing about structural violence stress the "invisibility" of structural inequities, noting that we tend to accept them as normal and just "the way things are."[e] In using the visual of a berry plant and the language of "structural violence," we hope to disrupt that tendency for readers of this report.

[d] Gerlach, A. J., Browne, A. J., Sinha, V., & Elliott, D. (2017). Navigating Structural Violence with Indigenous Families: The Contested Terrain of Early Childhood Intervention and the Child Welfare System in Canada. International Indigenous Policy Journal, 8(3), 1–23. https://www.jstor.org/stable/48767257

[e] Farmer, P. E., Kim, Y. J., Kleinman, A., & Basilico, M. (2013). Introduction: A biosocial approach to global health. In P. E. Farmer, Y. J. Kim, A. Kleinman, & M. Basilico (Eds.), Reimagining global health: An introduction (pp. 1–14). Berkeley and Los Angeles, CA: University of California Press. doi: https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137335432 1

In Chapter 2, we use the same interviews to describe the ways that families and communities are **Drawing on Strong Roots to Make Ends Meet**. Inuit parents and grandparents who we interviewed shared a sophisticated set of individual and collective strategies that they used to care for each other and make ends meet. They were cutting expenses, finding ways to make extra money, accessing the limited formal supports available and carefully budgeting, shopping and cooking. Community members also drew on their collective strengths; they supported each other by sharing country food, meals and other resources. They made these efforts even as they struggled to feed their own households and worried about the burden they placed on each other. Still, the people we interviewed had no choice but to plan for hunger: skipping meals or spending days without food were part of the calculated strategies they used to make ends meet in their daily, weekly, and monthly lives.

In Chapter 3, we draw on existing research and analyses of food prices to explore the **Stem and Root Causes of Food Insecurity: Colonial Impacts and Structural Inequities**. These structural inequities include: a housing crisis, limited employment opportunities and severe deficits in infrastructure across multiple domains. They also include deep inequities in the existing structures of Nunavut food systems, including reliance on Southern-based, for-profit entities (manufacturers, retailers and freight carriers) and federal subsidies that do not fully offset the rising costs of shipping food to Nunavut. Retail food prices are approximately twice as high as in Canada as a whole and have grown faster than in the rest of Canada in the last decade. These structural inequities mean that many Inuit families do not have incomes high enough to cover the cost of living in the region. Government supports are insufficient to bridge the gap between incomes and the cost of living: the maximum welfare benefits available to a family of four in Nunavut are equal to only 42% of the official poverty line, which is sometimes described as a 'basic, modest' standard of living.

In Chapter 4, we draw on key informant interviews and a review of government documents to describe **Strengthening Stems: Increasing Food Access Through ICFI-Funded Food Supports**. The ICFI is intended to ensure Inuit children do not face gaps, delays or denials in accessing government services because of their Inuk identity. Initially, ICFI-funded Grocery Supports were provided to individual families who had to submit personalized documentation for review. By 2023, there was a large backlog and long delays in response to requests for Grocery supports. As a result, hamlets began to apply for funding for food voucher programs, which provided food supports for all Inuit children and youth in a community. By the end of 2024, these programs reached Inuit children in 24 of 25 communities, for an estimated annual cost of just under $100 million. They operated without complex or time-consuming application processes and allowed families to use the funds in ways that complemented

their other budget-stretching strategies. The federal government suspended funding for the food voucher programs in March of 2025. After that, very few requests for individual Grocery Supports have been approved. The treatment of ICFI-funded Grocery Supports requests does not appear to meet the legal standards, for responding to urgent cases, that have been established for services to First Nations children through Jordan's Principle, the southern parallel to ICFI.

In Chapter 5, we draw on interviews with caregivers and key informants, existing research and analysis of anonymized data on health outcomes, school attendance and purchases made with ICFI-funded Grocery Supports to present our findings on **Growing Leaves and Berries: The Impacts of the HFV Program**. ICFI-funded food supports were designed to increase access to food without addressing the underlying structural inequities that give rise to food insecurity in Nunavut. Our findings suggest that the HFV accomplished this goal. It appears to have disrupted several physical and psychological harms of food insecurity by reducing hunger, increasing nutrition, improving physical health, improving quality of life and giving both families and communities greater resources to devote to needs that extended beyond nutrition. Analysis of available quantitative data suggests that there was a steady decline in the demand for meals at the Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre in Iqaluit after the HFV began; this trend reversed after the HFV ended. Further, the HFV increased purchases of Nutrition North Canada (NNC)-eligible healthy foods and baby supplies. Data from hemoglobin tests conducted in Qikiqtaaluk suggest that children aged 24–59 months had lower hemoglobin levels and were more likely to have anemia after the HFV ended than during the HFV program. Qualitative findings support the quantitative results and extend them further: in addition to experiencing less hunger and eating more nutritious foods, interview participants indicated they felt happier, less stressed and more able to attend to other (non-food related) needs and interests with the HFV in place.

In Chapter 6, we summarize our findings on **Keeping Stems Strong: Understanding the Economic Impacts of the HFV**. We examine the impact of the HFV on grocery prices and find that the program had little, if any, role in driving grocery price increases (inflation). Grocery prices rose markedly between 2022 and 2024, but most of this increase occurred before the first HFV was adopted and was driven by a combination of rising food prices in the South and the rising cost of shipping freight to Nunavut. In addition, communities that adopted the HFV early did not experience much larger price increases than communities that had not yet adopted the HFV. We also examined federal concerns that the HFV would 'displace,' or function as an alternative to, targeted programs like Income Assistance. We found that the HFV had no significant effect on Income Assistance: use has been rising steadily since COVID-era benefits ended and there was no change in this trend with the implementation of the HFV.

In Chapter 7, we present our analysis of **Keeping Stems Strong: Learning from Tensions and Challenges in ICFI-funded Food Supports**. We examine tensions in the national-level ICFI approach to meeting children's needs, the territorial-level design of the HFV program, and the local (hamlet level) implementation of the program. We highlight key considerations in the structure of programs and services that should be considered in designing future efforts to increase access to food. At the national level, we examine the ways that a temporary and discretionary approach to ICFI funding laid the foundation for ongoing shifts in the administration of individual Grocery Supports and for the termination of the HFV. At the territorial level, we explore tensions around the universality, progressivity, flexibility, and sufficiency of HFV benefits, establishing these as factors that should be considered in future efforts to increase food access. Finally, at the local level, we highlight the ways that HFV coordinators innovated and experimented as they sought to keep the shelves stocked, help families stretch their funds across the month, manage assignment and reassignment of families to grocery stores and enforce local rules around purchases of healthy foods.

In Chapter 8, we turn our attention to **Sustaining Strong Stems while Feeding Firm Roots: Future Directions**. We build on our analysis in the rest of the report to examine possible mechanisms for immediately increasing food access, while Inuit-led, long-term measures to eliminate structural inequities and support food sovereignty are being put in place. We compare the relative strengths and weaknesses of existing programs as mechanisms for quickly and broadly increasing food access. Our analysis does not suggest that any one mechanism is sufficient or clearly superior to the others when it comes to increasing food access for Inuit in Nunavut. Rather, it highlights the possibilities for a comprehensive approach that combines different policy options. Following this analysis, which has a strong focus on programs that could help close the critical gap between income and cost of living in Nunavut, we present interview participants' recommendations on a broader range of services and supports they see as needed. We close this report by reminding readers of a key limitation of this report: our focus is largely on increasing retail food access, and these options should be seen only as important complements to the longer-term, comprehensive work needed to eliminate structural inequities and support food sovereignty.

Inuit Parents Speak

Hunger, Caring for Each Other, and Making Ends Meet

My husband's part-time ... his payday is in two days ... I don't have enough meat to last until Friday. I have enough rice ... I don't have potatoes now. Vegetables, we have to eat the same kind of vegetables for the next three days because we have only one more bag.

A lot of the community members eat country food. One seal is a bit hard to share amongst a big family like we have.

INTERVIEW 11, COMMUNITY 1

There will be times where I have to sacrifice my meal so my children can eat instead.

We do as much as we can to support each other when it comes to food. My cousin, he's not really working, but he does make income through hunting ... we also get our food through his trips ... He usually tries to find where he can sell his catch. Sometimes Hamlet is looking. Sometimes Hunters and Trappers are looking. Sometimes he goes out for the heck of it just to feed some of the other community members.

INTERVIEW 13, COMMUNITY 1

I started making one less meal a day to make it last longer. And also, I don't make food until my kids are hungry.

When there's food, everybody eats ... No matter how big or small the portion is, you serve everyone ... That's what I learned from my grandma anyway.

INTERVIEW 7, COMMUNITY 1

A few days before payday, we will have bannock. That's pretty much it.

I'm pretty sure the stores won't be lowering their prices anytime soon. Right? ... There's families with more than one child that definitely need help. Because I have one child, and it's hard.

INTERVIEW 13, COMMUNITY 1

It's hard trying to keep up with the food and seeing my kids eating the same thing for a week [that] they don't feel like eating.

My parents are out for work. My sister and her husband are out on medical travel. So, I'm kind of taking care of my nieces and nephews.

INTERVIEW 10, COMMUNITY 1

A few days [in the month, we run out of food] ... I try to save as much ... spend less.

I used to get income support, but then my boyfriend started working, so that went out. [Compared to income support, his pay is] less because he's a casual worker. They only let him work when they need help.

INTERVIEW 3, COMMUNITY 2

Sometimes, every month [it's difficult to have food for everyone in the household].

It [the HFV] was helping so much. I was getting daily nutrition like fruits and yogurt, milk and grains, whole wheat grains, and it was helping out so much. So, I hope this keeps going to help families who are struggling.

INTERVIEW 11, COMMUNITY 3

With the two adults, [there's] not much with the food insecurity. But with the younger three, [we're] always trying to have some store-bought food, fast food, because they didn't want to eat their country food.

Frozen chickens are over $20, $26 or $25. I usually buy one pack, there's four chicken legs or three in there, in one. And ground beef, they're over 10 bucks now at Co-op. I usually buy two of them. And yeah, they're expensive.

INTERVIEW 4, COMMUNITY 2

[When there's] not enough food at home, well, sometimes, I was thinking to go to the dump looking for food.

We help each other. ...They help us and we help them too...And they [children] love to go to school when they eat healthy food.

INTERVIEW 8, COMMUNITY 2

I would give them [the kids] once a day meal because the food prices are too high.

Sometimes we would go out for a week out on the land. We would go netting sometimes. We would dry some fish or share some fish to the community ... On the cold winter days, sometimes my partner would go netting far away.

INTERVIEW 3, COMMUNITY 3

We have enough food for the week, and then I save half of my pay for the next week. I try and maintain the food for the whole two weeks ... But sometimes we run out just before payday.

When I lost my grandmother, I turned to alcohol ... My father-in-law told me, 'There are better things to do. You can do this. You can sew.' ... I do mitts and parkas.

INTERVIEW 6, COMMUNITY 3

About this Report

Project, Data, and Key Limitations

This is the final report from a study that started as an evaluation of individual requests for Grocery Supports provided through the Inuit Child First Initiative and evolved as the HFV program was implemented and discontinued. The multidisciplinary, mixed-methods study was initiated by Qupanuaq and funded by Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated (NTI), the Arctic Children and Youth Foundation, and the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council, with additional support from the University of Colorado School of Education. It brought together researchers from Qupanuaq, the University of Colorado (Boulder), Toronto Metropolitan University, Wilfrid Laurier University, Harvard University, the University of Manitoba, the Institute for Circumpolar Health Research, the University of Toronto, and BetterCart Analytics. The study was guided by a Nunavut advisory committee composed of representatives of regional/territorial organizations and departments concerned with child food security. On average, the advisory committee met every 4–6 weeks throughout the full project cycle from study design to completion of this report.

FIGURE 1

Map of the Qikiqtaaluk region



This report focuses on food insecurity in the Qikiqtaaluk (also known as Qikiqtani or Baffin) region of Nunavut. Nunavut is one of four Inuit regions in Canada, collectively referred to as Inuit Nunangat. It is the newest territory in Canada, created in 1999. Nunavut has a settled land claims agreement, which created the Government of Nunavut and the Inuit land claims organization, Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated.

Qikiqtaaluk includes the eastern parts of Nunavut and consists of 13 communities, more than half of Nunavut's 25 communities, including the capital city of the territory, Iqaluit. Approximately 14,000 Inuit lived in the region in 2021.[1] Access to food in Nunavut is shaped by Inuit culture and tradition and by past *and* ongoing colonial practices and policies.

Data

In this report, we present results from the analysis of:

- 21 key informant interviews conducted while the HFV program was operating, with people living/working in seven hamlets or working at the regional level (Qikiqtaaluk or Nunavut) and 5 additional interviews conducted after the end of the HFV program. Key informants included: service coordinators (who help families access ICFI-funded supports), service providers (such as health professionals or community workers), HFV coordinators, grocery store managers/employees, and Indigenous Services Canada (ISC) regional staff.
- 47 interviews with parents and grandparents of children who received food vouchers in 3 Qikiqtaaluk communities. These interviews were conducted after the end of the HFV programs and reflect conditions with School Food Program funded and in implementation stage and NNC subsidies and other programs/supports stably implemented for many years.
- Anonymized data on the purchases made between the beginning of 2022 and the end of 2024 by Qikiqtaaluk families receiving individual, ICFI-funded Grocery Supports and matched prices of Southern products during this period, which were provided by BetterCart Analytics.
- Data on community-level Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB) prices, shipments of NNC subsidies and subsidized foods from Nutrition North Canada from 2021 to 2025, Southern food prices (from Statistics Canada), freight prices, and corporate finances and profits (from annual reports).
- Anonymized data on health outcomes (HemoCue and anemia), school attendance, and Income Assistance use before, during and after the HFV.
- Existing literature, available government documents and media reports related to food security and the ICFI in Nunavut.

Key limitations

- The ICFI approach to food supports shifted rapidly during the study period. We worked to adapt and expand the study design to keep up with the changes in policy and the impacts for Inuit families in Nunavut. However, the changing context meant that we were not able to examine any single stage of ICFI-funded food supports in as much detail as we hoped. For example, we supplemented key informant interviews conducted during the HFV programs with additional interviews after the program ended, but we were not able to conduct key informant interviews before the HFV programs started. Similarly, we asked the caregivers we interviewed about their experiences during the HFV, but we were only able to interview them after the program ended.
- We worked within the limits of available quantitative data. Our price analyses depended on the products, communities, time periods and comparison baskets

available in each dataset. Our analysis of attendance data may have been affected by gaps for summer and other school breaks, missing data, and unmeasured factors such as illness, weather, and school or community events. Our analysis of Income Assistance use was based on trends in aggregate, community-level data, so we were not able to assess which households receiving Income Assistance also received HFV supports. Finally, our anemia analysis encompassed only those children who were tested, meaning our results must not be interpreted as population-level anemia prevalence. This limitation informed our narrowed focus on 1–4 year olds; their high rates of early child screenings that help reduce the risk of bias.

- Whenever possible, we took advantage of the staggered adoption of the HFV to examine changes that occurred after the adoption of HFV in each community and compare communities that had adopted the HFV to those that had not yet adopted it. However, we were unable to systematically distinguish between the effects of the HFV and other, concurrent programs that may have increased food access, such as individual Grocery Supports or school food programs.
- In the closing chapter of this report, we consider policies that could immediately increase food access. We were not able to offer a comprehensive analysis of policy options. Rather, we summarized our collective understanding, based on possibilities that emerged during our study of ICFI-funded food supports. Because we started with a focus on the HFV, which sought to increase retail food access and narrow the critical gap between income and the cost of living, we did not consider the equally important programs which attempt to address food insecurity by increasing access to country food.

In this report, we present a high-level overview of our findings from these multiple types of analyses. You can find an overview of the research design and methods here.[f] Throughout the report, you will find hyperlinks that take you to information sheets providing more detailed, technical information on key topics. You can find the full set of information sheets, as well as other reports and publications related to this project here.[g]

[f] https://icfi-evaluation.ca/4x6pmyxz

[g] https://icfi-evaluation.ca/yc7bfdr8

Inuit Parents Speak

Hunger, Caring for Each Other, and Making Ends Meet

I always have food on the table.

I try to have healthy foods, vegetables, and fruits... at times we don't really take much food, but the thing is that it gets kind of hard [to afford] the cleaning supplies.

INTERVIEW 13, COMMUNITY 2

When I started receiving JP [Jordan's Principle], I used it with food. And when it's payday time, we got caught up with our bills ... [Now] we get behind again.

I prefer country food than store-bought ... Caribou, muktuk, ptarmigan, fish.

INTERVIEW 4, COMMUNITY 3

We eat one time a day because we're broke.

We're not really eating anymore ever since Jordan's Principle's gone, because everything's expensive and I only get like $900 child tax for four kids.

INTERVIEW 15, COMMUNITY 3

Too regularly, every week, [we] tell the older kids not to eat ... so that the little ones have food.

We used to have [a community freezer] when I was growing up. And we used to go in there and just take what we need for the family, when I was younger.

INTERVIEW 2, COMMUNITY 3

Sometimes I don't eat along with my kids.

I'm saving up my paycheck down [to get a snow machine] ... [save] at least half of it, and half of it goes to groceries or house rent ... I have no choice, because we eat country food too.

INTERVIEW 9, COMMUNITY 3

[We don't have enough food about] twice in a month, for at least a week.

Overthink, overthink the night before: What's for lunch tomorrow? How am I going to stretch my dollar? What should I buy in order to stretch my money? ... It's sometimes even stressful trying to get to the store, knowing that my ... the grocery bill is going to go all the way up.

INTERVIEW 14, COMMUNITY 2

Sometimes, if it's just enough for my kids, me and my spouse don't eat a day. He would sometimes go to work without eating a day or two because it was only enough for our kids and he still managed to go to work in hopes of making more hours and seeing the pay they said he would see, right?

I love caribou. I love clams. I can't ... I have no favourite because I love them all equally. I can eat them every day. If I were to be able to live off them, I would definitely.

INTERVIEW 1, COMMUNITY 3

Sometimes I have not enough [food] for until the end of the week because the prices are getting higher ... I don't know what to buy for 40 bucks. If I want to buy Pampers or food, which one should I buy?

I used to work at the Northern Store. But it's hard for me right now ... [I'm] worried about my kids. If I'm not here, what if I'm out long? What if there's something happening there? Because my youngest always climbs up to [the] kitchen table and chairs.

INTERVIEW 5, COMMUNITY 3

Sometimes it goes like, few days before our income, we're completely out of food, and I encourage [the children to go to] whoever is welcoming them for food or whatever, and as much as they offer, just take them.

I want my door open for my nieces and nephews, and most of the week, they're pretty much hanging out too.

INTERVIEW 6, COMMUNITY 1

[It's] hard, especially when you don't have enough food and when my other grandchildren, who don't live with us, come and eat. But we still manage to feed them, which I'm happy about.

We have country food in the house most of the time. But [the children/grandchildren] they're not crazy about country food anymore.

INTERVIEW 10, COMMUNITY 3

[We're] eating less.

If I couldn't [sell crochet work], I bet we would all be starving. We would always be mad at each other for not getting the food you're supposed to be eating.

INTERVIEW 6, COMMUNITY 2

[When we don't have enough food, I am] not eating at all. It's sometimes, I just puke whatever I try and have. If I didn't eat for a couple days, I finally tried eating, I'm just gonna stop middle of the meal, or if we just started eating, I'll just stop and go to the washroom and just sit there and think until everybody is done eating. I'm used to it.

I used to buy pizza all the time because my kids love pizza. But now I can't because they're sky-high, and it used to be the cheapest to buy.

INTERVIEW 8, COMMUNITY 3

When I notice if we're not going to have enough food, since we're keeping my niece through foster care, I get hold of family services to get help. And that happens, like at least once a month or twice a month.

My son, since he was born, he has so many issues with his health. He always had to leave for follow-ups, medical follow-ups ... he's less traveling because he knows about his health now.

INTERVIEW 13, COMMUNITY 3

Every week [we don't have enough food] ... We ask from our family and get a little and [the kids] eat.

I actually do sewing, and sell my crafts ... [I make] wall hangings.

INTERVIEW 16, COMMUNITY 2

We eat less ... to save the food on the shelf.

Those little spare rib ones are like $60 or something. Now, if I get that, I'm going to have to try and think about the set aside like rice and vegetables, to get on the side. But then I wouldn't afford it if I had that spareribs.

INTERVIEW 7, COMMUNITY 2

Food Insecurity in Nunavut

Withered Leaves, Physical and Psychological Harm

In this chapter, we draw on existing research and interviews with Inuit caregivers to describe the level and impact of food insecurity in Nunavut today.

7 in 10 Inuit children in the territory live in households where people skip meals, eat less, and/or eat lower-quality food to make ends meet; an additional 1 in 10 Inuit children live in households that worry about running out of food.[2]

8 out of 10 families we interviewed faced daily, weekly, and monthly struggles to make ends meet. Half of them experienced monthly food shortages, typically in the days before a paycheck or government benefits came in, while the other half faced shortages on a weekly or daily basis.

Existing research suggests that chronic food insecurity has harmful, long-lasting impacts on children, youth, and adults, including effects on physical health, mental health, and development.

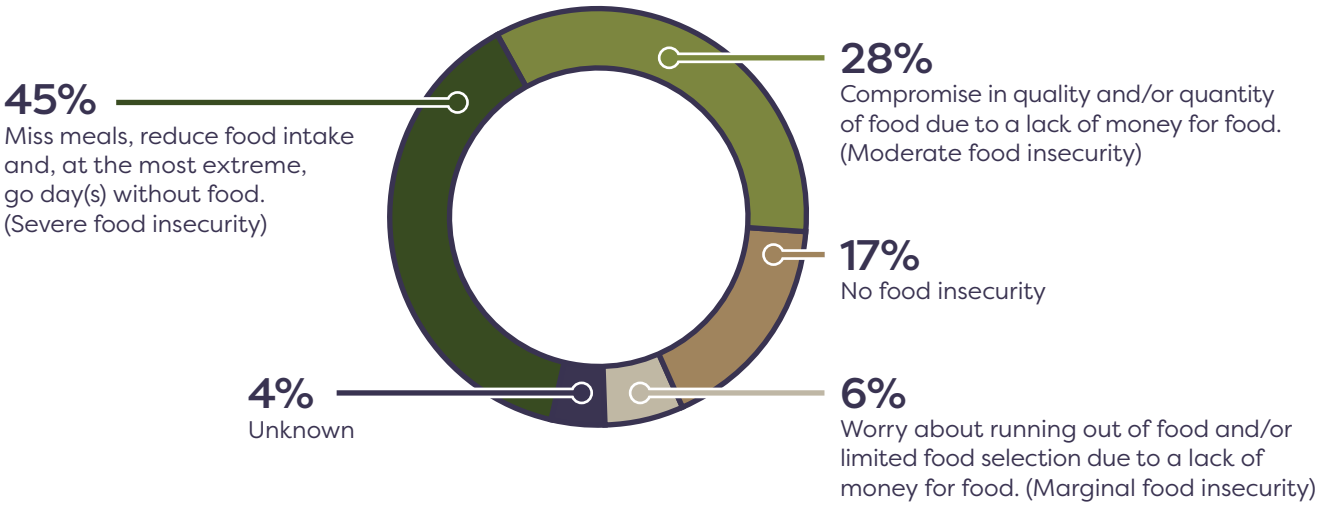
Thus, Inuit in Nunavut face an urgent food security crisis.

As shown in Figure 2, the 2022 Indigenous People's survey found that almost 8 in 10 Inuit, under age 15, in Nunavut (79%) lived in food insecure households: 7 in 10 (73%) lived in households where people skipped meals, ate less, and/or ate lower-quality food to make ends meet (severely or moderately food insecure). In comparison, 6 in 10 Inuit children in the Northwest territories and fewer than 4 in 10 Indigenous children in the Yukon[h] were food insecure.[3] Similarly, the 2023 Canadian Income Survey reported that 58.1% of households in Nunavut were food insecure, more than double the national rate of 25.5% of households.[4]

FIGURE 2

Most Inuit children in Nunavut live in food insecure households

Food security status of Inuit children, age 1–14, in Nunavut



Statistics Canada. (2024). *Food security status of First Nations people living off reserve, Métis and Inuit by age group*. https://doi.org/10.25318/4110006301-eng

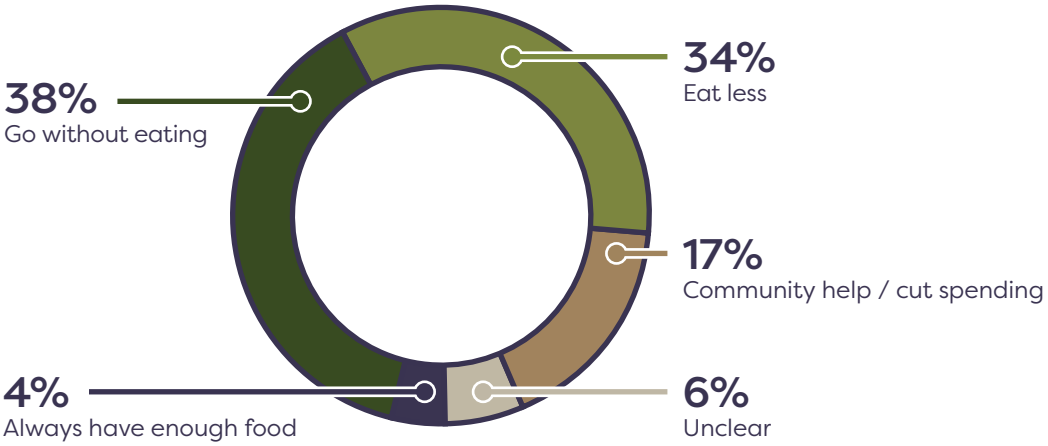
Smaller-scale studies report even higher levels of food insecurity than national surveys. For example, a recent study in Qikiqtarjuaq found that none of the respondents were food secure, and two-thirds were severely food insecure.[5] Nearly 9 in 10 households surveyed in Pangnirtung said that, before the HFV program, their children did not have enough to eat due to lack of money; 4 in 10 said this happened *every month*.[6]

> "We eat better in the springtime because we don't just eat store-bought food. We start eating country food."
>
> **INTERVIEW 11**

[h] Data for Inuit children only were deemed to unreliable to be published by Statistics Canada.

FIGURE 3

Most families we interviewed experienced food insecurity



In our study, we did not use a food security survey instrument; instead, we asked participants whether they had enough food for everyone in their households and how they were making ends meet. As summarized in Figure 3, only 2 of 47 participants (4%) reported their household always had enough food; 18 (38%) spoke of days when people in the home ate nothing, and 17 (34%) said they ate less (fewer or smaller meals) to make ends meet. An additional 17% relied on alternative strategies, including eating at relatives' homes, asking the community for food, limiting food variety (for example, only country food), or cutting essential non-food expenses. These strategies overlapped; many households combined multiple approaches to cope with food shortages.

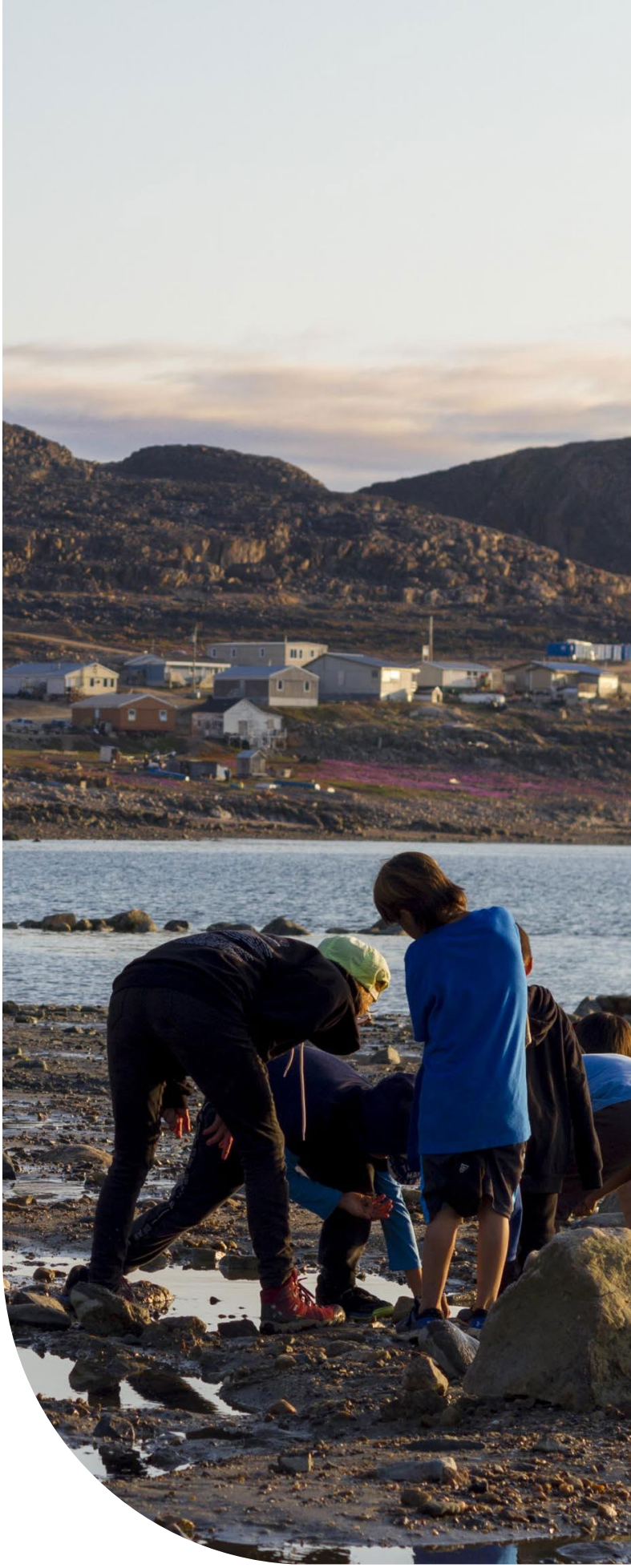
"We're struggling right now because my parents are out for work. My sister and her husband are out on medical travel. So, I'm ... taking care of my nieces and nephews. I'm trying to feed them and ... I'm trying to feed my family too."

INTERVIEW 10

Survey questions measuring food insecurity typically focus on the frequency of different events during the previous 12 months. In keeping with this time frame, interview participants talked about specific times of the year when it was more difficult to make ends meet. Many named the winter months as a difficult time because country food was less abundant; others noted December and

January were particularly hard because of the extra expense of Christmas gifts combined with reduced work hours. In addition, for some participants, the ability to feed their households was shaped by seasonal employment patterns or essential seasonal purchases, such as winter clothes or supplies to be on the land. Others described periods when it was more difficult to budget for food because family members struggled with addictions or they took on extra expenses associated with temporary care for children whose parents were away for work or medical travel.

However, most interview participants experienced frequent, ongoing food insecurity: 80% of interview participants said their households struggled every month. Forty percent spoke of struggles in the days before receiving their pay, Income Assistance, or Canada Child Benefit (CCB); an additional 40% struggled to feed everyone on a weekly or daily basis. Whether their primary income source was a paycheck, Income Assistance and CCB, or a combination of sources, interview participants said their income didn't stretch far enough. They spoke of difficulty making ends meet in the days before they received new income, and of having to wait until it came in to buy needed food. This echoes a recent study which found that total grocery sales, and sales of meat products in particular, increase across most of Nunavut on Government of Nunavut pay day and on Canada Child Benefit day.[7] As discussed in the next chapter of this report, families made great sacrifices to protect



children from hunger. Still, in the most severe cases, everyone in a household, including young children, regularly ate less than they needed or went entirely without meals.

Existing research suggests that the level of food insecurity in Nunavut has serious, negative impacts on physical and psychological health. As discussed in Chapter 3, the impacts of colonization and deep structural inequities mean that many households in Nunavut have limited access to nutrient-rich country foods and a deepening reliance on store-bought foods that are filling, but typically less nutritious.[8] In Qikiqtaaluk communities over the past decade, the decline in caribou and restrictions on caribou harvesting have raised concerns because caribou meat was a major source of important nutrients such as iron, zinc, vitamin B12, riboflavin, and protein.[9] One study estimated that the percentage of the Nunavut population with anemia would rise from 28.3% to 35.2% if caribou meat was no longer available.[10]

"[We are falling short] every month, at least a couple of days. We always try to buy food enough for the week, because I get paid, and then the week after, my husband gets paid. ... Even still, there's like, at least one day where we only live on bread and milk."

INTERVIEW 32

This is especially concerning for pregnant women, infants and children, for whom inadequate access to food and/or key nutrients can more quickly contribute to poor health outcomes. In young children, negative health effects can occur even before health professionals recognize symptoms of food insecurity, such as being underweight, and can continue even after treatment. Infants and toddlers are particularly vulnerable, partly because they are completely dependent on adult care-givers whose mental health, energy levels, and engagement can also be negatively affected by food insecurity.[11]

Recent research in Nunavut documents the links between food insecurity and multiple major public health challenges. One study found higher odds of rickets among children whose mothers experienced food insecurity during pregnancy.[12] Clinical guidance by the Government of Nunavut identifies iron deficiency, which is linked to food insecurity, in infants and young children as a prevalent yet preventable condition that may lead to irreversible developmental and cognitive challenges.[13] In addition, food insecurity is linked to the structural and environmental drivers of many of Nunavut's public health challenges, including tuberculosis and respiratory disease: tuberculosis disparities across Inuit Nunangat have been linked to overcrowded housing, food insecurity, poverty, barriers to health care and the ongoing impacts of colonization.[14] Lower respiratory

tract infections among Inuit infants in Nunavut have been reported to be among the highest in the world.[15]

> "I can tolerate hunger better than the rest of my family. If they've skipped a meal, everybody can tell from a mile away. And there will be also times where I have to sacrifice my meal so my children can eat instead."
>
> **INTERVIEW 38**

Studies using data from the Indigenous People's Survey find that, for low-income Indigenous people, there are strong associations between food insecurity and psychological distress, suicide ideation and suicide attempts. In addition, a longitudinal study of Inuit youth in Nunavik found that severe food insecurity was associated with greater levels of concurrent depression and withdrawn attitudes; persistent food insecurity (in childhood and adolescence) was associated with higher levels of adolescent depression and anxiety.[16]

Beyond that, systematic reviews and meta-analyses of existing research that do not focus on Indigenous people also document strong associations between food insecurity and negative outcomes for children, youth, and adults, including poorer general health, mental health (depression and stress), academic performance, and cognitive development. A growing body of research also links food insecurity to increased addictions, violence and mental health challenges for children and adults; some of these studies suggest that food insecurity during childhood results in poorer adult outcomes.[17]

Drawing on Strong Roots to Make Ends Meet



In this chapter, we draw on interviews with Inuit parents and grandparents in three Qikiqtaaluk hamlets. These interviews were conducted in October of 2025 and January of 2026, after the end of the HFV program. The National School Food Program was being implemented, and Nutrition North Canada (NNC) subsidies, and other programs aimed at increasing food access, had already been in place for many years.

The Inuit caregivers we interviewed shared a sophisticated set of individual and collective strategies they used to care for each other and make ends meet. They were cutting all but essential expenses, finding ways to make extra income and carefully budgeting, shopping and cooking to make scarce resources last.

Interview participants also drew on their collective strengths to support each other. They gave and received country food, meals and other resources, sharing within extended families and communities as they worked to feed their households.

Participants spoke about their commitment supporting each other and their awareness that the level of need in their communities strained collective resources, causing them to refrain from seeking or giving help.

Thus, despite their best efforts, interview participants had no choice but to plan for hunger: eating less, skipping meals, and going days without food are a regular part of their daily, weekly, and monthly lives.

Individual budget stretching strategies

Interview participants shared a comprehensive range of budget stretching strategies, highlighting the commitment, strengths and varied forms of expertise that they drew on to make ends meet. For some, the work to make ends meet started even before they had money in hand. They spoke of **carefully budgeting** to ensure they would not run out of food between paydays or the distribution of income support or child benefits. A key strategy involved staggering bill payments to allow for grocery purchases throughout the month. When that wasn't enough, some let bills go unpaid to prioritize food, taking on debt when needed.

> "I try and compare what I buy and see which one's cheaper."
>
> **INTERVIEW 42**

Their budget stretching efforts continued **during grocery shopping**. Interview participants spoke of actively comparing prices at the Co-op and Northern, buying no-name brands, ordering from online retailers when that was possible and choosing less nutritious but inexpensive items, like noodles, to fill their stomachs. When they could afford it, they also purchased meat and other food in bulk to save money. Some also intentionally shopped without their children to avoid impulse purchases of non-essential items.

> "Once a month, income support then once a month, Child [Tax] ... And it's, like, two weeks gap and that I would try and stretch it. But my fridge is very small ... I can only get so much in order to stuff the freezer and fridge."
>
> **INTERVIEW 4**

> "Every day for northern people, it feels like you have to make a choice. It's either good, healthy food or food that's just going to fill your stomach, you know? ... Noodles are $3 to $5 for it. And that can feed us, but it's not going to make us full. It's not too fun eating noodles every night."
>
> **INTERVIEW 11**

Interview participants also systematically **cut out non-essentials**. This meant prioritizing meat and staple foods by cutting out other foods and household items. They stopped buying foods they enjoyed, like fruit, and put off buying larger items like furniture. When needed, their families also went without diapers, cleaning supplies, and new shoes or clothing.

"Sometimes food is more important than being clean. Supplies, like laundry detergent, dish detergent. You might have put those aside for a bit."

INTERVIEW 11

Their efforts continued **in the kitchen** as they cut meat into smaller pieces, mixing it with vegetables and rice or potatoes to make meals appear larger and ensure nothing went to waste. Many preferred to eat country food when it was available, in part because they said it kept their families full longer, and they talked of practices like freezing country food so it lasted longer.

"I'll try [to] cook less, like cut up meat and cut up vegetables so it can combine along with rice and potato and mix it all up together."

INTERVIEW 40

Participants also worked on **expanding household budgets** by taking on additional jobs or informal work. Income-generating activities included selling crafts (sewing, beading, carvings, mittens), baked goods or personal items (cell phones, purses, headphones). Those who could also did things like renting their vehicles and taking on side work like cleaning, babysitting and giving massages for extra income. People who harvested also sold country food, though, as discussed below, some expressed discomfort doing so. Some also played bingo or gambled small amounts of money in hopes of winning money to buy groceries.

"I would work extra hard even during evenings, cleaning for people, doing their dishes, mopping their floors."

INTERVIEW 38



Collective strategies – caring for each other to make ends meet

Beyond their individual strategies for making ends meet, many interview participants spoke of collective strategies that built on Inuit strengths. They spoke of **food and resource sharing** with family and community members as important forms of support. This included sharing money, gifts of food or meals and country food. It also included eating at relatives' or community members' homes and inviting others to eat with them. Even those participants who experienced daily and weekly struggles to make ends meet talked about sharing with others.

"I have a lot of nieces and nephews. And also I have preteen, two preteens, son and daughter. They would have friends over, and most times they eat with us, or most times my nephews or nieces comes to our place to eat when there's not enough food in their house."

INTERVIEW 9

"I would have days where I feel like I have a little too much in my freezer or the cupboards, and I would end up gathering a little bit and ask somebody who is in need to pick it up. But of course, I have my days where I struggle too … I have people that help me out when I have struggles."

INTERVIEW 14

While some participants noted that they shared because they know what it feels like to be hungry, others talked about food sharing as a learned and expected way of living, rooted in teachings passed down from parents and elders. They emphasized that they were taught that everyone should eat, no one goes hungry and that resources should be shared regardless of quantity. At the same time, they also discussed tensions and challenges around sharing. Some spoke of sadness at not being able to share enough to meet community needs. Others noted that they had to prioritize their households/families and were not able to share as much as they would like. Some said they always shared what they could, but even those with very high household incomes noted that it was hard to make ends meet when there were many mouths to feed.

"My kids, they know how to cook a big cook. When we have no food at home, sometimes we mix it [with food] from their home … I'm glad they do understand they're helping other people too. We taught them."

INTERVIEW 23

"I have a family … [My sisters] have their own kids to support, and they have their own needs to end, too. So, I can't always depend on them."

INTERVIEW 7

"It's sometimes hard, especially when you don't have enough food and when my other grandchildren, who doesn't live with us, come and eat. But we, I still manage to feed them. ... I'm happy about."

INTERVIEW 42

Awareness that supporting extended family and community members strained people's abilities to feed their own household members was also reflected in participants' discussions of receiving community help. Some described their families as not liking to ask for help from the community and going without informal support that community members could potentially provide. Other interview participants spoke of embarrassment or discomfort, desire to avoid overburdening others and feeling unwelcome when asking for food. For this reason, for example, many talked of sending or encouraging their children to eat at other people's homes when there was no food in the house. When asked what adults did on these days, they shared that the adults stayed behind and went without to avoid overburdening family and community members.

"My late parents taught me to share with everybody who's in one place, even whoever's visiting ... So I try and share with everybody who's at my place, if we have enough food. But when it's not enough, it's like my heart breaks."

INTERVIEW 39

In addition, participants and key informants shared that communal support was not always equally available to all in the community. Those who had moved from another community or had fewer family members and community connections had fewer places to turn, as did those who were part of family networks in which many people were struggling. Interpersonal dynamics, such as unequal willingness to share, could also discourage individuals from accessing support. Further, the challenges of sharing and caring for each other could become complicated by additional obligations or considerations, such as managing medical travel, caring for disabled family members, or supporting family members dealing with addictions.

"We would ask through Facebook ... if anyone could spare food or we would ask our family if they have leftover or if we or our kids could go eat ... we, as the parents, start to feel unwelcome ... [and] even though we would want to share, but we can't, we gotta have, try to have enough food until our next income."

INTERVIEW 12

"It's embarrassing to look for food. Especially when we are hungry. It's hard. Especially when you don't have family to turn to."

INTERVIEW 17

Collective strategies – sharing country food

Communal norms around sharing were most pronounced when it came to country food. Sharing of country food was understood as a collective responsibility and tradition passed down across generations. In 2022 in Nunavut, 56% of Inuit over the age of 15 hunted, fished or trapped and 37% gathered wild plants.[18] One study estimated that 17 of 21 communities in Nunavut harvested enough country food to meet the protein requirements of all community members.[19] Thus, for many in Nunavut, country food is an important part of their household diets and plays an important role in efforts to make ends meet.

"I have a full freezer of caribou right now."

INTERVIEW 15

"We eat better in the springtime because we don't just eat store-bought food. We start eating country food."

INTERVIEW 11

"If my family member goes hunting, we go to their place to eat for country food."

INTERVIEW 5

Many of the people we interviewed, like participants in other studies, prized country food for being more delicious, filling, and healthy than store-bought alternatives; they also valued country food for its cultural meaning and role in maintaining relationships of reciprocity and care.[20] However, even for these participants, consumption of country food, and the role of country food in making ends meet, could depend on the preferences of people within their households. For example, while some participants said their children loved country food, others noted that some children preferred store-bought food. When there were different preferences within the household, some tried to accommodate different family members by regularly providing different food options. This, however, involved extra expense and was not always possible.

"Hunters usually post on social media … And when they post free for pickup, we pick something up. Yeah. And you also may also have family members who get invited to go out, so they share a little bit of their catch too."

INTERVIEW 8

"When the hunters are lucky to get food, they sometimes provide the community. So when there's some available, we get some. … Sometimes it's gone before we get there."

INTERVIEW 7

Access to country food also varied. Some interview participants reported eating country food multiple times a week or "always" having some in the house, while others had more infrequent access (e.g., a couple of times a month). For some, access to country food varied by season; they had more in the fall and in spring when animals were more abundant and hunting conditions were safer. In keeping with prior research, interview participants who did not have hunters in their families or strong ties to food-sharing networks had less access to country food.[21] Those who did not have access to a boat/skidoo to go out on the land also had less access.

> When there's some at HTO to pick up, we get those sometimes ... We kind of have to rush over there.
>
> **INTERVIEW 27**

The differences in country food access resonate with other studies in Nunavut, which show (for example) that sharing of country food is often shaped by household wealth, harvest production, kinship, and reciprocity. Some lower-income or low-harvest households received less country food. One study found that this was true even for single women and Elders who were often connected to large sharing networks but did not necessarily have reliable access to country food.[22] Many interview participants relied on broad community networks and sharing by the Hunters and Trappers Organization (HTO) for country food, which they appreciated. However, awareness of giveaways through social media or word of mouth was crucial and, as many community members were interested, they had to be quick to respond before supplies ran out.

> A lot of the community members eat country food. One seal is a bit hard to share amongst a big family like we have.
>
> **INTERVIEW 11**

> There's always free seal ... free walrus, and free bearded seals. But we don't eat those much. But caribou, we love caribou.
>
> **INTERVIEW 1**

Even those participants who had hunters in their homes or family networks reported challenges. In keeping with research in other Northern regions, participants who had hunters in their households detailed the numerous and often expensive supplies needed to go out on the land, including transportation (skidoo/boat), fuel, food and seasonally appropriate clothing; they noted that costs for these necessities were rising.[23] Thus, the same struggles to make ends meet that make country food sharing so vital also made it difficult to harvest.[24] Although some said country food was not traditionally sold, some explained that their family members needed to sell their harvests to cover costs and support their families. Participants who purchased country food understood this, but

they also described rising costs as a barrier to eating more country food.

> Hunters too, they need to pay for the bullets ... the food while they're out on camp and then gas... and the fuel for the stoves. Which makes sense, to why they were starting to have really high prices on country food, because then they go so far to hunt for the caribou.
>
> **INTERVIEW 14**

Thus, while sharing harvests with extended family and community members was described as an important and valued practice, interview participants in all three communities felt there was currently not enough country food to meet everyone's needs. Indeed, some participants noted that, in large families, expectations to share meant that there wasn't always enough left for hunters to meet the needs of their own households. While interview participants saw country food as a critical food security strategy, they suggested additional supports – such as more opportunities for young people to learn harvesting skills, paid positions for hunters, additional infrastructure like working community freezers and initiatives that subsidized the cost of equipment for hunting and harvesting – were required to fully meet demand in a context shaped by low household incomes, high grocery costs and under-supported harvesting systems.[25]

Accessing formal supports

Interview participants also spoke of **accessing the limited formal supports** available in the community. Many said that people in their households were receiving Income Assistance, and most also received CCB and Nunavut Child Benefits (NUCB). Some were able to access supports through Child and Family Services (CFS) when needed. Others shared that they believed they were eligible for supports but had not been able to satisfy the burdensome requirement to qualify. In addition, they spoke about supports they were (or had sometimes been) able to access through child and family services (money for groceries and clothing), Hunters and Trappers organizations (country food), and food available to children who attended school or daycare. They also spoke about accessing food pantries or soup kitchens and occasionally receiving food hampers, but these resources were very limited in the hamlets where we conducted interviews. In all three communities, participants discussed resources that had been available in the past but were no longer available or were operating with reduced capacity.

> "When I notice if we're not going to have enough food, since we're keeping my niece through foster care, I get hold of Family Services to get help. And that happens at least once a month or twice a month."
>
> **INTERVIEW 45**

Calculated hunger

Participants in our study were, individually and collectively, doing all they could to make ends meet, but it wasn't enough. Despite their sharing, planning and taking on extra work, 7 out of 10 participants said their families skipped meals or ate only once a day. For many interview participants, hunger was not something that snuck up and took them unaware; it was expected and carefully planned for. 'Going hungry' was, by necessity, one of their budget-stretching strategies.

> "I'd rather have my kids and my common-law to eat 'cause I don't want my common-law out there without putting anything in his tummy. And I would feel bad, right? I let him go out without having anything and I would keep crying knowing he hasn't put anything in his tummy along with my girls."
>
> **INTERVIEW 40**

Many interview participants spoke of sacrifices they made to protect their children from hunger. In some households, all the adults, and even older children, went without food so that younger children could eat. In addition, when there was no food in the house, children often ate at other people's homes while the adults stayed behind and went without. In addition, in keeping with findings in a prior study,[26] some participants said that women (mothers and sometimes their sisters/mothers) in their households went without food so that others could eat. These measures were on top of formal supports reserved for children: in all three communities in our study, children attending school/preschool had access to additional food that was not available to others.

In some cases, strategies around hunger were also part of a long-term calculation. For example, one participant, who shared that she sometimes did not eat so that her children could eat and that there were other times when her whole family went without food, also noted that she was saving half of her monthly paycheck to buy a skidoo. She explained, "I have no choice, because we eat country food too." (Interview 41)

> "Sometimes, if it's just enough for my kids, me and my spouse don't eat a day. He would sometimes go to work without eating a day or two because it was only enough for our kids and he still managed to go to work in hopes of making more hours and seeing the pay they said he would see, right? So … Sometimes we go a day or two without eating as long as our child is fed."
>
> **INTERVIEW 33**

Stem and Root Causes of Food Insecurity

Colonial Impacts and Structural Inequities

In this chapter, we draw on existing research and analysis of food price data to summarize the context of food insecurity in Nunavut.

Food insecurity in Nunavut reflects the ongoing harms of colonialism, which disrupted the strong roots of culturally and contextually grounded food systems.

It also reflects more recent structural inequities. These inequities are deep and interlocking. They include, but are not limited to, the high cost of living, inadequacy of welfare supports, a housing crisis, limited employment opportunities, and severe deficits in infrastructure across multiple domains.[27]

Structural inequities in Nunavut also include food systems that rely on Southern-based for-profit entities (manufacturers, retailers, freight carriers) and federal subsidies that do not fully offset the rising costs of shipping food to Nunavut. Retail food prices in Nunavut today are approximately twice as high as in Canada as a whole and have grown faster than in the rest of Canada in the last decade.[28]

These are the weak stems that leave Inuit in Nunavut unable to make ends meet. The result is that many Inuit in Nunavut have household incomes that are too low to cover the cost of living.

Colonial impacts on Inuit life

The context of food insecurity in Nunavut has been shaped by Canadian actions since at least the 1950s. During this period, Canada sought to protect its post-World War II sovereignty, facilitate the opening of Hudson's Bay Company trading posts and "police, educate, and provide health care for remote populations."[29] At this time, the federal government came to see the North as being in a crisis state requiring immediate intervention. It implemented relocation and settlement programs that disrupted communities and altered patterns of daily life. At the same time, the "number of caribou across the North declined and/or migration patterns changed, particularly in the Kivalliq region of central Nunavut.[30] During this period, Canada also introduced residential school policies that resulted in multiple generations of Inuit children living away from their families to attend day schools. The harm done by such policies has had long-lasting, intergenerational impacts.[31]

These programs also "curtailed Inuit mobility and, in some cases, prevented participation in harvesting activities and the transfer of essential life skills, limiting Inuit self-determination in the development of the Inuit Nunangat food system."[32] Land dispossession and the colonial introduction and expansion of capitalist food systems led to a growing reliance on store-bought foods, which are less nutrient-dense than country foods.[33] Together, the impacts of colonization have reduced participation in harvesting across generations, reduced intergenerational transfer of ecological knowledge, and disrupted food-sharing networks by commercializing traditional foods. The ability to sustain communities through traditional practices has also been damaged by population growth, harvesting restrictions on wildlife species, and (preventable) climate change, which affects wildlife migratory patterns and the ability to hunt.[34]

Thus, colonial actions disrupted a food system that is rooted in culture and food sovereignty.[35] Still, country food systems persist and continue to be an important part of life in Nunavut. As discussed in Chapter 2, food sharing and collective care are among the strong stems that help support healthy leaves and berries in this system.

Infrastructure gaps and the high cost of living

Food insecurity in Nunavut is rooted in colonial policies and actions that disrupted Inuit food sovereignty and ways of living, but more recent policies and governmental actions have compounded colonial harms, creating deep infrastructure gaps in the areas of power and wastewater treatment; housing; ports and harbours; health; community justice; and education. Such gaps are a result of inadequate investment and failures to support the development of infrastructure adapted for "Inuit social realities or Northern climate realities."[36] Collectively, they give rise to the high levels of food insecurity and poverty that exist in Nunavut today. These challenges represent *structural violence*: inequities so

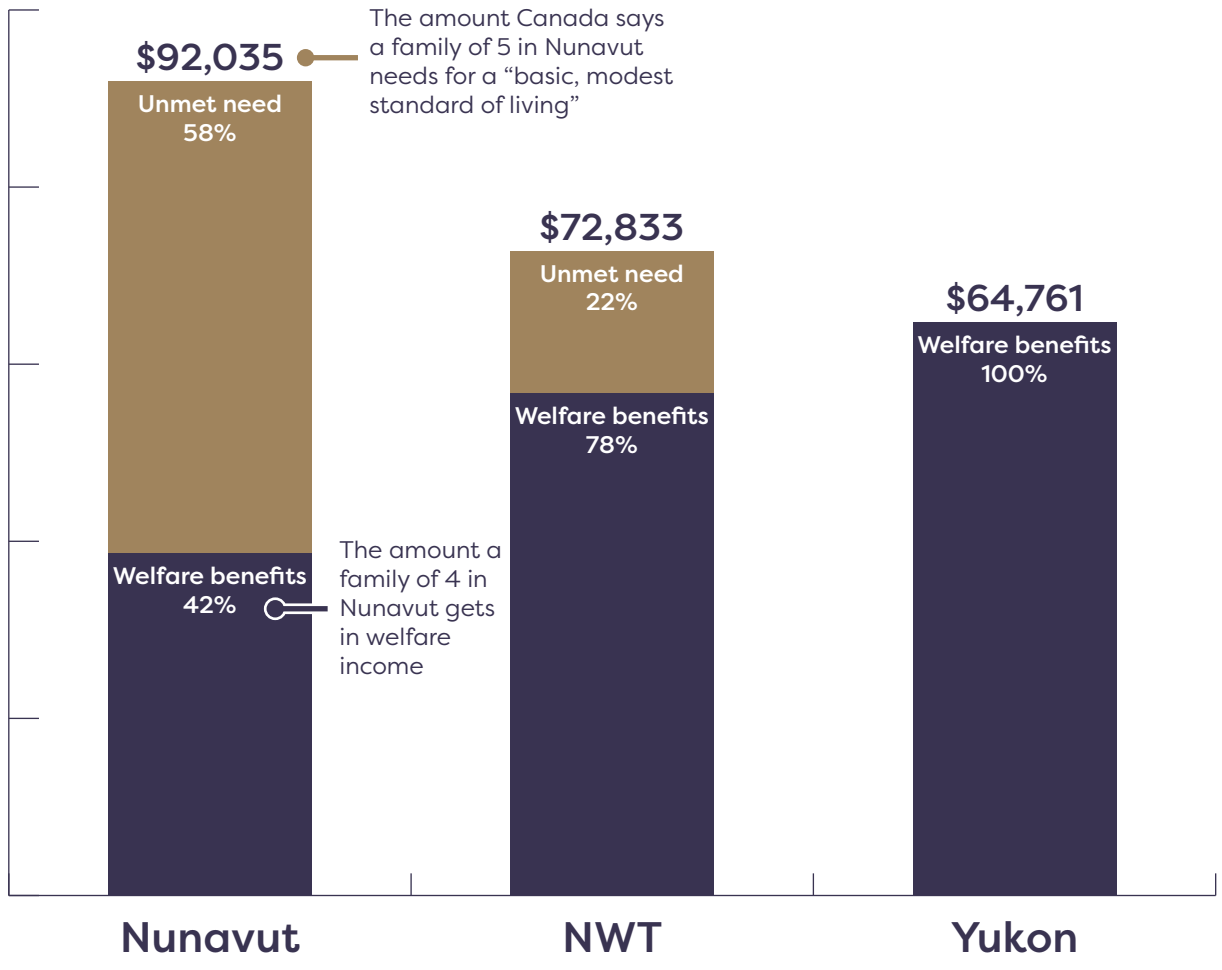
profound that they prevent Inuit in Nunavut from "having the resources necessary to help them reach their full potential" while other groups are spared this treatment.[37]

Collectively, these gaps drive up the cost of living and give rise to food insecurity. For example, inadequate harbours add to the cost of retail food, make it harder for Inuit to fish and hunt for country food and add to the cost of materials needed to build more housing. The housing shortage keeps market rates for housing high, which means that, after they pay rent, families have less money to spend on food.[38] Infrastructure gaps similarly contribute to the high cost of diapers and baby wipes, seasonal clothing, supplies needed to go out on the land/harvest country food, bills/utilities and other non-food expenses that interview participants cite as making it difficult to make ends meet.

FIGURE 4

Welfare benefits in Nunavut are less than half of the cost of living

Total welfare benefits and the official poverty line (2024)



Based on Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

The high cost of living in Nunavut is reflected in the region's official poverty line. As summarized in Figure 4, the Government of Canada estimates that an annual income of $92,035 is required for a family of five in Nunavut to have a basic, modest standard of living.[39] The poverty line is much lower in the Northwest Territories and Yukon. 43% of people in Nunavut live below the official poverty line, and the percentage of Inuit that the census classifies as low income (living in a household with less than 50% of the median income) is three times higher than the percentage of low-income non-Inuit.[40] In 2023, the poverty rate in Nunavut was higher than in any other province or territory, more than double that in Yukon and the Northwest Territories, and more than 4 times the rate for Canada as a whole.[41]

Education and employment

In the face of this high cost of living, Inuit employment opportunities are limited. The 2023 employment rate in Nunavut was 44.7% for Inuit, compared to 89.6% for non-Inuit.[42] Similarly, the median individual income in 2021 was $40,400 for Inuit and $116,000 for non-Indigenous people.[43]

> "My husband's pay is very small for being a part-timer ...We can't get income support either because he's working."
>
> **INTERVIEW 11**

High unemployment rates and low incomes for Inuit in Nunavut persist despite recent increases in minimum wage (now $19.75/hour) and the Government of Nunavut (GN) wage scale, GN provision of northern living and housing allowances and similar practices by other employers.[44] Recent studies suggest that a shortage of employment opportunities and a lack of required education/training for higher-paying jobs are major barriers to Inuit employment. For example, many jobs in the public sector, which is the largest employer in Nunavut, require post-secondary training, which is not available in many communities.[45] While Arctic College does have learning centres in every community, as well as a research institute and cultural learning facility with 2 satellite programs, many opportunities are located in 3 main campuses.[46]

> "A lot of us look for jobs, but some of us never get selected. And it's very hard to get a job here in Nunavut unless if you have an education ... Some of the people that don't have education get lucky to find a job and stay on the job ... Even though they make very good money, we still have trouble managing the bills, the food, feeding the dogs, buying gas, fuel for the stove, lantern, or Coleman stove."
>
> **INTERVIEW 12**

Across education levels, Inuit workers have lower incomes than non-Inuit workers. The disparities are greatest for the more than 50% of Inuit who have not completed high school.[47] Some of the other factors that may limit education and work include a long-term shortage of childcare spaces (particularly in the licensed centres that qualify for deep subsidies for low-income families).[48] Health infrastructure gaps may also limit workforce participation for those who are caregivers for family members with disabilities. In addition, because many specialized health services are unavailable within Nunavut communities, accessing needed services can require patients, caregivers and family members acting as escorts to stay outside their home communities for extended periods. This includes medical travel for specialist appointments, chronic disease management, pediatric care and pregnancy confinement (which in uncomplicated pregnancies can last for 1–6 weeks). These prolonged absences can disrupt employment, education, childcare arrangements, and household income, particularly in communities where informal caregiving responsibilities already place significant demands on families.[49]

Social assistance and subsidized housing

For those who are unemployed or under-employed, the situation is even more complicated. As shown in Figure 5, despite a significant recent increase in Income Assistance levels,[50] the welfare benefits available to families in Nunavut (including maximum Income Assistance payments, public housing benefits, federal and territorial child benefits, and other federal tax credits) cover less than half the cost for a basic standard of living (the official poverty line). In comparison, welfare benefits in the Northwest Territories cover almost 80% of the cost of living, and benefits in Yukon fully cover the cost of a modest standard of living.[51, i] The territorial differences in welfare sufficiency largely reflect the low level of 'basic social assistance' (Income Assistance) in Nunavut, the lack of additional social assistance (such as is available in Yukon), and the fact that neither territorial nor federal child tax benefits are adjusted to reflect the cost of living across territories.

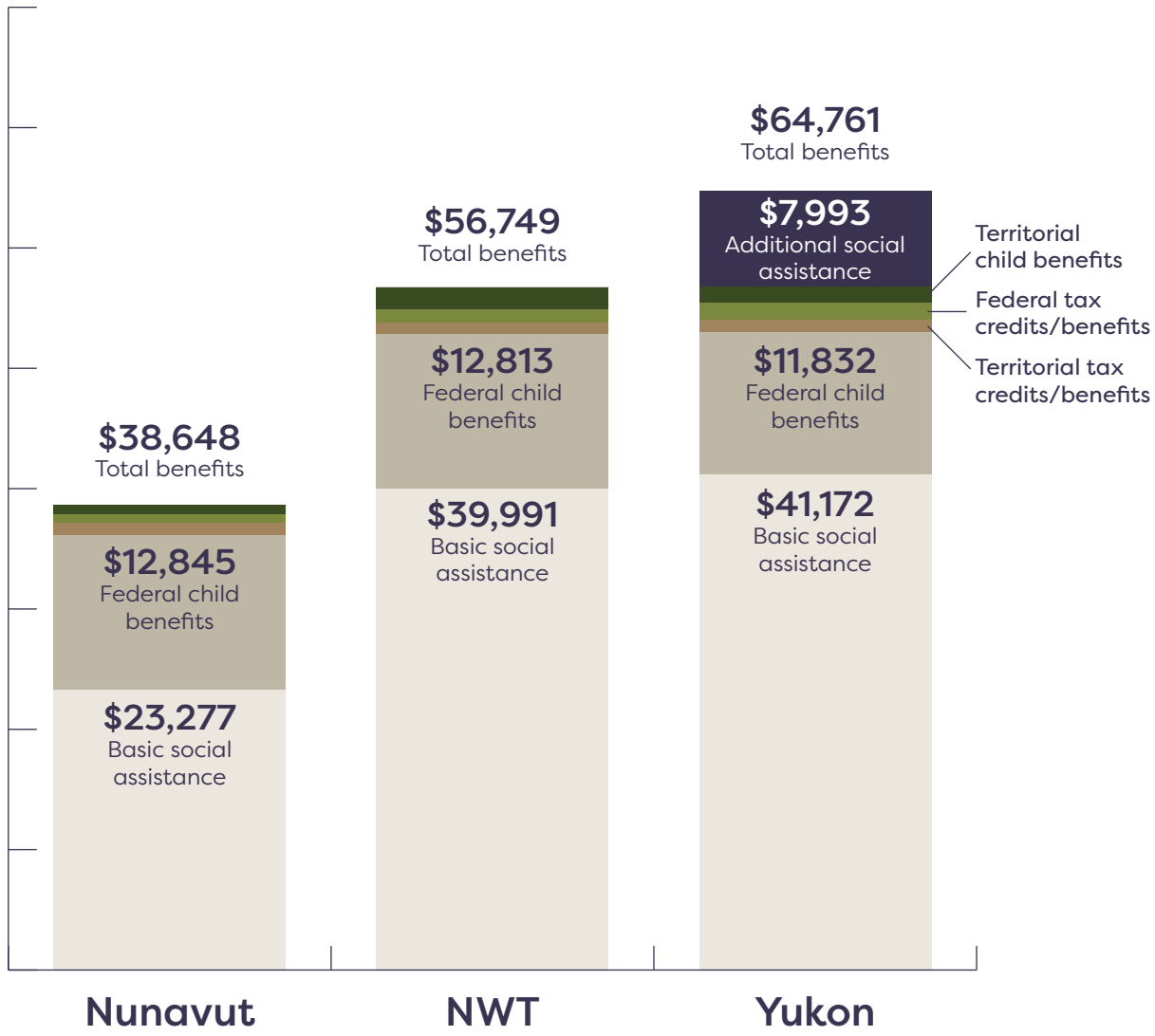
> "I'm not getting a job on purpose because of [the kids]. They usually go out through medical. And it gets complicated coming back to work after a trip."
>
> **INTERVIEW 4**

[i] For more information on the poverty and welfare measures utilized in this report, see this information sheet: https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p86wnwm

FIGURE 5

Social Assistance in Nunavut lags behind other territories

Components of welfare income (2024)



Amounts represent the maximum benefit available to a family with two children, living in social housing in Iqaluit. Based on Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

"I used to get income support, but then my boyfriend started working, so that went out … [his pay is] less because he's a casual worker. They only let him work when they need help."

INTERVIEW 18

"I was at a rate of $24.50 an hour when I was working at the Hamlet. Having to pay the power bill, your rent bills … It can't cover the whole two weeks."

INTERVIEW 33

For those at the lower end of the wage scale, trade-offs with work are compounded by structural disincentives in rules around Income Assistance and other social benefits. For example, a head of household with dependents receiving Income Assistance also qualifies for additional support, but they are only allowed $1000 in liquid assets and up to $700 in income before Income Assistance is reduced.[52] Similarly, disincentives exist for the 60% of Nunavummiut who live in social housing, which operates on a tiered payment system. The cost of subsidized housing for a full-time worker making between $33,280 and $40,000 (which is consistent with a full-time minimum wage job) can be $6600–$8000/year; this drops to $720 for a person working less than four days a week at minimum wage.[53]

"A lot of us families have to make a choice between the three main things: It's the bills or the clothes or the food."

INTERVIEW 14

"Even though I work with the government, with the house, rent is so expensive ... and then on top of that, I need to buy groceries for two weeks ... People say, people who works with the government are rich. But we're the poor!"

INTERVIEW 5

"I have a house through my work. ... And the rent is $2,200 every two weeks."

INTERVIEW 10

For others, the challenge of making ends meet is compounded by a housing crisis. In 2023, more than 3000 applicants were on the social housing waitlist, and 45% of social housing units were overcrowded.[54] In 2023, an estimated annual income of at least $115,000 was required to afford an unsubsidized two-bedroom apartment.[55] The impact of the housing crisis was evident in our interviews with caregivers; participants lived in households ranging from 4 people to 14 people who shared a 4-bedroom home.

"Our power bills are close to $400 and the water and sewage ... for the house is over $300 too."

INTERVIEW 36

The retail food system

The high rate of food insecurity in Nunavut reflects a vast gap between household incomes and the resources required for a basic standard of living. Because individuals have more direct control over the food they buy than over the cost of housing, utilities, and other essentials, they may reduce the cost of their food purchases to make ends meet. As discussed in the previous chapter, this can mean eating less nutritious food, skipping meals or eating less food overall.

"Baby wipes. They used to be like $69. ... Now they are $89.99 for a box."

INTERVIEW 7

"[Winter outfits] are a lot more expensive now, even trying to order, the shipping cost would cost double or half of the price you're paying for the items."

INTERVIEW 4

"Ribs are over $40, something like that, the long ones, frozen ones ... Even the small packages are over 13 bucks or something like that."

INTERVIEW 19

"Juice boxes: they're almost $50. Yogurt, cookies, Rice Krispie treats, cereal ... Fruits. Even fruits are more expensive now."

INTERVIEW 16

The challenge of making ends meet in Nunavut is complicated by gaps in the infrastructure that supports the retail food market. Communities in Nunavut are not connected to the South, or even to each other, by road. For most of the year, communities in Nunavut depend on air transportation to supply stores with food from distribution warehouses that are, on average, approximately 2000 km away. In the late summer, communities can receive a limited number of shipments by boat.[56]

Like many Northern communities, most communities in Nunavut are served by only one or two grocery stores and one or two commercial airlines, which are also often the main freight carriers.[57] This monopoly/duopoly structure reflects the small size of most Nunavut communities, which limits the number of potential customers for retail grocery stores and makes it expensive to operate in Nunavut. Retailers and shippers serving small communities cannot take advantage of the cost savings that come with buying in bulk, less expensive shipping of food on larger planes or opportunities to spread management and infrastructure costs over a large volume of sales. Increased competition would not automatically solve this problem – if each company had a smaller share of the market, they might actually face higher costs and set prices higher to compensate. However, the limited competition in the Nunavut retail market may also allow profit-maximizing firms to raise profit margins in response to policies intended to increase local incomes or reduce consumer costs through freight subsidies or infrastructure.

In addition, the current retail food system extends colonial power relations. Because all agricultural and manufacturing, and most freight/distribution, business services, and retail management income goes south, a large share of every dollar spent on food in Nunavut feeds into the southern economy rather than the economy of Nunavut. As a result, the local economic impact of food spending is considerably lower than in the South.

"Fruits are prices very high, higher than some junk food. That's not right. Because our kids have to eat fruits too, right?"

INTERVIEW 41

"I'm pretty sure the stores won't be lowering their prices anytime soon. Right?"

INTERVIEW 13

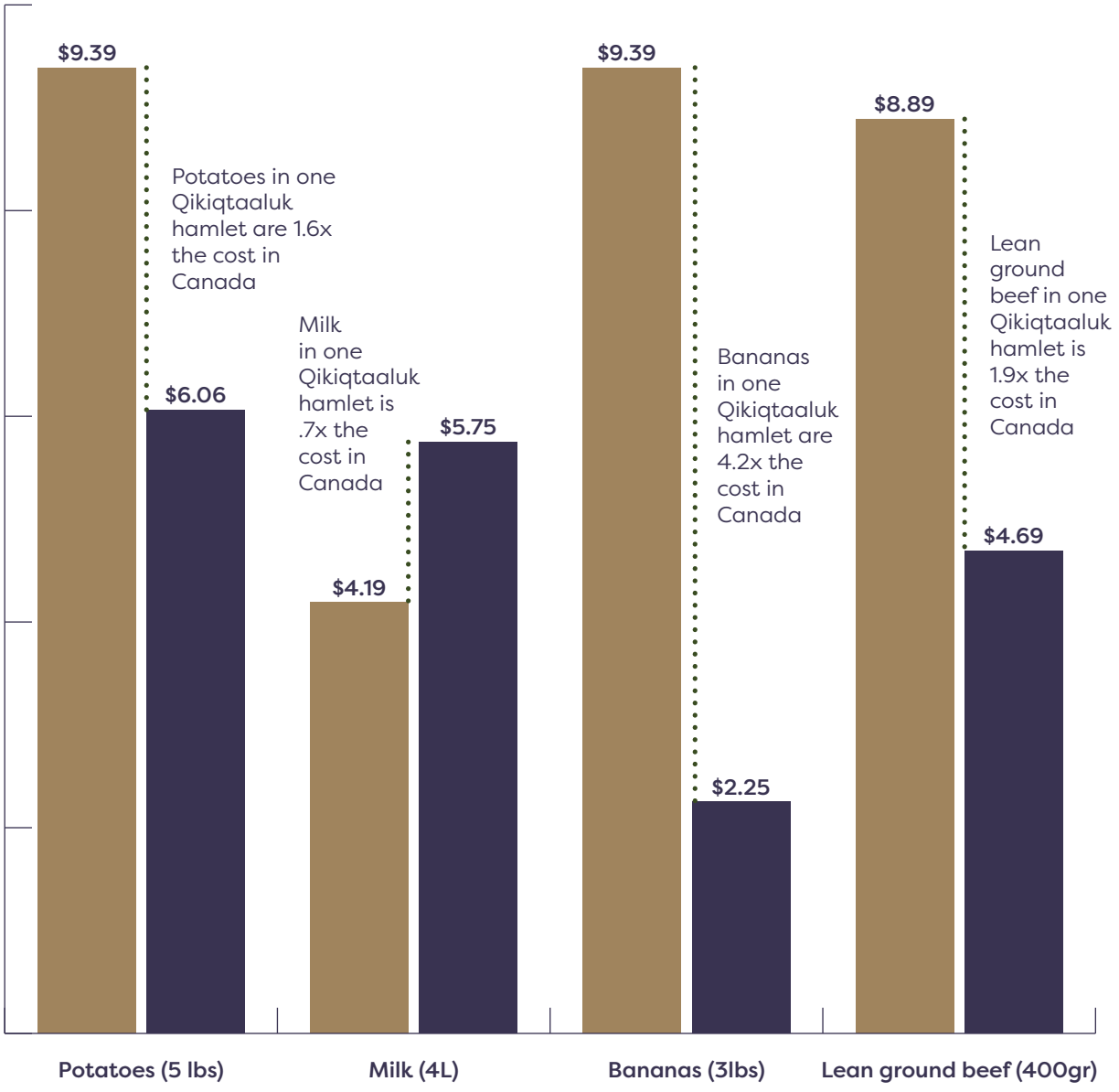
As a result of the infrastructure gaps, vast distances and limited competition, grocery prices in Nunavut are very high. Comparison of data on all the purchases made by families receiving individual Grocery Supports in Qikiqtaaluk and Canadian average prices (provided by BetterCart) indicates that, on average, between January 2022 and June 2024, prices were 1.91 times as high as in Canada as a whole. The biggest price difference was for fruits, vegetables, and legumes; within this category, prices in Nunavut were 2.44 times those for Canada as a whole (see Appendix 1 for more details). Price differences also varied across communities. Prices in Iqaluit were 1.77 times those for Canada as a whole. In contrast, prices in Grise Fiord averaged 2.47 times those for Canada as a whole.[58]



FIGURE 6

Even NNC subsidized foods can cost more in Qikiqtaaluk

Food prices in one Qikiqtaaluk hamlet vs. Canadian retail prices (late 2024)



Li, N., Morgan, R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) *Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025.*

Figure 6 shows some example price comparisons for one Qikiqtaaluk hamlet, using ICFI-funded Grocery Supports receipt data for the North West Company in 2024, and the Canadian average price (from BetterCart). These price differences exist even with subsidies through a federal program, known as Nutrition North Canada (NNC). NNC is intended to reduce high grocery prices in Northern communities. It provides direct payments to retailers to subsidize the cost of food in remote northern communities. Retailers are expected to pass through the savings to customers by reducing the retail price by the amount of the subsidy. However, existing research suggests that retailers in markets with only one or two retailers do not pass through the full amount of the subsidy.[59] The subsidy rates vary by community and product; products deemed more nutritious receive higher subsidy levels. Many widely consumed foods are not subsidized because they do not fall into the NNC categories of nutritious foods.[60] The products in Figure 6 — potatoes, bananas, milk, and ground beef — are all NNC subsidy eligible and received a small increase in subsidies in February 2023. For some products, like milk, the subsidies do help to reduce prices so that they are equal to or even less than average Canadian prices. However, for items like bananas, prices remain extremely elevated even with the subsidy taken into account.

On average, the price of subsidized products in Nunavut remains significantly higher than in the South. Even at the highest subsidy level, NNC only covers a share of the freight costs for eligible items. Unlike its predecessor, the Food Mail program, which guaranteed a fixed freight cost, NNC does not link subsidies with actual freight costs over time. Instead, changes in subsidy rates depend on the discretion of policymakers. As a result, NNC subsidies have not kept pace with high increases in freight costs in the last decade. Existing research shows that, though NNC may have reduced food inflation for some products, food insecurity in Nunavut increased after the introduction of NNC.[61] We further explore the reasons for high prices and inflation — especially rising freight costs — in Chapter 6.

Strengthening Stems

Increasing Food Access Through ICFI Food Supports

In this chapter, we draw on analysis of policy documents and key informant interviews to present an overview of ICFI-funded food supports.

The Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI/Jordan's Principle) is intended to ensure that Inuit children (under age 19) "have equal access to essential government-funded health, social and educational products, services and supports."[62] In recent years, food supports funded through ICFI have helped to address the structural violence faced by Inuit in Nunavut by increasing access to food.

Initially, food supports ($500 per month per child, with an extra $250 per month in diaper and formula support for children under age 4) were provided to individual families who had to submit personalized documentation for case-by-case assessment. By 2023, there was a large backlog of requests and long delays in response to requests for Grocery Supports.

As a result, Hamlets began to apply for Hamlet Food Voucher (HFV) programs, which provided $500 per month per child, with an extra $250 per month in diaper and formula support for children under age 4, to the families of all Inuit children/youth in a community. By the end of 2024, these programs reached Inuit children in 24 of 25 Nunavut communities.

> The HFV programs efficiently increased food access for all Inuit children in the community, eliminated the burden of submitting individual requests for families and service providers/coordinators, and countered the inefficiency of ISC's assessment of individual requests.
>
> The HFV program ended in March of 2025, when the federal government discontinued funding. We estimated the cost of expanding the program to all communities in Nunavut to be just under $100 million.
>
> ICFI continued to fund individual Grocery Supports, but only under considerably narrowed eligibility criteria. After March 2025, very few children qualified for individual Grocery Supports.
>
> The treatment of ICFI-funded Grocery Support requests does not appear to meet the legal standards that have been established for services to First Nations children through Jordan's Principle, the southern parallel to ICFI. The needs of Inuit children without access to food are not being met within 12 hours, and requests for Grocery Supports are being denied even though service providers and coordinators attest that no alternate supports are available.

The Inuit Child First Initiative

As discussed in the previous chapter, the high level of food insecurity in Nunavut is driven by the intersection of structural inequities across multiple domains. As a result, there is a deep gap between household resources and the high cost of living in Nunavut. Existing programs — like Income Assistance, Canada Child Benefits (CCB) and Nunavut Child Benefits (NUCB), social housing, NNC subsidies, the Northern living allowance and the Northern housing allowances — are not enough to bridge this gap, and food insecurity persists despite concerted individual and collective efforts to make sure that nobody goes without food.

Recently, key efforts to increase access to food in Nunavut have been funded through the Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI), which is intended to ensure that Inuit children (under age 19) "have equal access to essential government-funded health, social and educational products, services and supports."[63] ICFI parallels Jordan's Principle, "a human rights principle established by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) to make sure that First Nations children do not face gaps, delays, or denials in accessing government services because of their identity as First Nations children."[64] ICFI was announced in September 2018 as a temporary measure put in place "while an Inuit-specific

framework is being developed."[65] Since its initiation, ICFI has been funded through temporary budget allocations.

Through Jordan's Principle and ICFI, the federal government responds to:

- **Individual requests** for services, supports or equipment to meet the needs of individual First Nations and Inuit children.
- **Group requests** for funding for programs or services that meet the needs of groups of First Nations or Inuit children.[66]

Families making individual requests must submit documentation, including a service provider's letter of support, describing their child's unmet needs. Organizations can make group requests to fund programs or services for groups of children and to fund service coordinators, who help families navigate the individual request processes.

The standards and procedures for submission, assessment, and response to ICFI requests have shifted over time. These changes have been partially shaped by a series of rulings, issued by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) since 2016, in *First Nations Child and Family Caring Society & Assembly of First Nations et al v. Canada*.[67] The rulings apply specifically to Jordan's Principle, and Inuit have not been a party to that case. However, ICFI has "operationally ... mirrored Jordan's Principle processes since its creation in 2018",[68] and the *Canadian Human Rights Act* has established that in "the provision of goods, services, facilities or accommodation customarily available to the general public," it is discriminatory for the federal government to "deny, or to deny access to, any such good, service, facility or accommodation to any individual" based on race or ethnic origin.[69]

One key aspect of the CHRT rulings is that Jordan's Principle requests are assessed with respect to a standard of substantive equality, a legal principle focused on achieving equality of *outcomes* that requires consideration of "historical disadvantage" as well as "historical, geographical and cultural needs and circumstances."[70] Another is that "a child with no access to food or other basic necessities is considered an urgent case requiring action within 12 hours."[71] The federal government webpage for Jordan's Principle (for First Nations children) begins with clear instructions around urgent requests. In contrast, the government web page for ICFI makes **no** mention of urgent cases.[72]

National ICFI timeline

ICFI emerged as a temporary initiative, parallel to Jordan's Principle for First Nations children, that was to be in place until an Inuit-specific, long-term service framework was developed. This timeline summarizes developments in the implementation of ICFI and in work towards the long-term framework.

2016–17

The Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) issued a series of decisions mandating the full implementation of Jordan's Principle, which it broadly interpreted as being intended to meet the needs of First Nations children.

March 2018

Natan Obed, President of Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami, wrote to Prime Minister Justin Trudeau expressing "deep concern regarding Canada's denial of services to Inuit children and youth under Jordan's Principle."[73]

September 2018

The ICFI was announced as a temporary measure, parallel to Jordan's Principle, put in place "while an Inuit-specific framework is being developed."[74]

March 2019

Budget 2019 included an allocation of $220 million over five years for ICFI.[75]

January 2023

A Co-Development Steering Committee was established with membership from the ITK, Inuit Treaty Organizations (ITO), and Canada. The objective of the committee was to co-develop a long-term approach that is Inuit-led and responds to the needs of Inuit children.[76]

April 2024

An additional $167.5 million was allocated to extend ICFI for two years, from April 1, 2023, to March 31, 2025.[77]

Spring 2024

Cabinet endorsed the principle of a shared responsibility model and six of the seven guiding principles put forward by Inuit partners in fall 2023. ISC received direction to co-develop, with Inuit partners, a National Framework for an Inuit-specific approach to ICFI (to govern the implementation of the Inuit CFI at the national level) and to co-develop interim regional approaches.[78]

September 2024

The ITK Board of Directors met and committed to the co-development of the National Framework and interim regional approaches.[79]

Fall 2024

ISC began meeting regularly with ITK and the Inuit Advisory Committee, which includes representatives from each of the ITOs, to co-develop the National Framework.[80]

Late 2024

Nationally, there was growing concern over the backlog of unprocessed Jordan's Principle requests, the scale and scope of approved requests, and possible misuse of Jordan's Principle funds.[81]

November 2024 & January 2025

Decisions from the CHRT laid the foundation for a major shift in the approach to Jordan's Principle and the ICFI. They reinforced key aspects of prior decisions while allowing Canada greater flexibility in the prioritization, treatment and classification of Jordan's Principle requests. Lack of access to food was specifically identified as a basis for classification as an urgent case requiring action within 12 hours.[82]

January/February 2025

The Co-Development Steering Committee met to review a draft National Framework and interim regional approaches, then circulated a draft to Inuit partners.[83]

February 2025

An ISC "operational bulletin" outlined a new approach to ICFI, introducing stricter standards for requests and indicating that previously approved requests would be reviewed on a case-by-case basis. A wide range of supports to meet basic needs would no longer "be approved unless such funding is required by substantive equality" and supported by a "medical professional's letter of support" with child-specific recommendation based on specific needs. Access to food was not on the list of supports to be approved in keeping with these standards.[84]

February 2025

Canada and Nunavut reached a bilateral agreement on funding through the National School Food Program.[85]

March 2025

Minister Hajdu (ISC) announced $121.7 million to extend the Inuit Child First Initiative until March 31, 2026.[86]

May 2025

At a National Inuit Committee on Health meeting, there was a commitment from both Canada and Inuit partners to return to the co-development table and work towards finalizing the National Framework.[87]

December 2025

In response to a question from representative Idlout asking for dates, names of organizations, and other details about consultations on Jordan's Principle and Inuit Child First Initiative, the Minister of Indigenous Services confirmed that she had not undertaken any formal consultation specifically focused on either initiative since being sworn in (May 2025).[88]

February 2026

Minister Gull Masty (ISC) announced the federal government was providing $115 million to renew funding for the Inuit Child First Initiative until March 31, 2027.[89]



ICFI Grocery Supports/Hamlet Food Voucher (HFV) Program – Nunavut timeline

2020–21

Nunavut sees the first 20 approvals of Individual Grocery Support requests.[90]

2023–24

There is dramatic growth in Grocery Support requests: almost 1800 new approvals. By the end of 2023–24, 30% of the Qikiqtaaluk child population received a grocery supports approval.[91] As requests increased, a backlog in processing cases developed, and families waited several months (and sometimes more than a year) to receive Grocery Supports.

July 2023–January 2025

Hamlets began to submit and receive approval for food voucher programs to provide supports to all Inuit children in the community. The dates for HFV to start in Qikiqtaaluk hamlets ranged from mid 2023 to early 2025:

- **Clyde River**
  July 2023
- **Pond Inlet, Qikiqtarjuaq & Whale Cove**
  November 2023
- **Grise Fiord & Pangnirtung**
  February 2024
- **Kimmirut, Arviat & Coral Harbour**
  April 2024
- **Taloyoak, Baker Lake, Igloolik & Sanikiluaq**
  May 2024
- **Rankin Inlet, Cambridge Bay & Chesterfield Inlet**
  June 2024
- **Sanirajak, Kinngait & Arctic Bay**
  July 2024
- **Naujaat**
  Sep 2024
- **Gjoa Haven & Kugaaruk**
  Oct 2024
- **Iqaluit**
  November 2024
- **Kugluktuk**
  January 2025

Fall 2024–Winter 2025

In a national context in which there was discussion of a backlog of Jordan's Principle cases and worries about the management of Jordan's Principle funds, there was growing uncertainty about the future of the HFV.

March 2025

NTI received $5,987,144 National School Food Program funding. $1,842,198 for fiscal year 2024–25 and $4,144,946 for fiscal year 2025–26 (to be repeated in 2026–27, 2027–28, and 2028–29). The Government of Nunavut Department of Education also received $4,269,892 (total) for 2024–25 and 2025–26.[92]

March 2025

Nunavut leaders raised concerns about rising grocery prices, asked if the HFV could be driving this inflation and called for an "audit" of retail prices.[93]

March/April 2025

With ICFI funding renewed for an additional year, but no communication around the HFV, service coordinators and providers noted that confusion was growing. Some hamlets re-applied for funding, under the terms of the February 2025 operational bulletin, and had their applications denied. Others shut their food voucher programs down, still others continued to operate using unspent funds from the 2024–25 fiscal year.

April 2025

An email from an ISC staff member working in the regional office to NTI noted that: [Indigenous Services Canada] has determined, based on its analysis of legal obligations related to substantive equality under the Inuit Child First Initiative, that funding for universal food voucher programs will not be approved.[94]

Spring 2025–present

As the HFV programs ended, the ICFI approach to Grocery Supports also shifted dramatically. Most requests were denied, including, at least initially, those providing clear documentation of need and those for children with specialized medical needs. Families experienced long delays and shifting standards for requests. Rare approvals were often for short time periods, such as 1–3 months, and made on a one-time basis.

July 2025

NTI approved transfer of National School Food Program funding to District Education Authorities (DEAs)

Fall 2025

DEAs begin signing agreements and receiving National School Food Program funding.

From Individual requests to the Hamlet Food Voucher (HFV) and back again

In keeping with the goals and mandate of the initiative, ICFI-funded food supports emerged as immediate ways to address one aspect of the structural violence faced by Inuit children in Nunavut. ICFI-funded supports were not intended to eliminate the underlying structural inequities that give rise to food insecurity in Nunavut. Instead, they were meant to increase food access for Inuit children, given the persistence of deep inequities. For families of Inuit children in Nunavut, they helped address a critical gap between household resources and a cost of living that remained out of reach.

> "On the individual side, we've had a lot of cases where it's like, we have a request that's maybe been on a backlog for a bit, or we get a new request for groceries and we say, 'Have you heard about this [the Hamlet Food Voucher program]? Go to them.' And it's like, right away, they're able to do that."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 3**

Individual Grocery Supports

During the initial period of the ICFI in Nunavut, individual families submitted documentation to access individual Grocery Supports for their children. The amount and number of months approved varied over time, but stabilized at $500 per month per child, with an extra $250 per month in diaper and formula support for children under age 4. Before 2024 or 2025, supports tended to be approved for 6 months or a year. The individual request approach imposed a heavy administrative burden[j] on families, health and social service providers charged with writing letters of support and service coordinators who helped facilitate requests. It was also time-consuming for ISC staff, who had to review each individual application. The rates of families receiving Grocery Supports by 2023 varied across communities, from close to 0% in some hamlets to just over 60%.[95] The rate of applications depended on individual service providers or coordinators informing community members about available funding and supporting their applications.[96] As the number of requests from individual families grew, a backlog developed at ISC, and families waited weeks or months for their requests for Grocery Supports to be assessed.[97]

The HFV

As a result, hamlets began requesting, and ISC began approving, funding for HFV programs. These programs provided $500 per month per child, with an extra $250 per month in diaper and formula support for children under age 4, to all Inuit children in a hamlet. Applications came when hamlets felt they had sufficient capacity to develop, implement and administer an HFV program. Some communities were able to move more quickly than others. Once in place, the HFV programs efficiently increased food access for all Inuit children in the community, eliminated the burden of submitting individual requests for families and service providers/coordinators, and countered the inefficiency of ISC's assessment of individual requests. Sign-up was easy, requiring only in-person or online sharing of a Nunavut Inuit Enrolment card, or a call to Nunavut Tunngavik Inc. to confirm enrolment. In most hamlets, it took about two weeks to enrol almost every child in the community. Using data on funding approved for HFV, we estimated the cost of expanding the program to all communities in Nunavut to be just under $100 million.[98]

[j] Administrative burden is the cost associated with seeking public services — including costs of searching for information, complying with rules and requirements, and experiences of stress, loss of autonomy, or stigma. Herd, P., & Moynihan, D. P. (2018). *Administrative Burden: Policymaking by Other Means.* Russell Sage Foundation. https://doi.org/10.7758/9781610448789

"The sheer cost of processing a request ... the number of staff that we need to review all those individual requests, versus ... you know, put in a multi-year agreement in place with a hamlet on the group side, that also needs to be taken into account ... If we stop these [Hamlet Food Voucher programs], it's going to go back to the individual side, and that cost is going to be almost the same. It will be lower, but it will be lower because we don't have the staff to keep up with the number of requests coming in, or there's ... some families that won't be in a position or have the capacity to submit individual requests for, you know, a number of reasons."

KEY INFORMANT 3

However, the programs emerged in a national context of growing concern over the backlog of unprocessed Jordan's Principle requests, the scale and scope of approved requests and the alleged misuse of Jordan's Principle funds.[99] At the regional level, people wondered if the HFV program could be contributing to recent increases in grocery prices.[100] The federal government discontinued funding for the HFV programs at the end of March of 2025, amid profound shifts in the national approach to Jordan's Principle and ICFI.

Back to Grocery Supports

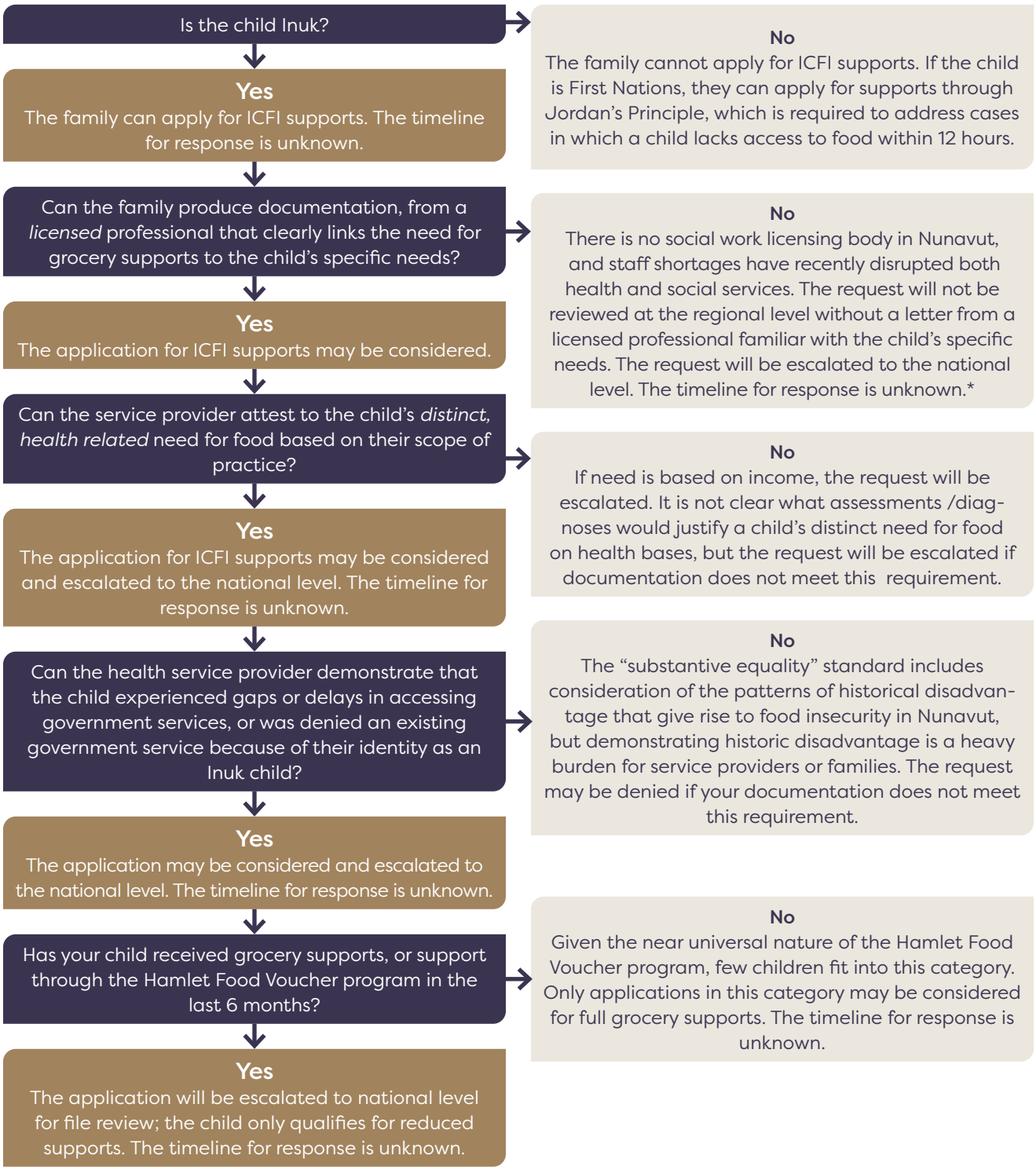
After the end of the HFV, families that were unable to provide the food their children needed were once again required to submit individual requests for Grocery Supports. At the same time, ISC's standards for and response to individual requests for Grocery Supports changed dramatically. In the context of new operational standards introduced in February of 2025[101] and heavy supervision from the ISC national office, administrative barriers to accessing ICFI-funded food security supports increased.[k] Standards shifted without public notice, leaving service coordinators/providers and families scrambling to figure out the details that should be included in documentation supporting a request for Grocery Supports. The new standards, which are summarized in Figure 7, included a requirement to provide a letter of support from a health or social service professional familiar with the child's unique needs. This was difficult to meet in a context shaped by limited access to service providers and ongoing disruptions in continuity of care.

[k] Jordan's Principle emerged in response to persistent administrative barriers to services for First Nations children. Still, in the years following their public commitments to implementing Jordan's Principle, federal and provincial/territorial governments enacted so many barriers to accessing services through Jordan's Principle that they were able to claim that there were "no Jordan's Principle cases in Canada." Rulings on Jordan's Principle made by the CHRT since 2016 responded to ongoing administrative barriers to service access.

FIGURE 7

To receive Grocery Supports a family must provide "correct" answers to these questions

ICFI standards for Grocery Supports (May 2025)



*Standards were subsequently informally revised, to allow support letters from Community Social Services Workers (and workers in similar positions) employed by the Government of Nunavut.

Sinha, V., Li, N., Wheatley, D., Hoang, N, et al (2025) *Preliminary findings from an evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Qikiqtaaluk. Qupanuaq.*



"I've definitely noticed a lot of families reaching out ... now that this food voucher program has ended, there is no more supports for their children. I've had some people sharing photos of empty cupboards and fridges because they have three to six kids who they need to support, and without that funding, a lot of families are definitely struggling."

KEY INFORMANT 13

In May of 2025, service coordinators reported that almost every individual request for Grocery Supports submitted for a Qikiqtaaluk family was either directly denied or subject to indefinite delays as it was "escalated" to the national ISC office for review and then denied. An April statement from ISC provided federal justification for this approach, stating, "It [ICFI] is not intended nor structured to displace government income assistance through universal programs such as food vouchers."[102] In subsequent months, despite the narrowing of potential ICFI cases outlined in the February 2025 operational bulletin, ISC's administrative backlog and long delays in addressing families' needs persisted.[103]

Though there was an increase in ICFI Grocery Support approvals in Nunavut starting in November of 2025, service coordinators reported that most requests for Grocery Supports continued to be denied. The exceptions tended to be approved for

very short time periods (e.g. 1–3 months) "on an exceptional basis, as a one-time final approval, to assist in providing temporary bridge funding, in order for the family to be connected and work with existing services or community supports, to navigate the children's current needs." ISC communication further noted that "there are existing government programs and services in place to address the needs of the child" but did not identify specific programs or services; none of the service providers, service coordinators, or family members that we spoke to could identify existing services or community supports that would meet children's ongoing need for food.[104]

This response to requests for individual Grocery Supports does not appear to be consistent with November 2024 and January 2025 CHRT rulings on Jordan's Principle. Those rulings clarified that "it is appropriate [for ISC] to refer the family to other non-discriminatory services, and if the services include barriers, to eliminate those barriers," but noted that this could only be done "once food or other basic necessities have been provided."[105] In many of the cases discussed by service coordinators and providers in Nunavut, children's immediate needs for food were not addressed, children were not referred to existing services, and families were charged with an ever-shifting and complicated set of administrative requirements even to have their cases considered.

"We had thought that it would be an immediate approval from ISC, because the letter of support came from a pediatrician, saying ... 'the child is losing weight, the child is in need of certain grocery items that the family cannot afford, and the child has now started a new medication that's impacting [their] appetite, which the family has stopped because they can't let the child lose any more weight,' and that is sitting in escalation for the last three weeks."

KEY INFORMANT 8

Growing Leaves and Berries

Positive Impacts of the HFV

In this chapter, we draw on interviews with families and key informants, along with analysis of administrative data — on purchases made with ICFI-funded Grocery Supports, health outcomes, and school attendance — and results from other studies, to document the positive impacts of the HFV on families in Qikiqtaaluk. Note that, though we asked specifically about impacts of the HFV in interviews, we cannot systematically distinguish effects of the HFV from effects of more targeted individual Grocery Supports or other, concurrent, food-related programs.

The HFV appears to have:

- **Reduced hunger:** Interview participants spoke of a reduction in, and often an end to, days when they had to skip meals or go without food. Data and media accounts from organizations providing meals to those in need also suggest that demand decreased while the HFV was operating and increased afterwards.
- **Increased nutrition:** Interview participants noted that the HFV allowed, and required, them to purchase healthy food and spoke of the positive impacts for their families. Similarly, 85% of people responding to a survey in Pangnirtung said that vouchers allowed them to feed their children more healthy food. These accounts are

supported by quantitative data on purchases made using ICFI-funded individual Grocery Supports: 62% of items bought using ICFI-funded individual Grocery Supports were eligible for NNC subsidies. In addition, monthly data on community-level shipments from Nutrition North Canada indicate an 11.5% overall increase in the volume of NNC subsidized shipments (healthy foods and infant products) by air following community HFV adoption: infant products increased 36.6%, fruits and vegetables increased 14.4%, dairy increased 11.9% and fish/meat/eggs increased 9.0%.

- **Improved physical health:** Across the Qikiqtaaluk region, children aged 24–59 months whose hemoglobin levels were tested had lower hemoglobin levels and were more likely to have anemia after the HFV ended than during the HFV program.
- **Improved mental health and quality of life:** Interview participants talked about the reduced stress and improved mental health for themselves, their children and other family members. Some also mentioned that their children had more energy to go to school. We analyzed school attendance data for a generalized effect and, though a short-term (few months) increase was visible in graphs of attendance patterns, we did not find a significant, sustained effect on attendance in more formal analyses.
- **Given individuals and organizations greater resources for other things:** Both individual interview participants and key informants talked about the HFV freeing community members and organizations from a constant focus on meeting the basic physical need for food. Families were able to start paying down debt, saving for harvesting equipment, addressing other family needs and experiencing greater enjoyment; service providers spoke of being able to support families in those efforts.

Reduced hunger

46 of 47 interview participants talked about the food vouchers as helping reduce hunger and/or allowing their families to eat more satisfying and healthy foods (the remaining participant felt she was able to manage food for her family without the vouchers but said they did allow her to buy more, needed household supplies). The $500 per month per child (and $250 additional each month for children under age 4) provided through the HFV program (or Grocery Supports) was not enough to fully meet the needs of every family; some still had days in the month when they skipped meals or went without food. However, for many participants, the support provided by the HFV program was enough to keep food on the table throughout the month and even stock snacks for their children. For others, it greatly reduced the number of days that they struggled, increasing their abilities to feed their families more regularly and sufficiently.

"With that JP account, we had good food, enough food, and my kids would say that thanks JP 'cause they knew the kitchen was full of food … they were eating healthy and they didn't miss a supper."

INTERVIEW 5

"We got to eat every day, I mean, more than once a day."

INTERVIEW 3

"It made us have meals without me having to worry about when or where I am going to get the next meal."

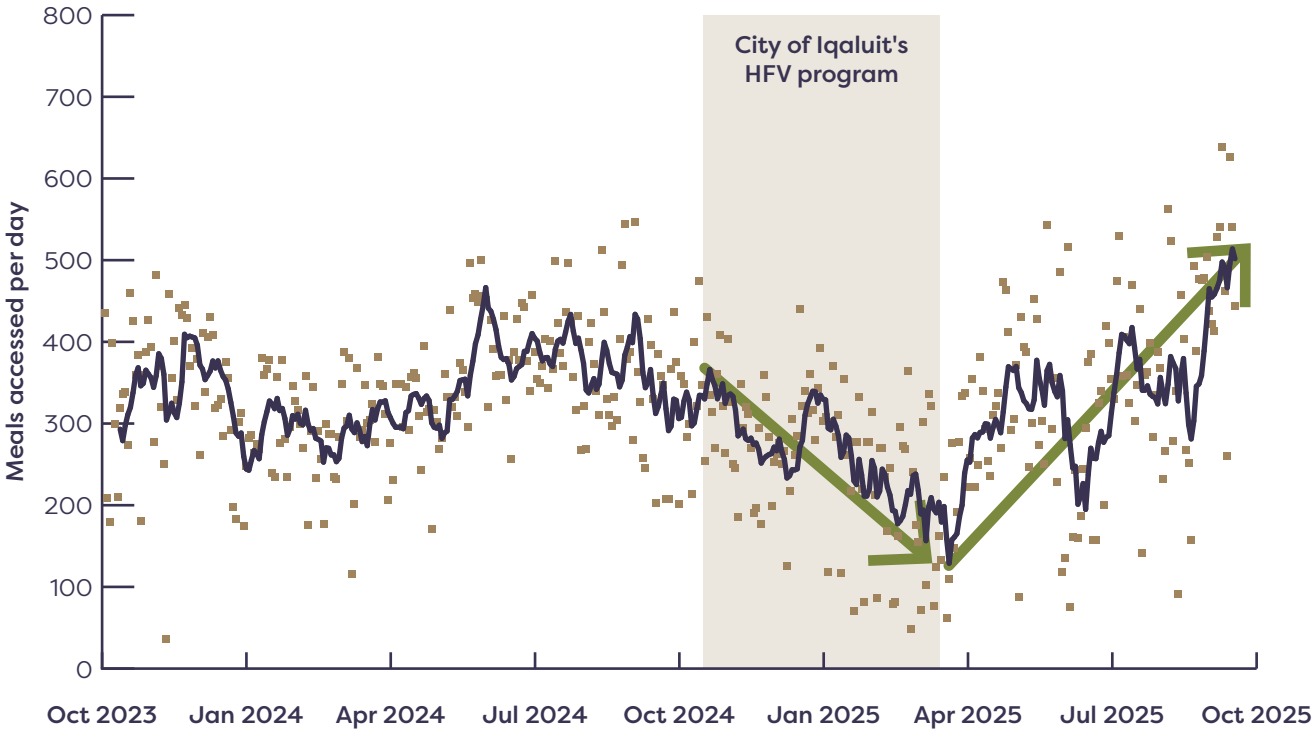
INTERVIEW 11

At the collective level, the strongest quantitative evidence of ICFI's impact on hunger comes from Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre, the largest community food program in Nunavut. Located in Iqaluit, Qajuqturvik serves more than 600 free meals on its busiest days, providing lunch to ~8% of the community. Figure 8 shows the number of meals accessed at Qajuqturvik between September 24, 2023 and September 24, 2025. There was a steady reduction in the number of meals accessed between November 2024, when the HFV was implemented in Iqaluit, and March 2025, when the HFV came to an end. In the year following the HFV end, the number of meals accessed rose steadily, expanding beyond the average number of meals served before the HFV was in place.[106]

FIGURE 8

Demand for meals at Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre declined during the HFV and rose steadily after its end

Daily meals accessed (Sept 24, 2023–Sept 24, 2025)



Line represents 7-observation rolling mean; brown squares are daily non-zero, weekday meal totals.

Gilbert, S. (2025, September 26). Surging food insecurity crisis [Press conference presentation]. Press conference hosted by Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre and Arctic Children & Youth Foundation, Iqaluit, NU, Canada.

"Everything was perfect. With the funding we had, we wouldn't go a day with being hungry, and every day my son's diapers and formulas would last for a whole month, and I wouldn't have had to worry about them. It was very good to have that."

INTERVIEW 2

"We would eat three meals a day when there was Jordan's Principle. It was very helpful in many ways."

INTERVIEW 12

"In the beginning, [when the program stopped] we had to try and get ourselves used to not having constant availability of food. And then we're practically back to used to it."

INTERVIEW 7

Media accounts and reports from interview participants told a similar story. For example, the coordinator of the Cambridge Bay Wellness Centre Food Bank reported that the number of families depending on the food bank when the HFV program ended increased to 489, roughly 1/3 of the Inuit households in the hamlet. He noted, "We don't have that big of a budget that we can sustain those numbers."[107] In addition, a Senior Administrative Officer we interviewed noted that she had been in ongoing discussion with school officials in her hamlet, and they reported that "the number of students at both schools, not having anything to eat, rose instantly when Jordan's Principle stopped." She noted the breakfast program got busy right away, and more students came to school without eating lunch.

"Before the introduction of the ICFI food voucher program, families struggled to access food for their children ... We have a food kitchen that the Hamlet helps financially ... They prepare some meals, and by the time it's like four o'clock, they ... [have] often exhausted its food supplies. However, since the CFI program launched, the soup kitchen now operates once a week, and still, leftovers are consistently available. [Before] there were a lot of people that posted on Facebook asking for help with food or if they can invite their children over for some meals. We've been seeing a lot of less of those posts."

KEY INFORMANT 14



Increased nutrition

Alongside discussions of having more food and less hunger, interview participants also talked about being more able to buy healthy food. Many noted that healthy foods tend to be more expensive than junk food and talked about buying healthy foods — fruits, vegetables, and meats — in quantities that they couldn't otherwise afford. They emphasized that, without the food vouchers, they were often unable to afford these foods. Some also noted that they were only allowed to spend HFV funds on "healthy foods," noting that local restrictions (discussed further in Chapter 7) both kept them from buying some items that their families really wanted and encouraged them to try new foods. These qualitative accounts match survey data from an evaluation of the HFV program in Pangnirtung: 85% of respondents said the HFV program allowed them to feed their children healthier food.[108]

> "[The vouchers meant] eating healthy. Eating healthy and eating every day."
>
> **INTERVIEW 13**

> "If I told [the kids] that the card was loaded … they would get excited and look at the price tag if it has an NNC on it."
>
> **INTERVIEW 4**

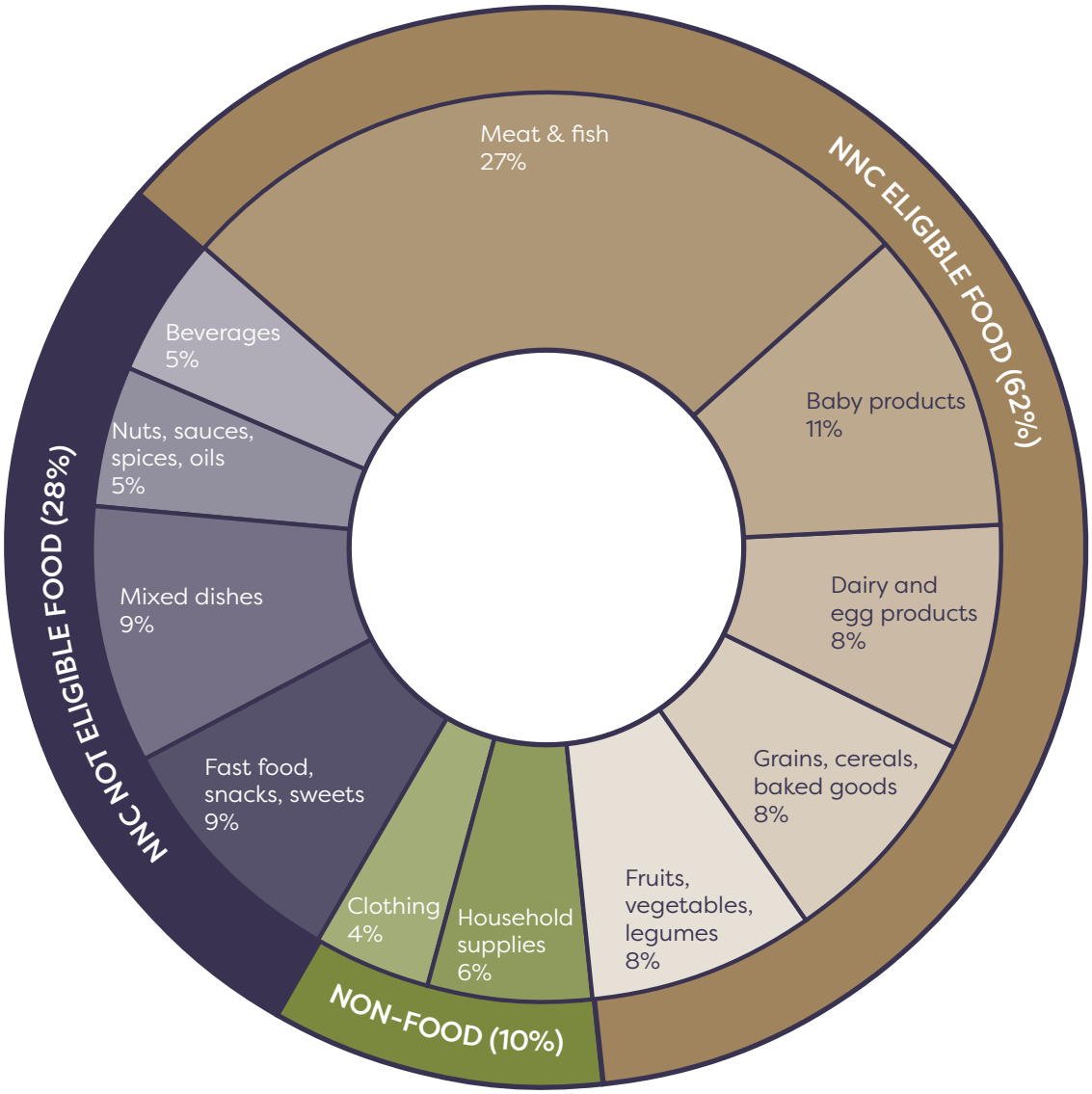
In addition, as shown in Figure 9, data on the purchases made using Grocery Supports in Qikiqtaaluk show that 62% of expenditures were on items considered "healthy" by NNC. Of these expenditures, 27% of expenditures were on meat. Only 28% of expenditures were for foods in categories like (non-dairy/non-juice) beverages, sweets, snacks, mixed dishes, and fast food that are usually inelgible for any type of subsidy. Another 10% were on clothing and household supplies, and the remainder (35%) was spent on fruits, vegetables, grain/cereal products, dairy/egg products, and baby products.[I]

[I] An important limitation of these data is that they only reflect purchases made with grocery supports, and do not reflect purchases made with personal income from other sources. For example, ISC prohibited the purchase of tobacco using food voucher funds, and most hamlets prohibited the purchase of items like pop and chips (see Chapter 7 for a discussion of these policies). Accordingly, they showed up minimally in the grocery supports data, but families could purchase such items using income from employment, alternate government programs (e.g. income support), or other sources

FIGURE 9

62% of Grocery Support Expenditures were on 'Healthy Foods'

Analysis of ICFI-funded Grocery Supports receipt data



Sinha, V., Li, N., Wheatley, D., Hoang, N, et al. (2025) *Preliminary findings from an evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Qikiqtaaluk. Qupanuaq.*

Data on shipments of subsidized products to communities from Nutrition North Canada also show that the HFV led to substantial improvements in nutrition and spending on subsidized products. We compared changes in shipments in the months after a community adopted the HFV to changes in shipments in communities that had yet to adopt the HFV. We focus on subsidized air shipments since they are more likely to respond quickly than subsidized sealift shipments that only change once a year.

"When we get vouchers, I usually buy fruits and vegetables and meats."

INTERVIEW 10

"Fresh fruits, fresh vegetables, those are costly ... Since they stopped, I started buying only frozen vegetables."

INTERVIEW 24

Our estimates indicate that HFV adoption led to an 11.4% increase in the volume of NNC subsidized shipments by air. There was variation across categories of items purchased: infant products increased 40%, fruits and vegetables increased 14.5%, dairy increased 12.8%, fish/meat/eggs increased 8.5%, and there were no significant changes in grain shipments (~1%). The magnitude of these changes is broadly similar, in terms of the kilograms of shipments per dollar, to findings from a recent study that estimated the impacts of increases in Canada Child Benefit payments, a cash transfer.[109] Our estimates thus confirm that regardless of whether households with children are targeted with cash or restricted-use vouchers, the effects on consumption of NNC subsidized food and infant products are similar and substantial.

Improved physical health

Caregivers and key informants described positive physical impacts for children receiving HFVs and/or Grocery Supports: their kids were sick less often, visited the health centre less and had more energy to go to school. Some interview participants also noted that elders in their families were more active.

The physical health impacts were even more pronounced for children who experienced severe food insecurity or had underlying health conditions. In particular, service providers and coordinators spoke of specific cases in which they could see direct impacts of ICFI-funded food supports. These were cases in which children's ICFI-supported food access was disrupted, either because they moved back and forth between the homes of caregivers who had food vouchers or Grocery Supports and those that did not, or because the support itself was disrupted due to delays in processing renewal requests or shifts in administrative procedures. In these cases, service providers/coordinators noted that children's health outcomes declined when they lost access to food supports and improved again once food supports were available.

"[with the voucher, my kids] were getting less sick ... I've noticed that a lot; they stopped being sick. They go less to the health centre."

INTERVIEW 12

"The child wasn't having enough to eat, would be skipping meals. We got grocery supports, and you could see on his growth curve that it went from a dip to back up. And so, clearly, there was substantial nutritional deficiency there that was rectified."

KEY INFORMANT 6

"When her grocery supports are provided, her glucose levels and range are stable, and her levels are constantly the same. When those items are not provided ... her levels go down ... her physical health is drastically impacted when those grocery supports are not available to her"

KEY INFORMANT 8

In addition, the health effects of the HFV were seen in our analysis of hemoglobin and anemia status, which are critical markers of pediatric health. Iron-deficiency anemia in early childhood has significant effects on children's health, particularly on neurodevelopment, cognitive function, motor development and behaviour, as well as poor growth, increased susceptibility to infections and impaired exercise capacity. Nunavut has among the highest rates of infant iron-deficiency anemia in Canada; the Government of Nunavut's estimates that 30% of Nunavut infants are affected by iron deficiency, citing low socioeconomic status and delayed introduction of iron-rich solid foods as major risk factors.[110]

"I've had lots of families come to me and say it's really been life changing ... if you have a child with a medical condition, your priority is going to be to feed that child ... if you don't have to worry about three meals a day, you can focus on other things, in particular, other aspects of health."

KEY INFORMANT 9

To test the possibility that, by helping families access iron-rich foods, the HFV reduced iron deficiency rates, we analyzed hemoglobin screening data from the Qikiqtaaluk region. The Government of Nunavut's Iron Deficiency Anemia protocol involves routine finger- or heel-prick hemoglobin screening (HemoCue) for all children at well-child visits from 6 months to 2–3 years of age.[111] We analyzed HemoCue data from January 1, 2023 through April 30, 2026 to assess the impact of the HFV program on children's health. In models that controlled for calendar month, community, and child age, we compared anemia and hemoglobin levels for 1–4 year olds who had HemoCue tests before, during, and after the HFV.

We did not find a statistically significant change in anemia or hemoglobin levels when

we looked at all children who were tested.[m] However, when we divided the sample in two groups along anemia thresholds[n] — 12–23 month olds (meaning 1 year olds) and 24–59 month olds (2–4 year olds) — we found that 2–4 year olds had 52% higher adjusted odds of anemia[o] and 2.1g/L lower mean adjusted hemoglobin levels after the HFV ended than during the program. These negative changes in their health were at or below the threshold for statistical significance (p=0.04 and 0.05, respectively), meaning they are relatively reliable estimates. While the hemoglobin difference is modest at the individual level, it is meaningful at a population scale because the average hemoglobin in this age group was close to the anemia threshold and this type of small downward shift could move children who were just above the anemia threshold into the anemic range.

There were no statistically significant differences for the tested 1-year olds, possibly because children of this age often consume iron-fortified formula. Because formula tends to be prioritized within household budgets and is available independently of HFV through NIHB and health centres for at least a subset of infants who qualify, 1-year olds may have continued to consume formula after the end of the HFV. In contrast, by 2 or 3 years of age, most children transition to cow's milk, a well-established driver of iron deficiency.[112] Cow's milk-dependent children rely on iron-rich foods like meat to keep their hemoglobin levels high and, without an iron-fortified beverage to offset the loss of iron-rich foods or an alternate program to subsidize these purchases, the end of the HFV may have hit this older group harder.

Improved mental health and quality of life

Several interviewees spoke about their improved mental state when discussing impacts of the HFV program. Parents and grandparents said that, while the program was running, they were happier because they were better able to feed everyone in their households. They contrasted this with the stress of constantly having to work to stretch their budgets and of having to look for or ask for help from others.

> "[Before, people] have their money just to survive. Now they have some money to express themselves, to enjoy themselves, and that's a good thing. We all need that."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 16**

[m] We were not provided data on tested infants 6–11 months old.

[n] Hemoglobin cutoffs for anemia of 105 for 12–23 month olds and 110 g/L for 24–59 month olds.

[o] Odds compare the chance that something happens to the chance that it does not happen. For instance, if 30% of tested children at time point A have anemia, the odds are 30/70, or 0.43. An odds ratio compares those odds across two groups or time periods. An odds ratio of 1.50 comparing time point B with time point A would mean 50% higher odds at time point B. Continuing the example in odds terms, this would increase from 30/70 (or 0.43) to 45/70 (or 0.64).

Service coordinators and providers also spoke of positive impacts that were noticeable from the outset of the HFV program. One recalled the excitement in the community on day one of the HFV program, observing that the program made a difference by relieving people's stress. A grocery store manager/employee contextualized this further, describing the HFV-related economic shift for families as allowing them to move beyond an overwhelming focus on basic physical needs, towards centring personal growth and realizing their full potential.[113]

"It was helpful because there are times when either my mom or my sister or me don't eat so that the kids can eat. And then when we started receiving help from Jordan's Principal, my mom became happier, healthier, and more active because we were now able to afford food for everybody."

INTERVIEW 9

Several interviewees also noted that there was less tension between family members when there was enough food for everyone. Some explicitly described the toll that the stress of hunger took on the patience and outlook of particular family members. A service provider also connected the vouchers with reducing stress related to financial burden. They noted that this was particularly true for the parents of babies, for whom food vouchers reduced the stress associated with buying expensive items like formula and diapers, and shared a case in which the provision of Grocery Supports seemed to reduce domestic violence within a household.

"It made me ease down … It made me know that I will be able to buy food because I have an account from JP that can buy me food. And that made my mind calm down. That made me happier and not having to look for somewhere or from someone having to ask them."

INTERVIEW 7

Key informants also spoke of reduced stress for children and youth. One shared that a principal of a local school told her they saw a reduction in fighting once the HFV program started and school food programs expanded. In complement, some interviewees spoke of increased behaviour problems once the HFV program ended, pointing to youth setting fires, shoplifting, and acting out in other ways. Many interviewees talked about their children feeling happier and having more energy. Some noted that their children were fighting less and were more willing to go to school when they were eating well.

"It did really help with, our mental state of mind ... for me and my kids, they were a lot more happier when JP was running ... And I noticed that after getting that referral, [my youngest daughter's] loud and sassy personality became more so I'm thankful for opportunities like that."

INTERVIEW 29

We examined administrative data on attendance at schools in Qikiqtaaluk, from August 2022 to March 2026, to assess whether there was any observable impact of HFV implementation on attendance rates.[p] Attendance data can be difficult to analyze because of gaps for summer and other breaks, missing data, and the possibility of other events such as illness, weather, school and community events, and other factors. In a descriptive analysis that grouped schools by grade level, school attendance appeared to rise in the first 3 months of HFV rollout; however, this effect was not sustained. In addition, a model controlling for differences between community, month, and other key variables did not identify a statistically significant relationship between HFV and school attendance.

"[If] you can relieve the financial burden and the stress on some of these parents, then you eliminate some of the domestic violence, you eliminate some of the trauma ... it just it helps make an overall better-rounded family."

KEY INFORMANT 11

"I have a son who can eat good, and when we're out of food, he's barely happy, like, it really affects all of us. Well, we don't say it much, but everything's annoying to him. He's not very happy and argues here and there with the girlfriend."

INTERVIEW 6

[p] Because the start and end dates of HFV differed between communities, we aligned the monthly data around the first month of HFV implementation to analyze attendance trends prior to HFV implementation, during HFV, and after the HFV end. We grouped schools by grade-level (K–5/K–6, 6–12/7–12, and K–12) and excluded schools in Iqaluit from analysis of the other Qikiqtaaluk communities. Iqaluit was excluded because the HFV began later and lasted only 5 months and it has larger, more urban school system as compared to the other communities in the region.

Greater resources for other things

By providing funds to buy food, the HFV program allowed participants to use their incomes to cover other costs that were previously difficult to manage. Participants said the HFVs allowed them to pay essential bills, such as utilities and rent, pay down debts, and buy needed items like equipment for country food harvesting and warm clothing for their children. While they noted that the HFV program and Grocery Supports were insufficient to address underlying issues that led to food insecurity, key informants discussed cases in which they provided families with the additional assistance needed to move out of precarious situations. They gave examples that highlighted not only the financial benefits, but also the relief from stress that could allow families to focus on things like applying for jobs, working on housing applications, or paying down debts.

"[With the HFV, my kids] weren't lazy to go to school. They weren't lazy to wake up to getting ready to be in school."

INTERVIEW 12

"Once the JP stopped, I was like, 'I'm back to my routine'. Make sure we have for enough food for two weeks or ... I was, I mean, how would I explain it? I was more looking into my budget than the job."

INTERVIEW 45

"Jordan's Principle helped us a lot with our food. It also made us be able to get more supplies that are not food-related: bathroom supplies, fuel for the skidoo ... It helped us be less impoverished, is how I'd say it."

INTERVIEW 11

"We were catching up [on] our bills, and it was awesome."

INTERVIEW 3

Thus, though the official goal of the HFV program was to support the purchase of nutritious foods for Inuit children, the reality was that recipients had much more to consider than simply feeding their children; they were working to cover multiple necessary expenses while also addressing the needs of their extended family and community networks. The HFV helped, but it could not eliminate the financial struggles of all families. A survey of 78 people participating in the Pangnirtung HFV program found that, while a greater proportion of participants reported they were always or almost always able to pay all their bills once the program started (58% during the program vs. 38% before), more than 40% of respondents were still only "sometimes or never able to pay all their bills."[114]

Multiple key informants, working across service domains, also spoke of the reduction in burden on previously overwhelmed local services and supports. They noted that even organizations like Child and Family Services,

whose missions were not explicitly food security related, previously took responsibility for feeding people. The HFV program freed these organizations to do more targeted work in line with their missions/mandates.

With the end of the HFV programs and the severe restrictions on Grocery Supports, families and communities had to readjust. Interviewees spoke of falling behind on bills again, the stress associated with mounting debt, and the sadness of not being able to afford the clothes, toys, and other small items that the food vouchers enabled them to purchase.

"Having help from Jordan's Principal for food, I was able to buy more clothes for my kids. I was able to help with school activities that they needed, and especially outside wear, mainly boots and shoes are very expensive here, and I was able to buy all my kids' warm clothes and warm outerwear jeans."

INTERVIEW 9

"In my office, when I was with Family Services, we ran a food pantry basically off the side of our desk, because food insecurity was so high, and that doesn't exist anymore, because there's no longer that dire need, because people are getting food."

KEY INFORMANT 8



Keeping Stems Strong

Understanding the Economic Impacts of the HFV

In this chapter, we examine concerns about the economic impact of the HFV, exploring whether the program was linked to increases in grocery prices or changes in the use of territorial Income Assistance.

At the end of 2024, Nunavut leadership expressed worries that the HFV might be driving steep increases in grocery prices. We examined that possibility and found that HFV had little, if any, effect.

Between 2022 and 2024, grocery prices around the world rose markedly. The increase was even larger in Nunavut. This was primarily due to rising freight costs. Most of this increase occurred before the first HFV was adopted, and communities that adopted the HFV early did not experience price increases that were much larger than those in other Nunavut communities that had yet to adopt the HFV.

In addition, statements by federal officials suggest concerns that the HFV would 'displace' (or serve as an alternative to) targeted programs like territorial Income Assistance. We examined that possibility and found the program had little, if any, effect on Income Assistance use. Use of Income Assistance has been steadily rising since the discontinuation of COVID-era income benefits, and this pattern continued through the period of HFV implementation.

Grocery price inflation

As discussed in Chapter 3, as a result of the infrastructure gaps, vast distances and limited competition, grocery prices in Nunavut are very high. However, because it is not practical to track the prices of all items that are bought or sold in a region, precisely measuring the difference between prices in Nunavut and other parts of Canada is difficult. As a result, every study is based on choices about what products to include in price measures, and how to deal with the fact that some items may be purchased more often, or in greater quantities, than others. When it comes to examining changes over time, choices about what time period to consider are also important. A partner report, which can be found here,[q] systematically explores Nunavut grocery prices and growth in prices (inflation) using all available datasets: ICFI-funded Grocery Supports receipts, the Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB), the Nunavut Price Survey, and government cost-of-living measures. Overall conclusions based on the comparison of different data sets are consistent: prices are higher in Nunavut (at least 50% higher) than the rest of Canada and have grown more quickly than southern prices for comparable products in recent years.[115]

In this report, we summarize key findings from analysis of both receipt data from ICFI-funded individual Grocery Supports expenditures and data from the Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB), a NNC measure reported for all Nunavut communities. The ICFI data includes prices of the products that were actually purchased by families receiving Grocery Supports in Qikiqtaaluk between 2022 and June 2024. Our analysis uses the largest set of products that can be matched within community over time (for inflation estimates) or matched with Southern counterparts at a given point in time (for calculation of price ratios) and reflects the actual amount of each product that families purchased.[r] In addition, we created an ICFI basket of 86 products that were consistently purchased using ICFI vouchers and could be matched to identical barcode products in a Southern price data set collected by BetterCart Analytics. The RNFB data estimates the cost of a 67-product basket of goods that represents one week of food for a family of four. NNC provides data for 21 communities for every quarter from 2011 up to March 2025.[s]

As depicted in Figure 10, RNFB data show that food price growth in Nunavut has exceeded that in the South over the last decade, and especially in recent years, leading to a growing price gap. For example, from March 2021 to March 2025, average RNFB prices in 10 Qikiqtaaluk communities rose by 45%, compared to 21% for a comparable basket of Southern foods. (For 21 Nunavut communities, prices rose by 39% during the same time period.)

[q] https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

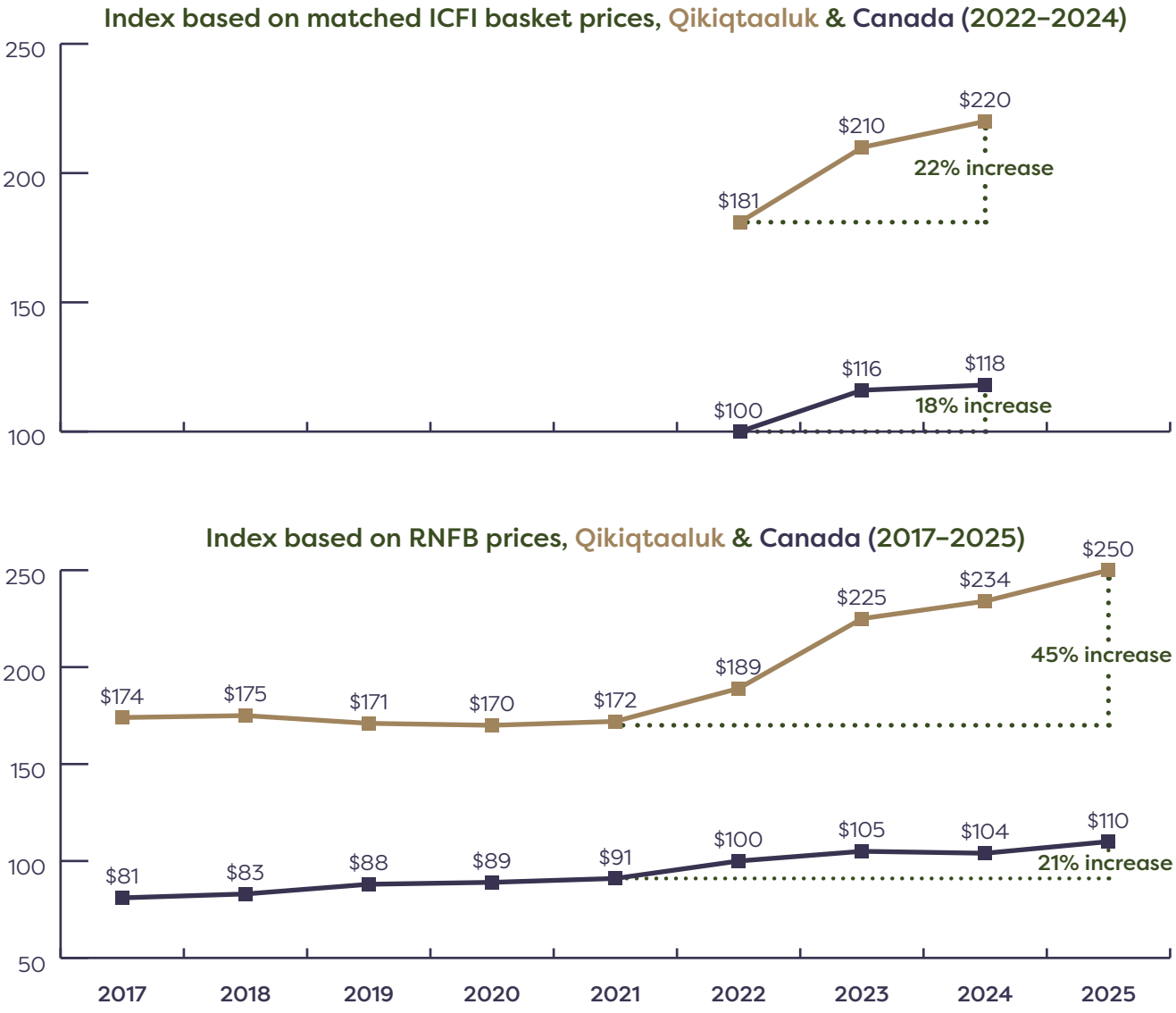
[r] Accordingly, the number of products and communities varies across comparisons.

[s] Communities with only an Arctic Co-Operatives store (Grise Fiord, Resolute, Kugaaruk, and Whale Cove) are not included until October 2023 so we exclude them from analysis of inflation over longer periods.

FIGURE 10

Prices are higher and rising faster in Qikiqtaaluk than in the South

RNFB data (2017–2025) and ICFI-funded Grocery Supports data (2022–2024)



Li, N., Morgan, R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) *Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025.*

Grocery Supports receipt data for Qikiqtaaluk imply that the cost of the most comprehensive and representative basket of products purchased with ICFI Grocery Supports rose by 26.5% from early-2022 to mid-2024. Considering only the 86 products purchased consistently over time and precisely matched to their southern counterparts, prices rose by 22% while the cost of matched products in the South rose by 18%. The same data imply that the price of this basket rose from 1.81 to 1.87 times the price of the same basket of goods in the South.[116]

The ICFI and grocery price inflation

At the end of 2024, leaders in Nunavut raised concerns about rising retail grocery prices.[117] They wondered if this inflation (rise in prices) could be tied to the implementation of the HFV program and called for an "audit" of retail prices. Their concerns resonated with findings in existing research. One recent study found that when average federal child benefits increased by $1500 per tax filer in 2016, prices rose 1–3% in Northern communities that had only one or two stores (the estimated increase in Nunavut was closer to 1%).[118] Prices may have increased because retailers took the opportunity to increase their profit margins due to higher demand, but price increases could also reflect other factors. For example, if people suddenly started buying more and stores used up their inventories, the stores might have to place new orders sooner than expected. These new orders might have to come by air freight instead of the less expensive sealift, or they might reflect recent wholesale price increases that had yet to be passed through to retail prices (i.e., Southern inflation), driving up prices on the shelf.

In addition, the introduction of HFV programs beginning in 2023 coincided with a period of abnormally high food inflation and freight costs across Canada and the rest of the world. This makes it difficult for both shoppers and researchers to assess how much the HFV program could have contributed to inflation, especially if its contribution was small.

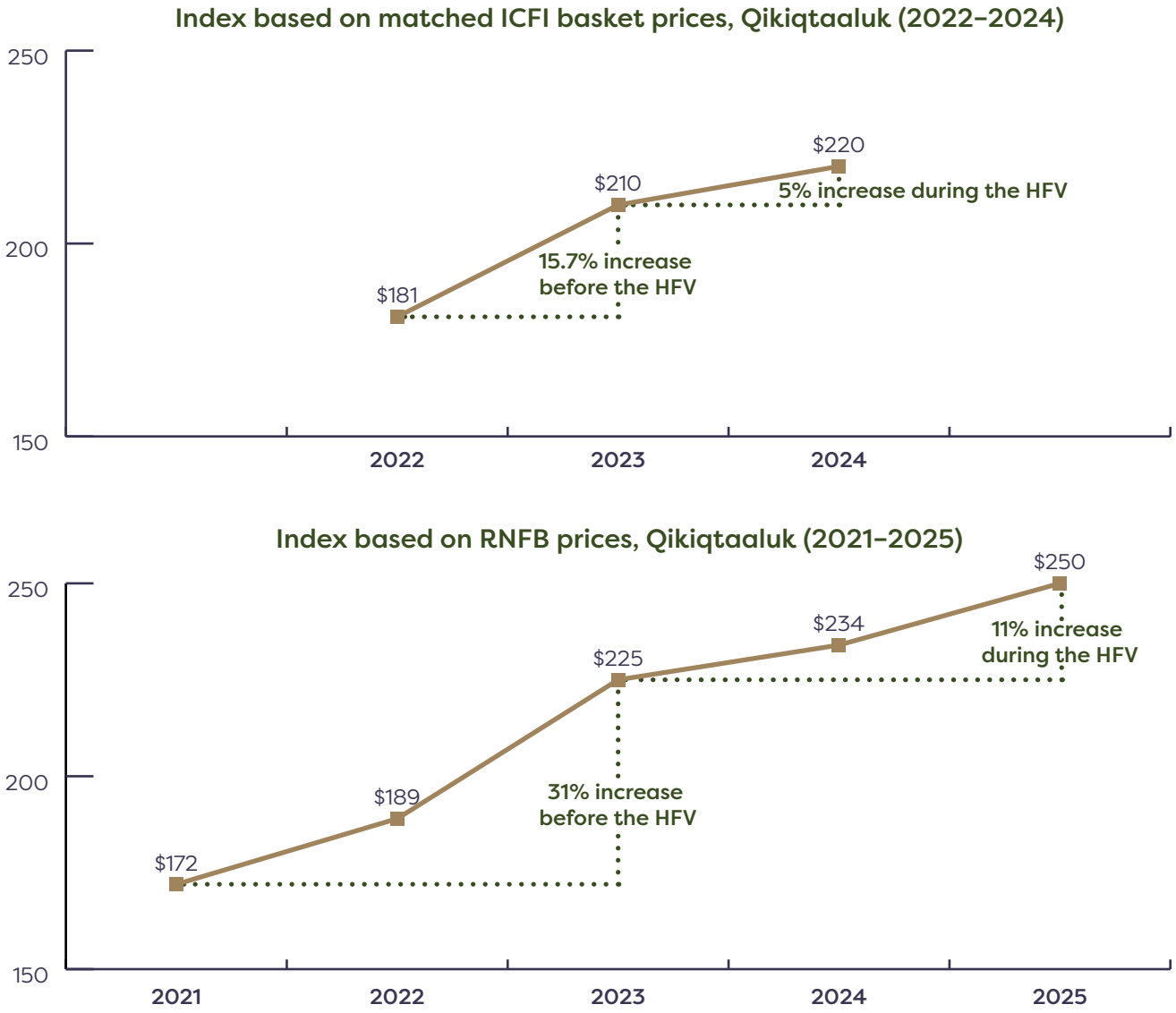
> "We have heard before that the prices will go higher ... Our great-grandmother will tell us that the price, it will go higher in the future, to prepare us."
>
> **INTERVIEW 20**

We assessed the contribution of the HFV to grocery price inflation using two methods, drawing on two different data sets. First, we compared inflation in the period before any HFV programs were introduced with inflation in the period after. As summarized in Figure 11, grocery receipt data from ICFI indicates a 15.7% increase in food prices from January 2022 to June 2023 (before the first Hamlet voucher program was introduced) and a 5.0% increase in food prices from June 2023 through June 2024. (Using the most comprehensive and representative basket of products, we estimate 17.4% inflation from January 2022 to June 2023 and 7.4% inflation from June 2023 through June 2024). The majority of the inflation in Qikiqtaaluk for the products we observe occurred before any communities had adopted the HFV program. Similarly, NNC data on RNFB costs, which is available for a longer time period, implies that prices increased by 31% from March 2021 to March 2023, the two-year period before the phase-in of the HFV program, and 11% from March 2023 to March 2025, the two-year period during which the voucher was phased-in (for Nunavut as a whole, RNFB inflation was 32% and 6% during the same periods).[119]

FIGURE 11

Prices in Qikiqtaaluk rose more in 2021–2023 than in 2023–2025

RNFB data (2021–2025) and ICFI-funded Grocery Supports data (2022–2024)



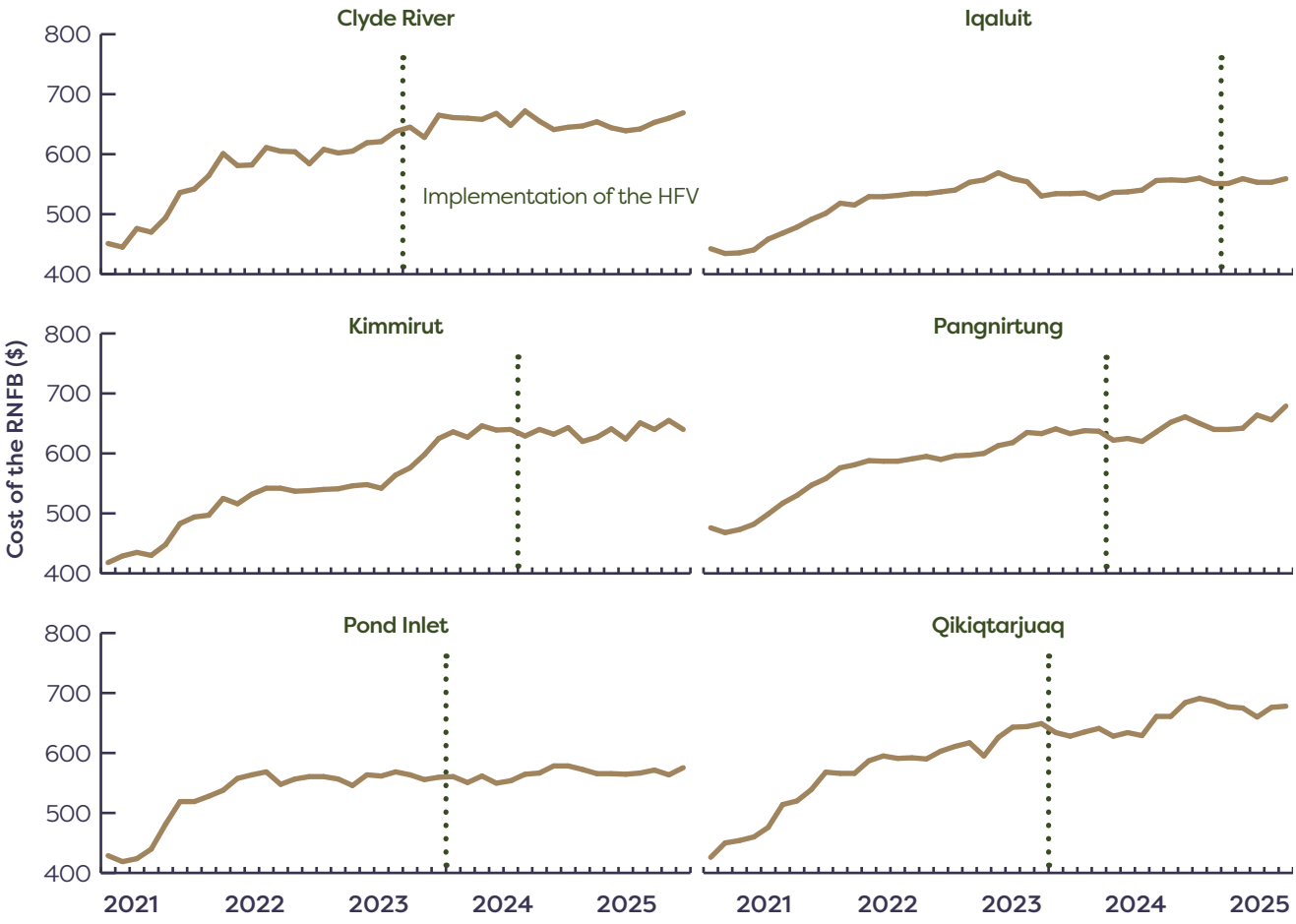
Li, N., Morgan, R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) *Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025.*

This before-and-after analysis can also be assessed on a community-by-community basis. Figure 12 provides an illustration for six Qikiqtaaluk communities that adopted the HFV at various times, including early adopters like Clyde River and Pond Inlet and late adopters like Iqaluit. The graphs present the cost of the RNFB over time. The vertical line indicates when the HFV program was adopted by a hamlet. Observe that some communities experienced price increases after the adoption of the HFV, while others experienced minimal price changes or even price decreases. But in all cases, the vast majority of the price increase occurred in the 2022 to mid-2023 period.

FIGURE 12

The price of a basket of food in Nunavut communities increased sharply before the HFV program

RNFB prices over time in 6 communities



Li, N., Morgan, R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) *Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025.*

The second method to assess whether HFVs contributed to price increases uses the staggered adoption of the program across communities as a "natural experiment." This method assumes that, without the HFV, Nunavut communities would have similar changes in food prices. It compares the change in average prices of the products purchased with vouchers or included in the RNFB in communities receiving the voucher ("treatment") with communities that have not yet received the voucher ("control") to estimate the "causal" effect of the HFV on prices. Note that our analysis does not assess the possibility that the HFV contributed to large price increases for some specific products, only whether it caused systematic increases in average prices. The analysis also generates a measure of the uncertainty associated with the estimate of the HFV's impact on prices.

Applying this method to ICFI receipt data yields an estimate of 0.3%. Taking the uncertainty in the estimate into account, the HFV could have driven a maximum 1.3% increase in prices. Applying it to RNFB data yields an estimate of 1.3%; with uncertainty accounted for, the HFV's maximum effect may have been increasing prices by up to 3.5%. In both cases, the estimates are small enough, and the uncertainty around those estimates is large enough that it is also possible the vouchers had no overall effect on inflation.

Thus, analysis of both datasets indicates that the HFV program was not a major contributor to overall inflation during this period. While we cannot rule out small but meaningful effects (i.e., up to a 3.5% contribution to inflation), they are dwarfed by the overall high inflation during this period (over 20%), which mostly occurred before any community had adopted the program. An important limitation of our analysis based on the ICFI data is that we only have data for Qikiqtaaluk communities. In addition, we do not have data tracking prices after mid-2024, and many Nunavut communities only started receiving vouchers after that.[t] However, the estimates using NNC RNFB data provide before and after data for all 24 Nunavut communities that adopted the program and also suggest a small or zero price effect.[120]

Other causes of inflation

If the HFV program was not the primary reason that food prices increased so much between 2022 and 2024, what was? Our partner report[u] on food prices in Nunavut systematically considers a wide range of possible causes for rising food prices. We briefly summarize those analyses here.

The price of a food product in Nunavut can be theoretically broken down into three components:

Nunavut Price =

Product wholesale cost

+ Freight cost (- the NNC subsidy)

+ Gross Margin (the cost of labour, energy, capital, management/corporate services and profit).

In terms of the recent increases in Nunavut prices, all three cost components played some role.

As noted earlier, there were substantial increases in retail prices in the South in 2022–2023. These increases were, in large part, due to wholesale cost increases, though rising retailer margins may also have played a role. However, these increases are not enough to explain why Nunavut prices in Nunavut increased more than prices in the South, exacerbating the already substantial gap in food prices. For example, we

[t] We did request updated data from ISC, but they were committed to other pressing priorities and did not have the capacity to prepare additional data in time for inclusion in this report. If/when such data become available, we plan to extend this analysis.

[u] https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

estimate that from March 2021 to March 2025, the average RNFB cost increased by $197 across 10 Qikiqtaaluk communities, while an equivalent basket in the South only increased by $49, which represents only 24.9% of the increase in RNFB cost. As discussed below, analysis of published air and ocean freight costs, NNC subsidy rates, and corporate financial reports suggest that freight costs (even after factoring NNC subsidies), higher gross margins (which partly reflect higher local operating costs), and higher net margins/profits all contributed to higher prices in Nunavut, with the latter playing a relatively small role on the order of 5% of the price difference.[121]

Freight costs

In 2022, a large jump in global freight costs (coinciding with the start of the war in Ukraine) helped drive Nunavut freight and food costs up further. Published costs of air freight to Nunavut (from Canadian North and Calm Air) rose 20–25% since 2021. While US air freight costs declined after the peak in late 2022/early 2023, air freight costs to Nunavut remained elevated: there was a notable surge in freight costs from 2021 to early 2023, followed by a slow but steady increase. Published ocean freight costs to Nunavut (from Desgagnes Transarctik and NEAS) rose about 25–30% since 2019: there were large increases between 2021–2022 and especially 2022–2023, followed by some decline. We believe that an increase in freight costs is the most important contributing factor to the 'excess' food inflation experienced in recent years. As detailed in the food price report,[v] NNC freight subsidy rates have not kept pace with these increases. Unlike its predecessor, the Food Mail program, which guaranteed a fixed freight cost, NNC does not link subsidies with actual freight costs; as a result, the modest increases in NNC subsidies that occurred in February 2023 did not fully offset these freight cost increases.

To provide a perspective on the relative contribution of freight costs, we estimate that the average cost of shipping the RNFB to Qikiqtaaluk by air (net of NNC subsidies) increased by $108 between March 2021 and March 2025, while the cost of shipping by the lowest-cost mode (i.e., assuming that 100% of non-perishables are shipped by sea, using the NNC surface transit subsidy) increased by $72. This represents between 36.5% and 54.8% of the total increase in RNFB costs. Combined, the Southern price increase and the increase in net freight account for 61.4–79.7% of the average increase in RNFB cost. Note that these calculations do not include increases in local costs, such as the increase in Nunavut's minimum wage from $16 to $19 in January 2024.[122]

Breaking these estimates down into the period before the HFV was phased in and the period during which the HFV was phased-in provides further insight. As shown in Figure 13, we estimate Southern RNFB prices rose $36 (15.6%) and air freight rose $90 (15.9%) during the March 2021 to March 2023 period, while NNC air subsidies rose

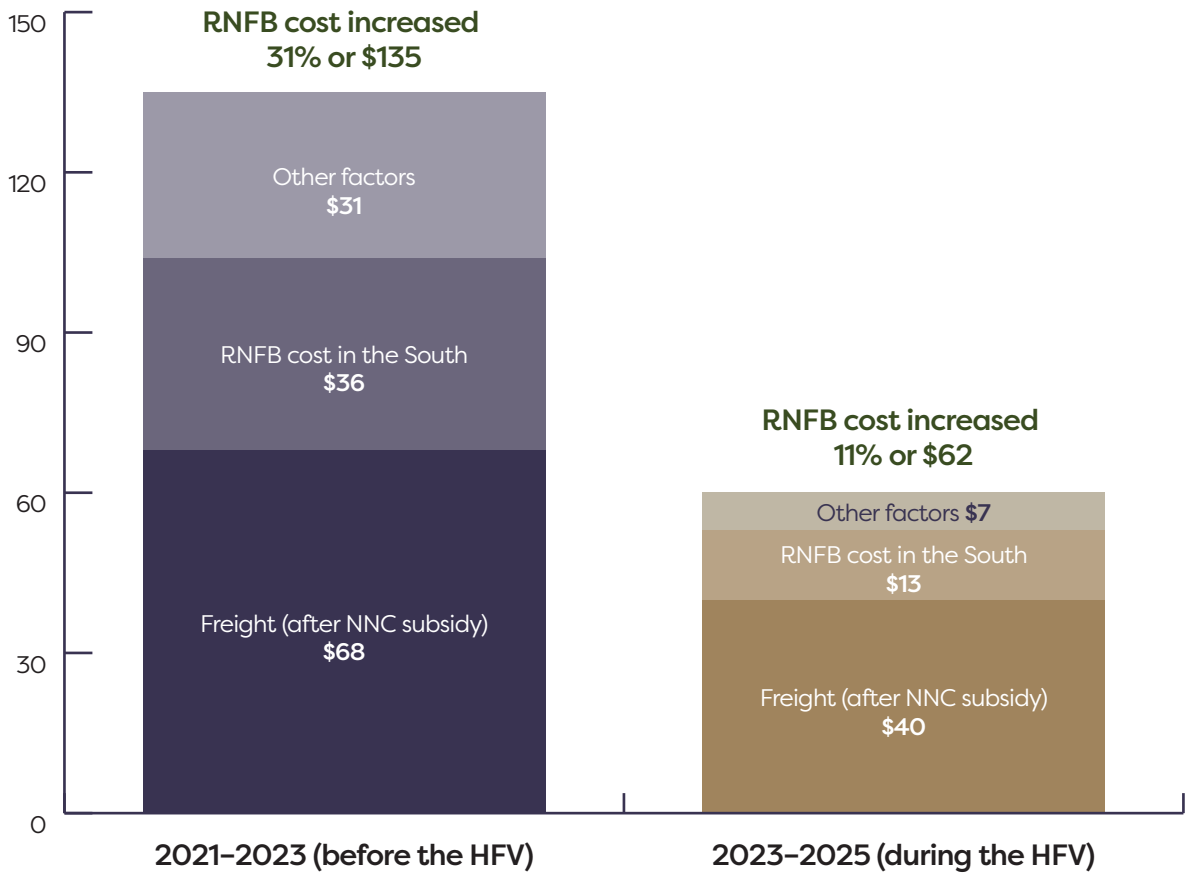
[v] https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

only $22 (6.9%). This implies that Southern price increases can account for 26.7% of the increase in Qikiqtaaluk prices and net freight cost increases (i.e., including NNC subsidy) can account for another 50.4%; combined, they can account for up to 77% of the price increase during this period. During the subsequent March 2023 to March 2025 period, RNFB costs in Qikiqtaaluk rose $62 (10.8%). During this period, Southern RNFB prices rose $13 (4.9%) and freight costs rose $40 (6.1%) while NNC subsidies were unchanged. During this later period, coinciding with ICFI-funded HFV phase-in across Qikiqtaaluk communities, Southern prices and freight costs can respectively account for 21% and 64.5% of the average price increase, and combined they can account for up to 85.5% of the average RNFB price increase.[123]

FIGURE 13

Increasing freight costs were the major driver of growth in Qikiqtaaluk food prices

Decomposition of RNFB price inflation (2021–2023 and 2023–2025)



Li, N., Morgan, R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) *Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025.*



Retailer profit

Analysis of corporate financial reports (annual reports for North West Company and the three major Canadian food retailers: Loblaws, Empire and Metro) suggests that retailer profit margins are slightly higher in the North than for other major Canadian food retailers.[w] Higher profits seem to account for about 5% of the higher prices (freight costs are responsible for much of the difference). In terms of inflation, margins in the North increased by 4–5% between 2018 and 2025, but most of the increase was prior to 2021. Margins only increased about 1% for Northern Canadian stores between 2022 and 2025 (the period when the ICFI-funded HFV program was phased in), and there was no major increase in gross or net margins coinciding with the period of peak inflation in 2022 and 2023.

However, even if the retailer margins stay about the same as a percentage, the retailers still make more profit as their costs and consumer prices increase. For example, if the wholesale and freight costs for a basket of goods were $100 in 2022 and the retailer charged a 10% margin, they got $10 in profits and the cost to the public was $110. If their costs increased to $140 in 2025 and they still charged a 10% margin, they would make $14 in profit. As a result, the cost to the public increases to $154. Thus, even a constant percentage profit margin amplifies the effect of higher wholesale or freight costs.

In sum, our analysis suggests that freight cost increases contributed a large share – perhaps more than half – to the price increases that occurred in recent years, while increases in product prices (proxied by retail inflation in the South) can account for much of the rest. The existing high level of retailer profitability may have amplified the effect of these cost increases on local prices, but the growth of retailer margins contributed little to inflation since 2021.

[w] An important limitation of this analysis is that we are not able to assess profits on a per-store basis, on a per-product basis (e.g. restricted to only ICFI eligible or food products) or restricted to Nunavut communities only.

"Displacing" Income Assistance

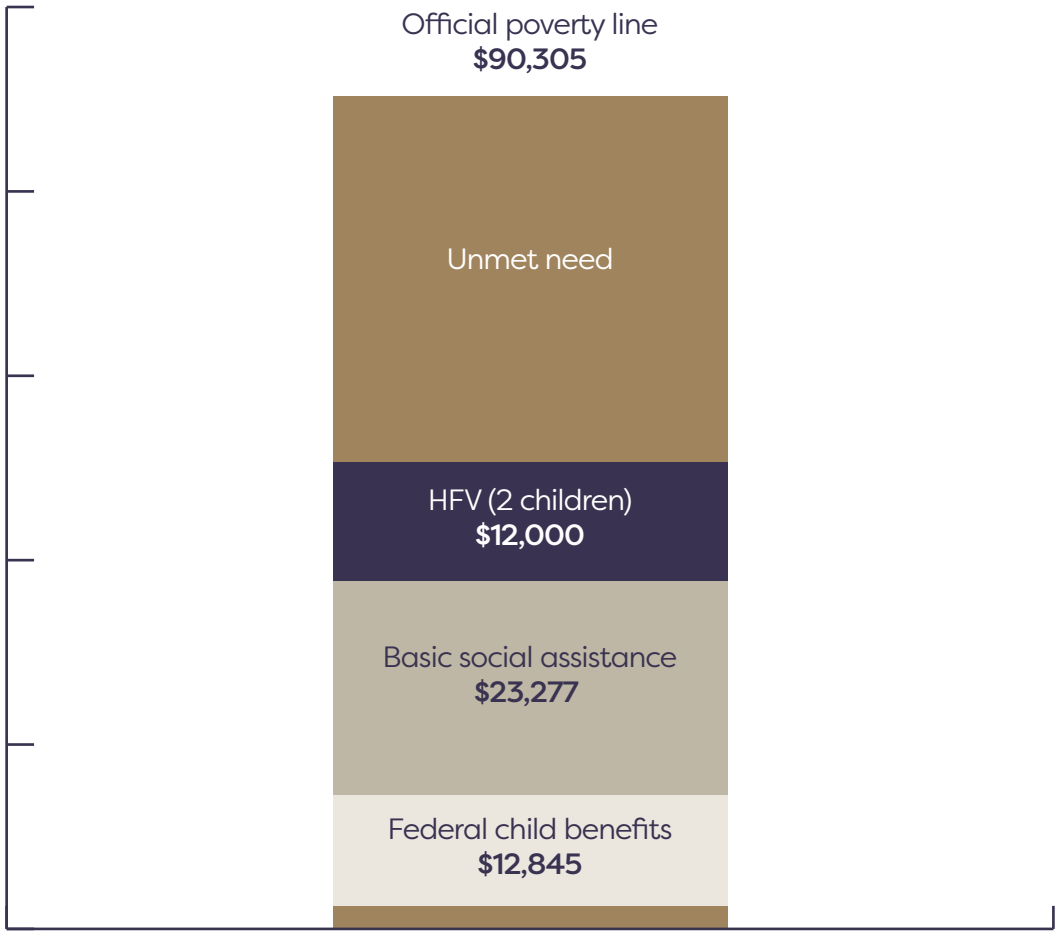
A second concern about the economic impact of the HFV was less clearly expressed than the worry that HFV might be driving food price inflation, but it can be seen in the connection between statements from ISC: a concern that people may be relying on ICFI-funded HFV supports in place of the Income Assistance provided to low-income households by the Government of Nunavut. One indication of this concern can be seen in an ISC statement cited in a CBC news article: "Indigenous Services Canada said the initiative was structured to provide temporary relief, rather than to displace government Income Assistance through "universal" programs like food vouchers."[124] This statement may be linked to the language of recent ISC denials of individual requests for ICFI-funded Grocery Supports, which note that "there are existing government programs and services in place to address the needs of the child" and that, as a result, the criteria for receipt of ICFI supports are not met. None of the service providers, service coordinators or family members that we spoke to could identify existing services or community supports that would meet the ongoing need for food of children living in households that struggled to make ends meet, and the ISC denials do not identify alternative services/supports. However, putting these two statements together, one possibility is that ISC sees Income Assistance as an existing program that could address the needs of children applying for Grocery Supports.

As noted in Chapter 3, Nunavut Income Assistance has restrictive rules that allow a head of household to have only $1000 in liquid assets and up to $700 in income before Income Assistance benefits are reduced.[125] Accordingly, HFV vouchers, which did not have these restrictions, might be seen as a less-restrictive alternative to income supports. However, as discussed in Chapter 3 and displayed in Figure 14, overall welfare benefits in Nunavut do not even cover half of the cost of a basic standard of living (the official poverty line). Even with the HFV payments added in, maximum welfare benefits for a family of 4 (living in social housing in Iqaluit) were only 63% of the official poverty line. From this perspective, the HFV payments can be seen as helping to fill a critical gap between the supports available to Inuit families from existing services and the amount of income needed to meet the needs of their children.

FIGURE 14

Even with the HFV benefits, welfare benefits in Nunavut do not match the cost of living

Welfare benefits and poverty line (2024)



Amounts represent the maximum benefit available to a family with two children, living in social housing in Iqaluit.

Based on Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

To more specifically test the possibility that the HFV displaced income support, we examined data on income support use across Qikiqtaaluk hamlets between mid-2021 and the end of 2024. As shown in Figure 15, use of Income Assistance has been growing steadily since the end of COVID-era federal benefits and other relevant assistance initiatives (like the Qikiqtani Inuit Association's series of grocery vouchers to Elders and families and some harvesting support grants). In a descriptive



analysis of 11 Qikiqtaaluk communities with HFV programs, seven had a slightly higher average monthly Income Assistance utilization rate after HFV adoption, while three had somewhat lower average use and one had no change. These findings do not point to grocery vouchers displacing Income Assistance. More accurately, they suggest that vouchers temporarily narrowed the critical gap between the cost of living in Nunavut and existing welfare supports. They did so between 2023 and 2025, when temporary, pandemic-era income and food-related supports had ended and inflation and cost of living began to soar.

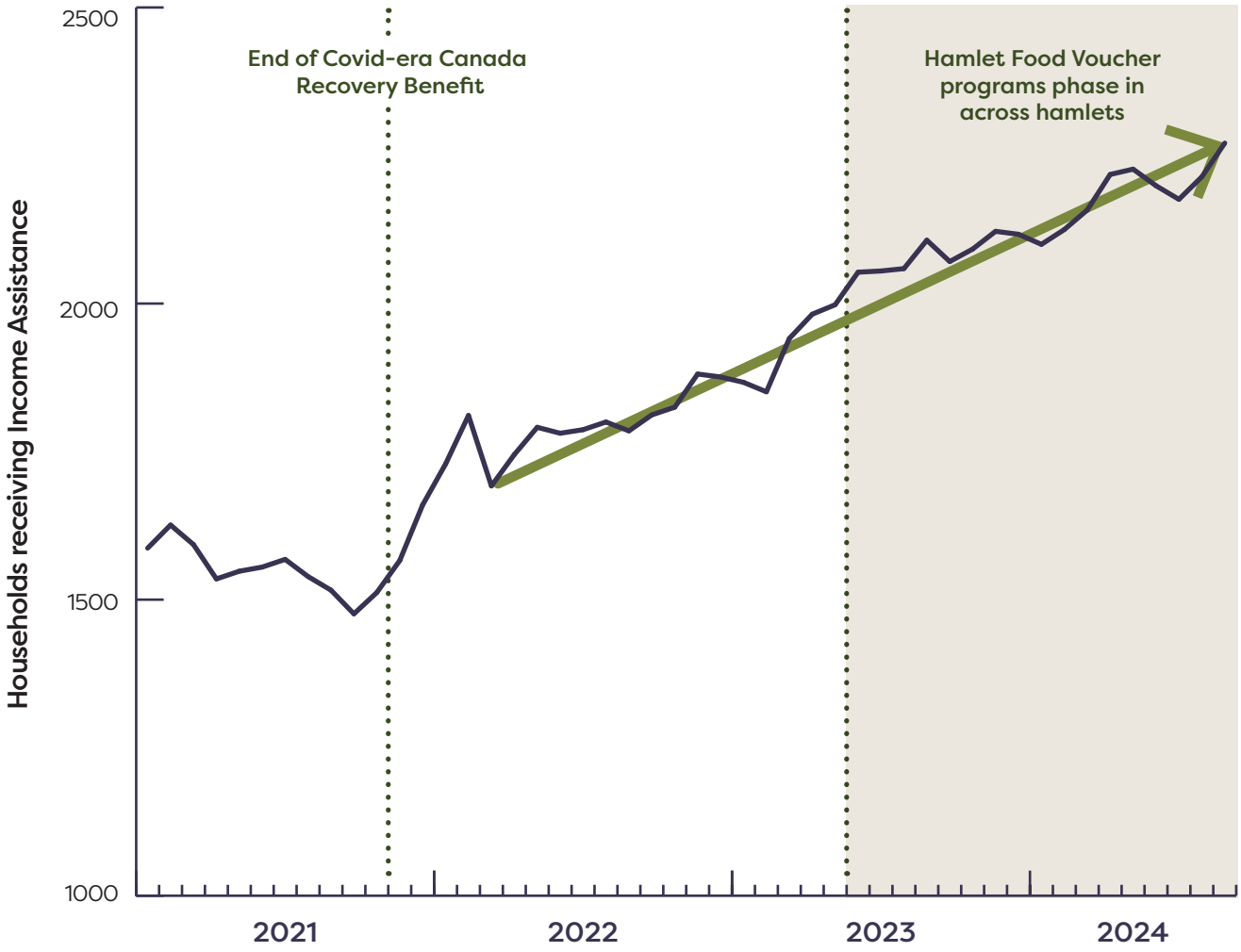
"ICFI was never meant to be an income supplement, but it's clear what the issue is: people cannot afford food. The original intention was to support children's medical needs, gaps, and services such as assessments which are difficult to access. And those supports are still important. But when basic needs like food and housing aren't being met, supports such as psychoeducational assessments become secondary, they go hand in hand."

KEY INFORMANT 1

FIGURE 15

The use of Income Assistance has been steadily increasing since COVID-era benefits were discontinued

Monthly Household Income Assistance use (January 2021–December 2024)



Keeping Stems Strong

Learning from the ICFI Approach to Food Supports

In this section of the report, we analyze the structure and implementation of ICFI-funded food supports, highlighting challenges and lessons for future efforts to increase food access at the national, regional, and local levels.

At the national level, we examine the ways that the temporary and discretionary approach to ICFI funding laid the foundation for ongoing shifts in the administration of individual Grocery Supports and for termination of the HFV.

- At the territorial level, we explore tensions around the universality and progressivity, flexibility and sufficiency of HFV benefits, establishing these as factors that should be considered in future efforts to increase food access. In terms of the HFV program, we find that:
    - It combined broad access for families of Inuit children (universality) with a distribution of benefits that disproportionately reached households with lower income per person (progressivity).

- There were concerns about restrictions that prohibited people from using HFV funds to buy cleaning products, hygiene items, harvesting supplies and other essential items (flexibility). At the same time, some families expressed appreciation for the approach of providing benefits in the form of grocery store credit rather than cash, noting that this could help them navigate complicated household dynamics.
- The HFV helped reduce the struggle to make ends meet for all families who received the benefits, but that was not enough to end food insecurity for *all* families. Key informants and interview participants expressed particular concern for people living in communities with higher grocery costs, large households, households headed by single parents and families getting by on Income Assistance or facing additional challenges. Data from the Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre in Iqaluit reinforce concerns about the insufficiency of HFV benefits for some families, showing that the number of meals served declined in the week following HFV distribution, but climbed again after that.

- Finally, at the local level, we highlight the ways that HFV coordinators innovated and experimented as they sought to keep the shelves stocked and help families stretch their funds across the month, manage assignment and reassignment of families to grocery stores, and enforce local rules around the purchase of healthy foods.

  Significant time and energy were needed to ensure the HFV was implemented in a way that was perceived as being fair, did not disrupt the availability of food for the community and enforced local rules that restricted purchases to healthy food. Future initiatives may incorporate mechanisms for cross-community collaboration and support, to ease the burden of program design and implementation at the local level.

A temporary, discretionary structure

At the national level, tensions around the HFV and individual Grocery Supports had to do with the structuring of ICFI as a temporary initiative. In place of continuing budget lines, ICFI has been funded through annual or multi-year budget allocations that are typically announced in February or March. This means that, as the end of a fiscal year approached, families, service coordination organizations, and programs supported by the ICFI were left in a state of uncertainty, wondering if funds would be renewed. A similar pattern has been documented in relation to Jordan's Principle, on which the ICFI is based.[126] As a result of this pattern of funding renewal, families did not have advance warning that the HFV program would end and, even 7–10 months afterwards, interview participants wondered if the program would be restarted.

The uncertainty stemming from the temporary structure of ICFI is compounded by an approach in which, as discussed in Chapter 4, the requirements for submitting requests for Grocery Supports, the process for reviewing requests and the standards for approval also shifted over time. Research on Jordan's Principle has tied such shifts in policy and practice to over-reliance on a discretionary approach in which, instead of systematically addressing known gaps in existing services, the federal government requires individual families, organizations or communities/ Nations to request supports and then adjudicates each request on an individual basis.[127] This approach is time-consuming for both the families and service providers/coordinators submitting requests and the ISC employees who must spend time adjudicating the requests. As a result, large case backlogs and lengthy delays in responding to requests have been documented for both ICFI and Jordan's Principle.[128] Finally, there are suggestions that this approach is also costly. Working in the southern context, the First Nations Child and Family Caring Society recently estimated the cost of adjudicating a Jordan's Principle request to be $540, bringing into question the fiscal benefit of requiring an adjudication process for low-cost requests.[129]

Families also pay a high cost for the case-by-case approach to meeting children's needs. As discussed in Chapter 4, the Grocery Supports request process requires each family to submit individualized documentation demonstrating their children's unique need for food. After the HFV ended, families faced new requirements when submitting requests for Grocery Supports; these were, in some cases, impossible to meet. Thus, the ICFI individual request process carries a heavy "administrative burden" – the costs associated with seeking public services, including costs of searching for information, complying with rules and requirements and experiences of stress, loss and stigma. Existing research describes the imposition of heavy administrative burden as having an effect like that of formal restrictions on program eligibility and describes it as limiting access to rights and public services.[130]

Because it relies on individual families, organizations or Nations/communities to undertake the burdensome process of requesting services or supports, and on federal evaluation of requests on a case-by-case basis, the discretionary approach to Jordan's Principle and the ICFI also introduces the possibility of additional inequity. For example, some families, organizations or Nations/communities may be better equipped, or more willing, to bring forward requests and, as a result, may receive supports that are not offered to others with similar needs. An extreme example of the inequities stemming from a discretionary approach can be seen in a September 2025 question period note from ISC Minister Gull Masty's office. "Despite mirroring Jordan's Principle as a federally-administered request-based initiative, the implementation of Inuit CFI was never subject to litigation or oversight by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal."[131] The implication is that, unless Inuit bring a parallel legal claim, the federal government may use its discretion to deny Inuit children the standard of public services legally required to meet the needs of First Nations children in a timely fashion.

HFV design considerations

In addition to concerns about the ICFI approach, there were tensions in the design of the HFV program that clustered around three major themes: 1) Universality and progressivity, 2) Flexibility and 3) Sufficiency.

Universality and progressivity

The first set of tensions centred on two key questions: 1) Who gets this benefit (universality), and 2) Does the benefit reach those who need it most (progressivity)?

Underlying these concerns, from one perspective, was a question about whether the HFVs were an efficient mechanism for helping families that needed food supports the most, or whether a large proportion of funds might be going to families who would be able to make ends meet without the support of the HFV. For example, as noted in Chapter 4, key informants working in the ISC regional office discussed federal concerns about the cost of an HFV program that ISC has described as "universal".

> "[I] get people that come here to try and register (for the HFV), even if they have no children, so I would have to explain to them that it's for people who have children under the age of 19. They're thankful, but some ask me why it's only for children."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 14**

In contrast, service providers and coordinators who were key informants spoke of the exclusion of entire categories of people from the HFV program. For example, one noted that, because ICFI's mandate is to meet the needs of Inuit children, the HFV program left some groups of food insecure

people without supports. They wondered if the program was inequitable for many seniors and others who did not have primary responsibility for the care of children. Another key informant wondered whether the families of non-Inuit children living in the region also struggled to manage high grocery prices. From this perspective, the program was universal only in the sense that it was designed to provide support for Inuit children in participating hamlets. It was not universal in the sense of reaching everyone who needed food support: seniors, adults without children, and families of non-Inuit children were outside its mandate.

"We're talking and working with the stores, because I want to make sure that elders who do not have children in their house and don't benefit from this program still have the ability to buy what they need at the store, and we don't put added stress on them."

KEY INFORMANT 19

A recent analysis, which examined the distribution of NNC subsidies, child benefits and estimated HFV benefits in Nunavut, demonstrated that the impact of the HFV also depended on household size and composition, especially the number and ages of children in the household. The study looked at how much of the funds from each benefit went to households in which each person had a low level of income and how much went to households with a higher per-capita (per-person) income. The analysis first divided each household's total income by the number of people living in the household. The households were ranked from lowest to highest per-person income and divided into ten equal groups (deciles). Then, the share of each program's total benefits to households in each decile was estimated. For the HFV, this meant looking at the number and ages of children in the households in each decile and estimating the HFV benefits accordingly ($500 per child per month + an additional $250 per month for children under 4); it was, therefore, not just a simple count of children. For NNC, the analysis combined actual subsidy spending by food category in each community with estimates of household spending on those foods to estimate the distribution of NNC benefits across the income deciles.

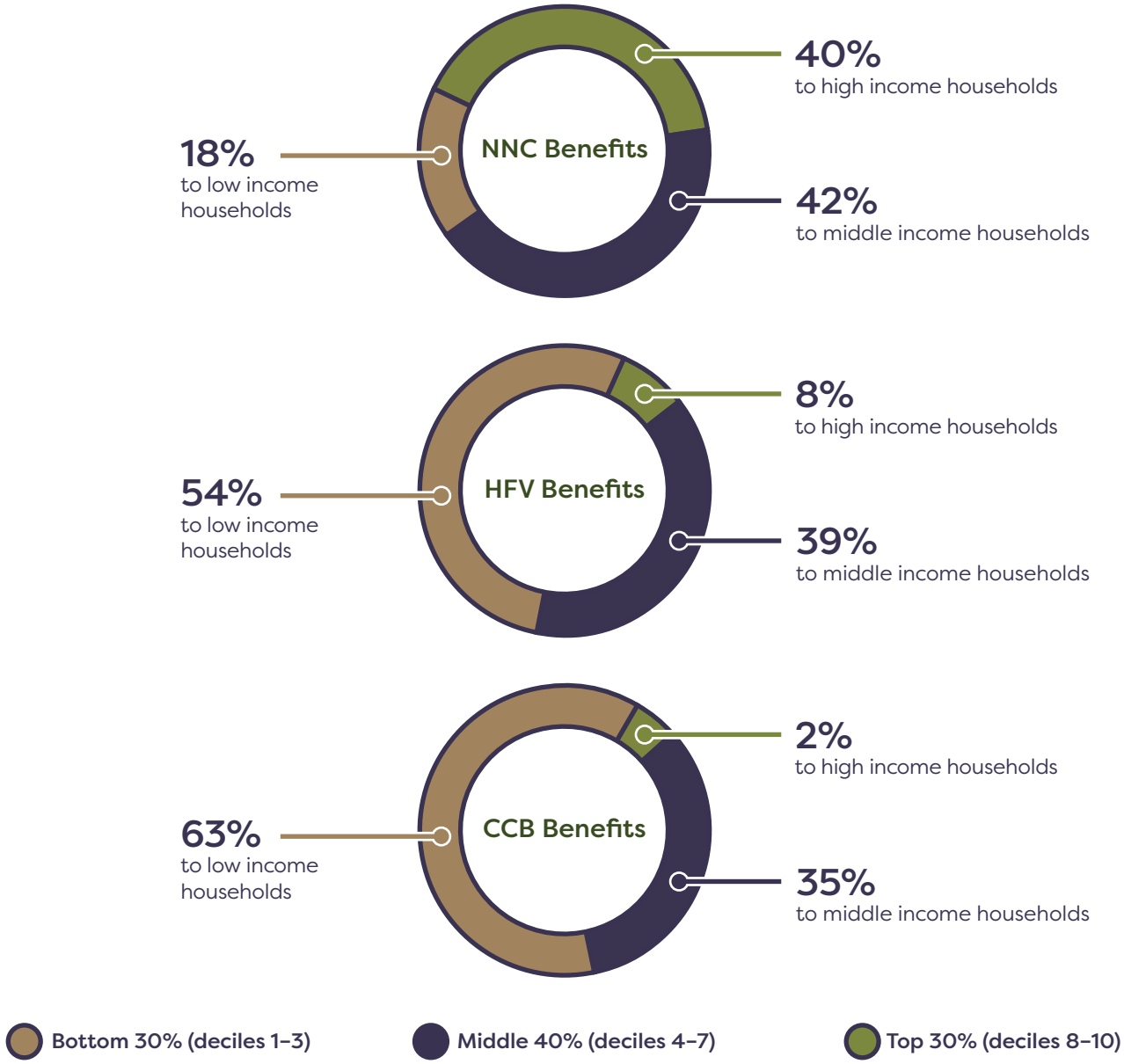
As displayed in Figure 16, this analysis showed that, even though the HFV was not targeted through an income test or individualized assessment of need, it was a relatively progressive child-based benefit. Because children in Nunavut are concentrated in households with lower per-person incomes, HFV benefits were also concentrated among those households. Households in the bottom 30% of Nunavut's per-person income distribution received an estimated 54% of HFV benefits: 17% went to households in the lowest decile, 20% to the second decile, and 17% to the third decile. The highest per-person income decile received an estimated share that rounded to 0%. Child benefits followed a similar

pattern: the bottom 30% of households received an estimated 61% of child benefits and the top 30% of households received 5%. In contrast, NNC subsidy benefits were much less concentrated among lower-income-per-person households: the lowest decile received only 3% of estimated NNC benefits, the bottom 30% received 18%, the highest decile received 10%, and the top 30% received 40%.[132]

FIGURE 16

Lower income households benefited most from the HFV

Distribution of NNC, Canada Child Benefits (CCB) & HFV benefits



Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). *Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada* [Manuscript].

For the families of Inuit children, the HFV combined broad access with a distribution of benefits that disproportionately reached households with lower income per person. In this sense, the HFV was not targeted through a burdensome application process, income test or individualized demonstration of need, but its child-based design indirectly directed resources toward lower-income households. Future food-access policies should therefore distinguish between two questions: whether supports should be universal or targeted within a defined group, and whether that defined group is broad enough to respond to the scale of food insecurity in Nunavut. The HFV addressed urgent needs among Inuit children in a relatively progressive and low-barrier way, but additional or complementary supports would still be needed for people who were excluded from its child-focused mandate.

Flexibility

ISC guidelines placed some restrictions on what people could buy with ICFI-funded Grocery Supports or HFVs, limiting purchases to food and excluding adult items like coffee and cigarettes as well as skidoo parts and other non-food items. Further restrictions on the purchase of junk food were imposed at the local level. As discussed below, administering a program with these restrictions was labour-intensive for hamlets. It also caused tensions within the community. People working for the food voucher program or as cashiers at the grocery store were placed in the position of monitoring family purchases and enforcing restrictions on food seen as 'unhealthy.'

> "I have a niece who's under Jordan's Principle, and she started her menstrual cycle early and when, when her parents can't afford to buy pads, they have to ask me ... I think it would be very helpful for young, young girls to be able to buy pads."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 16**

> "Because it didn't allow us for junk. It taught me that healthy food is more, you get more product out of it because you're not buying pop. It made me realize that produce and the healthier food lasted longer than the ones that we want ... That's what I learned anyway."
>
> **INTERVIEW 7**

These restrictions may seem straightforward, and in line with a focus on food security, but some key informants spoke of negative impacts of the exclusion of all non-food items. One asked, for example, why the funds could not be used to purchase feminine hygiene products, which are needed by youth and sold at the grocery store. Others asked similar questions about clothing, cleaning supplies and other essential items. In a context in which country food traditions coexist with a retail food economy, restrictions on non-food

items like bullets, skidoo parts and other items used in harvesting may also be seen as problematic because they limit access to culturally appropriate, nutrient-dense food. These restrictions have a historical analogue to the first Family Allowances introduced in Canada in the 1940s and 1950s; families in many Indigenous communities did not receive cash and could only purchase prescribed retail foods rather than hunting supplies.[133]

> "Items not included would be pet food, toys, clothing, other household items and furniture, wireless phone cards, gift cards, tobacco, chips, pop candy, chocolate bars, energy drinks and adult hygiene."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 9**

In combination, these restrictions provide important context for key informants' accounts and media reports of some families selling groceries, which may have been purchased with food voucher funds, on Facebook. Reselling groceries converts HFV funding to a less restrictive and more flexible form of needed income.[134] At the same time, speaking after the end of the HFV program, some interview participants expressed appreciation for some level of spending restrictions. For example, participants who struggled with addictions, or had family members who did, noted that limiting funds to the local grocery store helped prioritize food and reduced family tensions around budgeting. Others supported restrictions to healthier foods, noting that it encouraged them to try new foods, which they enjoyed.

Sufficiency

Finally, several key informants wondered whether the HFV program offered enough support to families. Recipients received $500 per child, per month. This was the same amount available to First Nations families in southern provinces like Alberta, which have much lower grocery prices and, viewed from that perspective, may be insufficient to help families combat inflation. In addition, as displayed in Figure 14, in Chapter 6, HFV benefits were not enough to close the sizeable gap between total welfare benefits and the official poverty line in Nunavut. On the other hand, in total, HFV benefits represented approximately $2400 per person in Nunavut. In comparison, NNC subsidies and the Canada Child Benefit each amount to about $1600 per person, substantially less than the HFV.[135]

All key informants and interviewees noted that the amount of funding provided by the HFV was helpful for families; however, several also said that it did not meet the needs of all families or communities. One service provider/coordinator used Grise Fiord, the northernmost community in Qikiqtaaluk, as an example of a community in which HFV funding was insufficient. They noted that Iqaluit had more grocery stores to choose from and greater competition for prices, whereas Grise Fiord had only one grocery store and faced higher costs due to the extra cost of shipping supplies to the community.

"It depends on your community, honestly. For example, Grise Fiord [is] the most northern community in Nunavut; it is not enough. $500 does not meet the need for a child in Grise ... [Families in Iqaluit] have multiple grocery stores, multiple different options available. So, there's competition between the grocery stores, as well, for lower prices. But then you're in Grise, you have one store ... Stock is low and the cost to fly to Grise Fiord is very different than Iqaluit. So, you're getting those shipping costs of things go on top of your price of items in certain communities."

KEY INFORMANT 8

As demonstrated in Figure 17, which is based on analyses of purchases made with ICFI-funded Grocery Supports, prices did vary greatly between communities.[136] The figure illustrates the differences in costs across hamlets. Imagine a family living in Iqaluit was able to budget for a full 30 days of food; the figure shows how long their money would last in other communities in Qikiqtaaluk. In all other communities, their budget would run out at least one full day before the end of the month; in Qikiqtarjuaq, Pangnirtung, and Clyde River, our estimates suggest they would run out of money for food more than three days before the end of the month. In Grise Fiord, they would run out of money for food more than five days before the end of the month.

"[People] on income assistance are more likely to run out of food, even with the food voucher that is going out each month, due to the high cost of food prices ... If I was working, and for example, my sister is on income assistance, she'll ask me if I have this just until next week, because the ends don't meet."

KEY INFORMANT 18



FIGURE 17

Food prices differ across Qikiqtaaluk communities

Based on analysis of ICFI Grocery Supports Data

If a family in Iqaluit is able to budget for a month of food **and** they move to another community and buy the same food, they run out of money for food before the month ends.



Some key informants and interviewees also pointed to variations in the sufficiency of the $500 per child hamlet voucher payment within hamlets. For example, multiple people suggested that this payment was not enough for families on Income Assistance, large families or families headed by single parents or supported by single wage earners. Some interview participants shared that, though they got closer to making ends meet when the HFV was in place, they still had days when they had to cut down on food or skip a meal. As discussed in Chapter 2, many noted that the level of sharing in the community informally helped to even things out, with families that could spare sharing with those who struggled more.



"I am a single mother, so it's a lot harder when you know rent is $3,500 and groceries is $500 a month for just one child... and then trying to afford to feed five adults will be difficult."

KEY INFORMANT 13

"There's families with more than one child that definitely need help. Because I have one child, and it's hard."

INTERVIEW 13

Patterns in the use of formal supports also suggest that the HFV was insufficient for some families. A recent study of the number of meals served each day by Qajuqturvik Food Centre, in Iqaluit, found that demand for food centre meals fell by 17% in the week after HFV distribution.[x] However, this post-voucher dip was temporary and meal counts returned to high levels the week after HFV distribution.[137] This suggests that, for some families that were struggling, the HFV (and other formal benefits) offer enough to get by for a week or so, but not enough to help them to make ends meet across longer time periods.

HFV implementation challenges

While the HFV program operated within a federally defined structure, implementation at the hamlet-level reflected ongoing efforts to adapt the program to local realities. HFV coordinators, other SAO employees and grocery store managers/employees worked together to improve the program as much as possible within the general framework of the HFV. Key areas of local innovation and experimentation are summarized in Table 1.

[x] The analysis adjusted for holidays, day of week (Monday to Friday), and smoothed time trend. It also showed similar, weeklong reductions in meal count with Canada Child Benefit [-14%], GST/HST Credit [-16%], and OAS/CPP payments [-8%].

TABLE 1

At the local level, people worked to make the Hamlet Food Program better

Area of Variation	Issue Being Addressed	Local Innovations
Timing of Fund Release	Challenges stretching money across the month, 'emptying of shelves' because so many people are making purchases at the same time	• Bi-weekly vs. monthly release of funds • Rolling release vs. release to the whole community at one time
Assignment to, and Transfer Between, Grocery Stores	Work associated with supporting consumer choice and fairness to all stores in the community	• Families select a store and are limited to one transfer per year • All families rotate between stores on regular basis • Families can switch as desired, but only upon release of the next payment
Strategies for Enforcing Restriction to Purchase of 'Healthy Foods'	Compliance with rules	• Coordinator review of receipt • Checker/manager sorting of items (allowed/not allowed) • Release of new funds only after repayment of funds spent on restricted items • Deduction from future funds • Facebook pages and posters advertising/clarifying rules • One on one conversations when rules are not followed

Keeping the shelves stocked and helping families stretch their funds

A central challenge reported across several communities was that families often spent much of their monthly voucher allotment immediately upon disbursement. When all families in a hamlet received their funds at the same time, this could lead to empty shelves, strain on store inventory and limited food access for others in the community. In response, some communities experimented with informal strategies such as staggering fund release (with families receiving their funds at different times across the month). These local innovations aimed to stabilize the flow of goods into the community and help families stretch their food supply across the entire month.

> "I think a lot of people are buying a whole bunch of groceries at once, because now they haven't, maybe had food ... for the last couple of weeks."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 11**

"It tends to be, [that they're] at the store to buy everything and then it leads to empty shelves, empty produce, and other people who aren't getting that [the vouchers] being affected by it. So, it's a big demand on the stores and the community in general sometimes."

KEY INFORMANT 19

Supporting consumer choice and fairness to retailers

Local-level innovation also focused on balancing the burdens of managing the HFV with support for consumer choice. Key informants noted that choosing between grocery stores gave families the option to enjoy a greater variety and quality of products, the ability to purchase at lower prices and the flexibility to minimize stress that might be tied to relationships with store employees. Supporting family choice also allowed local governments to maintain a neutral stance towards retailers and avoid possible perceptions that the HFV favoured one retailer over another. However, across hamlets, key informants also noted that substantial work was associated with "switching" a family from one store to another and shared restrictions they put in place to limit that burden. To switch a family from one store to another, the HFV coordinator had to work with one store to close or suspend a family account and with another store to establish accounts and track families' spending across stores in real time. Arrangements with the stores had to be tailored to their accounting practices. Accordingly, all hamlets in which we spoke with key informants required participants to wait until their next disbursement to switch stores, and several restricted the number of these switches to one or two a year. With similar considerations in mind, one hamlet decided to disburse funds every two weeks and rotate families between grocery stores. By dividing the list of food voucher recipients in two and assigning half to the Northern grocery store and the other half to the Co-Op for the first payment of the month, and then switching for the second, they offered families a choice and maintained a stance of fairness towards retailers.

"The food prices are ridiculously high, so we don't want it going all at once, so we decided to split it in half and on each month, if you got it from Co Op, and on the second one, and you'll get it from the Northern, it's switching. We don't want them shopping in one store, because it's going to run out of whatever they have ... So, we decided to split them up and ... they have more choices."

KEY INFORMANT 18

Enforcing rules around healthy foods

Another area in which local adaptation was evident was the enforcement of guidelines around the purchase of "healthy" foods.

Restricting food voucher purchases to healthy foods was initially proposed by ISC and was implemented at the local level even after ISC policies were relaxed to allow the purchase of almost all foods. Typical restrictions included prohibitions on using HFV funds to buy chips, pop, candy, chocolate bars and energy drinks. However, the restrictions varied from hamlet to hamlet and, in some places, also included 'fast' or pre-prepared foods. Key informants broadly indicated support for the restrictions, but they also described tensions and added work associated with the enforcement of these restrictions. Several key informants shared initial difficulties and strategies for ensuring that families understood the hamlet-level restrictions. Others noted the work that went into monitoring family purchases. Enforcing purchase restrictions required someone to review each receipt, line by line, and then follow up with families about purchases of forbidden items to remind them of the rules and/or arrange for repayment or deduction of the value of those items from the next release of HFV funds.

Work to enforce rules continued at the grocery stores, with much of the burden falling on local cashiers who were sometimes charged with telling community members they could not buy restricted items. Key informants in our study discussed the tension of interpreting and enforcing ambiguous rules in real time and the strategies they developed to deflect conflict. Ongoing research in Kitikmeot also documented the stress and concern that this type of monitoring caused for families; participants in that study worried that they, or others in the community, would lose access to the HFV program if they broke the rules around healthy food purchases.[138] At the same time, some HFV coordinators noted that tensions around healthy food restrictions eased once the HFV had been in place for several months. Over time, coordinators developed better strategies for communicating restrictions to families and families began to better understand which purchases were allowed.

> "The cashiers know what, basically, what they should have and not have. But cashiers are young. They're nervous ... They'll call out to me. I have learned to say, 'You need to check with the hamlet. We have a list. If it's not defined in your list, then you need to check with the hamlet. And you're better off no until you do ... It's a local to a local. And you now, that's very different, very, very hard to do at times. So, this one takes the guess-work out of it. Yeah, they know they're being looked at, they're being checked on, and the food actually goes to the child or the family."
>
> **KEY INFORMANT 21**

Sustaining Strong Stems While Feeding Firm Roots

Future Directions

We started this report by presenting data on the high level of food insecurity in Nunavut. Existing survey data indicate that 7 out of 10 children live in homes in which people eat less or skip meals to make ends meet. Interview data suggest that families face monthly, weekly, and even daily struggles with hunger. Food insecurity has serious, long-term negative physical and psychological consequences for children and adults.

The high level of food insecurity in Nunavut has complex structural roots. Colonial processes disrupted Inuit ways of living, and these disruptions have been compounded by severe structural inequities. The result is a profound gap between the income/resources available to many Inuit families in Nunavut and the high cost of living in the region. Thus, food insecurity persists despite the best individual and collective efforts of Inuit to stretch their budgets and support each other.

The HFV, funded through ICFI, temporarily alleviated food insecurity for many families with children, but it did so without remedying underlying structural inequities. Between July of 2023 and March of 2025, the program efficiently extended support for greater food access to almost all families of Inuit children in almost every hamlet. It reduced hunger, increased nutrition, improved physical and mental health and gave people greater resources for other things. It did this without

substantially raising grocery prices or impacting the use of Income Assistance. However, the program was grounded in a temporary, discretionary structure and was discontinued at the end of March 2025.

With the end of the HFV program, many Inuit families in Nunavut once again face urgent challenges accessing the food their families need. Long-term, comprehensive solutions are needed to address the structural inequities that give rise to food insecurity, but those solutions will take time to develop and implement. The current scale and severity of food insecurity in Nunavut also calls for immediate measures to increase food access and reduce the physical and psychological harms described in this report.

In this final chapter, we build on our analysis in the rest of the report to examine possible mechanisms for immediately increasing food access. We offer a comparison of the relative strengths and weaknesses of using existing programs and policy mechanisms to increase food security in Nunavut. Our goal in offering this comparison is not to suggest that any one mechanism is superior to the others or sufficient when it comes to addressing food insecurity in Nunavut. Rather, we want to highlight the need and the possibilities for a comprehensive approach that combines different policy options to improve food access for all Inuit in Nunavut.

Following this analysis, which has a strong focus on programs that could help close the critical gap between income and cost of living in Nunavut, we present interview participants' recommendations on a broader range of services and supports they see as needed. We close this report by reminding readers that our focus has been largely on mechanisms for increasing retail food access and that these options for increasing food access should be seen only as an important complement to the longer-term, comprehensive work needed to eliminate structural inequities and support food sovereignty.

Immediate possibilities – policy options

In this section of the report, we present our research team's summary of some of the possible policy mechanisms for immediately increasing food access in Nunavut. Our analysis is grounded in the understanding that one short-term challenge to be addressed is the gap between the incomes of Inuit in Nunavut (based on earnings, welfare benefits, and other supports) and the cost of living in the region.

What we offer in this section is not meant to be a comprehensive analysis of policy options. Rather, we aim to summarize our collective understanding of the policies that could serve as mechanisms to immediately increase retail food access. We focus on possibilities that emerged during our study of ICFI-funded food supports, based on the information compiled in this report and existing literature with which we are familiar.

Starting with a focus on the HFV, which sought to increase food access by narrowing the critical gap between income and the cost of living, we identified 8 programs that might be expanded and/or revised to immediately increase food access: the HFV (or a similar, new program), the Canada Child Benefit (CCB), the Nunavut Child Benefit (NUCB), Income Assistance, a universal basic income, NNC subsidies, individual Grocery Supports funded through ICFI and the School Food Program. Importantly, our focus means that we did not consider programs that attempt to address food insecurity by increasing access to country food.

We organize our notes in Table 2 around themes that emerged in our analysis of ICFI-funded food supports:

Level of benefit: How much do people receive each month?

Universality: Who can receive this benefit? Is it available to a broad segment of the population or limited to a narrow group?

Sufficiency: How adequate is the benefit? We assess this in two ways: comparative sufficiency, which compares the level of benefit in Nunavut to what people get in other territories/provinces, and needs-based sufficiency, which calculates the benefit as a percentage of the official poverty line.

Flexibility: Are benefits provided in a way that complements individual strategies for making ends meet and allows recipients to address their self-determined and prioritized needs?

Progressivity: Do the benefits go to those who need them most?

Ease of access: Are those who are eligible able to easily qualify for benefits, or is there a high administrative burden attached to applying and qualifying for benefits?

In Table 2, we offer a summary assessment of "high", shown in green, to indicate favourable options. We use "low", shown in red, to indicate options that have undesirable characteristics. "Moderate", shown in yellow, indicates those options that fall somewhere between the high and low ratings. When a rating is unknown, not directly comparable, or dependent on the design of a future policy, this is indicated in the table and shown in gray.

The eight programs identified differ with respect to the qualities summarized briefly in Table 2 and in much more detail in a table in Appendix 2. They also differ in the level of revision or policy development required for them to support food access on a scale similar to that of the HFV. Meaningful increases in food access through any of these policy pathways would require significant additional investment.

TABLE 2

Summary of possible mechanisms for increasing food access

Policy mechanism	Level of benefit	Universality	Flexibility	Sufficiency	Progressivity	Ease of access
1. **Hamlet Food Vouchers (HFV; past program)**	$1,000–$1,500/ month for a two-child family	High	Moderate	High	Moderate	High
2. **Nunavut Child Benefit (NUCB; territorial)**	$58/month for a two-child family	Low	High	Low	Moderate	Moderate
3. **Canada Child Benefit (CCB; federal)**	Approximately $1,070/month for a two-child family	High	High	Moderate	High	Moderate
4. **Income Assistance / Basic Social Assistance**	Up to about $1,939/ month for a family of four living in social housing in Iqaluit	Moderate	Low	Low	High	Low
5. **Universal Basic Income (UBI; potential future program)**	Design dependent	Design dependent	High	Design dependent	Design dependent	Moderate
6. **Nutrition North Canada (NNC) subsidy (federal retail subsidy)**	An estimated average value of about $533/month	High	Low	Moderate	Low	High
7. **Individual Grocery Supports**	Typically $500/ month per child when approve. Approval length varies from about 1 month to 1 year	Low	Moderate	Unknown	Unknown	Low
8. **School food programs**	In-kind benefit of meals, snacks, or other food at school	Moderate	Low	Unknown	Unknown	High

Revived HFV or a parallel program

The HFV reached almost all families of Inuit children in almost every Nunavut community and was very easy to access; registration requirements were minimal. The program, which appears to have been unique across Canadian provinces/territories, offered a family with 2 children a benefit that represented 13% of the official poverty line. Though all families, regardless of income, received the same per-child benefit, the concentration of children in the lowest income households in Nunavut meant that HFV most benefited households where income was low and/or stretched across many people: 54% of benefits went to people in households in the bottom 30% of the per capita income distribution. In contrast, people living in households in the top 30% of the per capita income distribution received only 8% of HFV benefits.[139]

In terms of flexibility, families could use HFV funds on 'healthy foods', a restriction which may have contributed to the purchase of more nutritious groceries but also limited people's abilities to buy other needed items such as health and hygiene products, cleaning supplies and supplies for hunting/harvesting. The HFV was an efficient mechanism for increasing food access to families in Nunavut. Reinstatement of the program, or creation of a similar program, could quickly increase food access. However, the trajectory of HFV should serve as a cautionary tale; any new efforts in this direction should establish a stable and consistent basis for ongoing support.

Expanded Canada Child Benefit (CCB)

All families with children are eligible for a flexible cash transfer through the CCB, but the level of benefits is determined through a progressive, three-tiered framework in which households with less than $38,327 receive the maximum income and those with higher incomes receive reduced benefits.[140] Thus, the CCB is a progressive benefit. In Nunavut, people in households in the lowest 30% of the per capita income distribution got 63% of CCB benefits, and those in the highest 30% of the distribution got 2%.[141]

Receipt requires the filing of taxes and, in most cases, the presentation of a birth certificate and proof of primary responsibility for the child's care. In some cases, a signed letter from the female parent and/or proof of citizenship status and Canadian residency may also be required. In 2024, the CCB provided a benefit of $553 per month per child (over the age of 6, and $634 for younger children) each month,[142] totalling 14%–16% of a modest standard of living for a family with children. The CCB is currently not adjusted for cost of living differences across provinces and territories; this type of adjustment could be another mechanism for immediately increasing food access in Nunavut.

Revised and expanded Nunavut Child Benefit (NUCB)

The NUCB is available only to families with children that have net incomes of less than $22,065.[143] Receipt requires the filing of taxes and, in most cases, the presentation

of a birth certificate and proof of primary responsibility for the child's care. In some cases, a signed letter from the female parent and/or proof of citizenship status and Canadian residency may also be required. The NUCB provides a flexible cash transfer, but the benefit is only $29/child each month, totalling 1% of a modest standard of living for a family with children.

A recently announced doubling of this benefit will bring the dollar value of the NUCB in line with territorial child benefits in NWT and Yukon, but it will not address the difference in cost of living across territories.[144] The current level of and framework for the NUCB make it a poor mechanism for increasing food access for the 79% of Inuit children that are food insecure in Nunavut. However, a revised NUCB framework and greatly increased level of benefit that brings the NUCB more in line with the CCB could serve as an efficient mechanism for increased territorial support for food access.

Revised and expanded Income Assistance

Access to, and the level of, Income Assistance benefits is based on assessment of the gap between a household's actual expenses and income. One recent report estimates a maximum benefit of $1939 per month, for a family of 4 living in social housing in Iqaluit.[145] Data from 2018 suggests that roughly 1800 families with children accessed Income Assistance each month.[146]

Qualifying for Income Assistance requires individual, case-by-case assessment and extensive documentation, including: birth certificate, health care card and SINs for each household member; rental or mortgage papers; property tax statements and land lease agreements; utility bills; employment insurance applications; pay stubs; employer contact information; proof of other benefits; and, in some cases, high school attendance records. Benefits vary by geographic zone, family income and family needs.

There are strict asset and income limits for recipients; Income Assistance benefits are reduced once a family has more than $1000 in liquid assets or earns/receives more than $700 in additional income in a month.[147] These restrictions led a recent study to conclude that the Income Assistance framework is not aligned with Inuit values and to recommend a shift towards a framework more grounded in universal basic income principles to: reduce stigma, foster financial stability and security for clients, increase benefit levels, and eliminate asset tests as a criterion for eligibility.[148] Such a shift would likely increase ease of access, universality, and flexibility of supports and could lay a foundation for an expansion of income supports to efficiently increase food access.

Universal/income tested basic income (UBI/IBI; future possibility)

Recent studies have turned attention to a UBI as another possible policy mechanism for addressing the gap between incomes and cost of living in Nunavut.[149] A UBI would be a flexible and unconditional cash transfer provided to all adults who meet specified

eligibility criteria, such as an income cut-off established for an income-tested basic income (IBI). It could also include additional features such as a child benefit.

A universal basic income does not currently exist in Nunavut, but a series of recent studies lays the foundation for considering UBI as an additional possible mechanism for increasing food access. UBI is typically linked to a tax framework so, like CCB and NUCB, would require filing taxes and, if designed to include a child benefit, the presentation of a birth certificate and proof of primary responsibility for the child's care. In some cases, a signed letter from the female parent and/or proof of citizenship status and Canadian residency might also be required. Simulations conducted as part of a 2024 study found that, for example, an income-tested basic income of $25,000 (which is roughly equivalent to COVID-19 era CERB payments), with a per-child supplement and a gradual (15%) rate of reducing benefits with increased income would reduce the number of people with low income in Nunavut by 71%[150]

Nutrition North Canada (NNC) food subsidies

NNC provides direct payments to retailers to subsidize the cost of food in remote northern communities. Retailers are expected to 'pass-through' the savings to customers by reducing the retail price by the amount of the subsidy. However, existing research suggests that retailers in communities with only one or two stores do not pass through the full subsidy.[151] The benefit is attached to specific eligible products, depends on store prices and household purchases, and is automatically credited to anyone who buys NNC-subsidized products in eligible communities.

The subsidy rates vary by community and product (e.g., those deemed more nutritious receive higher subsidy levels) and have an estimated average value of about $533/month for a family of four, or 7% of the official poverty line. Because the benefit is tied to consumption, meaning those who buy more subsidized products benefit more, NNC subsidies are less progressive than other policy mechanisms. Households in the bottom 30% of the per-capita income distribution received an estimated 17% of NNC benefits, while households in the top 30% of the income distribution received 40%. Targeting subsidies towards foods consumed in greater quantities by the lowest income households could potentially increase progressivity, but households with little to no income would get little benefit.[152] In addition, as discussed in Chapter 6, linking NNC subsidies directly tied to freight costs could ensure that they fully offset freight cost increases during periods of high inflation.

School Food Program

School food programs provide in-kind benefits, usually prepared meals or snacks served at school. Some schools send home food baskets, but children and families generally have little flexibility to decide how to use school food benefits. The program is easily accessible to a large number of children

who are registered in and present at school, though (for example) some programs have required a note saying there is no food at home. The dollar value of the benefits provided varies by school and program model; we were not able to obtain systematic data that allowed for calculation of an average benefit. The signing of a National School Food Program funding agreement in 2025 is an important development that may support increased food access across Nunavut communities. However, school food programs do not typically operate in the summer or reach younger children, out-of-school youth, or adult household members.

ICFI-funded Grocery Supports

As described in Chapter 4, ICFI continues to fund individual Grocery Supports for select children who apply and receive discretionary, case-specific approvals in line with current eligibility criteria. Approved amounts are typically $500 per month per child in grocery credit that can be used to buy food, with some restrictions. Thus, the benefit is more flexible than school meals but less flexible than cash transfers. The number of months of support approved varies from one month to one year but is generally limited. If both children in a two-child household were approved for Grocery Supports, the benefit would total 1%–13% of the official poverty line, depending on the length of support approved.

The benefit is, in principle, targeted by need. However, actual access depends on awareness, service-provider support, documentation, discretionary review, and shifting standards. Findings from existing research on Jordan's Principle, as well as the backlogs and delays already experienced in the administration of the individual Grocery Supports in Nunavut, suggest that individual requests are not an appropriate mechanism for addressing broad gaps in existing policy frameworks that contribute to nearly 80% of Inuit children in Nunavut living in food insecurity. However, individual Grocery Supports could be an important and effective way to address individual cases, in which there are unique considerations or extenuating factors, once the existing policy gap is closed.[153]

Table 2 shows that, while there is no perfect solution, there are many possible ways to increase food access while comprehensive work to address structural inequities is ongoing. Indeed, given the sizeable gap between the current level of welfare benefits and the cost of living in Nunavut, increases in the benefits provided through multiple policy mechanisms may be required.

Interview participants recommendations

In keeping with our focus on increasing food access by closing the gap between income and cost of living, the most common request or recommendation from interview participants was to bring back the HFV program. These recommendations were made in the context of often-emotional interviews in which participants were asked to reflect back on what things were like when the vouchers were in place and to talk about their situations without the vouchers. Many participants struggled to come up with alternate recommendations, stating that they "didn't know" or asking that we skip to the next question.

Still, some interviewees did have additional recommendations, and many of these focused on increasing access to food for those most in need. Several participants pointed to resources that existed in the past, recommending the strengthening and reintroduction of food banks and soup kitchens, suggesting they could help ensure consistent access to food, especially for children.

Several interviewees also emphasized the importance of country food and suggested additional means of supporting hunters to provide country food to the community. Possibilities included repairing or purchasing community freezers, creating new paid positions for community members to harvest and provide food to people, increased opportunities for young people to learn harvesting skills, and establishing country food stores where people could purchase country food on an ongoing basis.

Beyond food-related recommendations, participants also suggested a range of community and social supports. These included youth centres, community hall activities, music festivals, gatherings and games to engage people and keep them away from trouble. Some recommended teaching practical skills such as carving, sewing, and setting gill nets to help individuals become more self-sufficient and generate income. Others suggested that such activities might also help people avoid drinking and smoking so they can save money for food. Participants also noted the need for more job opportunities to help families manage financially.

Addressing structural inequity and supporting food sovereignty

These more holistic recommendations are in keeping with the long-term, comprehensive approaches to reducing poverty and increasing food sovereignty that have been put forth in Inuit-led strategic plans and research. For example, the *Inuit Nunangat Food Security Strategy* (2021)[154] identifies strengthening food security through direct financial support to low-income families, which is very similar to our focus in this report, as only one part of a more comprehensive set of needed actions that also include:

- Strengthening Inuit self-determination within the Inuit Nunangat food system,

- Improving food security through poverty reduction and economic self-reliance,
- Subsidizing, regulating and investing in the northern air sector as an essential service, and
- Major new investments in infrastructure[155]

Qikiqtani Inuit Association's (2019). *Food sovereignty and harvesting outlines* important pathways for addressing food insecurity and poverty in Nunavut by increasing food sovereignty. Recommendations for an approach that builds on Inuit Qaujimajatuqangit include investment in small craft harbours and deep-sea ports, multi-use facilities (like equipment warehouses and office spaces for harvester and steward programs), food processing plants, a training centre, Inuit harvester and stewardship programs, and elder and youth on the land programs.[156]

As displayed in Figure 18, the Nunavut Roundtable for Poverty Reduction's (2017) *Makimaniq 2* plan[157] identifies increased food security as one of 8 complementary priorities. *Makimaniq 3*, which will be released in the fall of 2026, will build on that report and update priorities for supporting poverty reduction and economic self-reliance.



FIGURE 18

Increased food security is one of eight complementary priorities in the Makimaniq 2 plan



The Nunavut Roundtable for Poverty Reduction. (2016). The Makimaniq plan 2: A shared approach to poverty reduction. https://www.gov.nu.ca/en/media/4911

Long-term, comprehensive approaches are needed to eliminate the structural inequities that give rise to food insecurity and promote food sovereignty in Nunavut. The options discussed in this chapter for immediately increasing food access by closing the gap between income and the high cost of living are one important part of that broader work. They should be understood not as substitutes for measures that redress existing inequities and strengthen Inuit food sovereignty, but as immediate ways of reducing the harms of food insecurity while that longer-term work continues. Closing this gap would strengthen the efforts that Inuit families and communities are already making to feed their children, share food, support hunters, keep doors open and care for one another without having to plan for hunger. As one interview participant put it, "When there's food, everybody eats... No matter how big or small the portion is, you serve everyone ... That's what I learned from my grandma anyway." The task ahead is to ensure that public policy supports, rather than strains, that ethic of care.

Appendix 1

The Difference in Food Prices in Qikiqtaaluk and Canada by Community and NNC Category

	Cost of ICFI basket vs. Canada average
All	1.91
Community	
Arctic Bay	2.03
Cape Dorset	1.99
Clyde River	2.05
Grise Fiord	2.47
Hall Beach	1.96
Igloolik	1.92
Iqaluit	1.77
Kimmirut	1.81
Pangnirtung	1.9
Pond Inlet	1.92
Qikiqtarjuaq	2.03
Resolute Bay	1.7
Sanikiluaq	1.84
Category	
Baby	1.28
Dairy and Egg Products	1.72
Fruits, veg., legumes	2.44
Grains, cereals, baked	1.77
Meat	1.34
Nuts, sauces, spices, oils	1.43

Sinha, V., Li, N., Wheatley, D., Hoang, N, et al (2025) *Preliminary findings from an evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Qikiqtaaluk. Qupanuaq.*

Appendix 2

Possible Mechanisms for Increasing Food Access

Policy mechanism	Level of benefit	Universality	Flexibility	Sufficiency	Progressivity	Ease of access
1. Hamlet Food Vouchers (HFV) (past program)	$1,000–$1,500/month for a two-child family: $500/month per child age 4+, plus an additional $250/month for each child under age 4.	High. Reached families of Inuit children in participating hamlets; did not directly reach households without children, or families of non-Inuit children.	Moderate. Grocery-store credit, often with healthy-food restrictions. More flexible than prepared meals, but less flexible than cash.	High. We do not know of another province or territory that had a comparable program. About 13% of the Nunavut official poverty-line if both children are age 4+; about 20% if both children are under age 4.	Moderate. Not income-tested, but progressive because children are concentrated in households with lower income per person. Households in the bottom 30% received an estimated 54% of HFV benefits; the top decile received a share rounded to 0%.**	High. Local sign-up, in person or online, using a Nunavut Inuit Enrolment Card or confirmation of enrolment through Nunavut Tunngavik Inc.

** Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada [Manuscript].

Policy mechanism	Level of benefit	Universality	Flexibility	Sufficiency	Progressivity	Ease of access
2. Nunavut Child Benefit (NUCB; territorial)	$58/month for a two-child family.* The territory has announced that the amount will double in 2026–27.***	Low. Limited to families with children that have a net income of less than $22,065.	High. Cash transfer, so families can use it according to their own priorities.	Low. The current amount is below territorial child benefits in the other northern territories. About 1% of the Nunavut official poverty-line. The benefit will double next year but will still be very small relative to the cost of living.	Moderate. Flat benefit for qualifying low-income families, the income threshold is very low.	Moderate. Requires tax filing and child-related documentation such as birth certificate and proof of primary responsibility for care. Other documents may also be required.
3. Canada Child Benefit (CCB; federal)	Approximately $1,070/month for a two-child family, depending on children's ages and household income.*	High. Available to eligible families with children.	High. Cash transfer, so families can use it according to their own priorities.	Moderate. The benefit formula is national and is not adjusted to Nunavut's higher cost of living: About 14%-16% of the Nunavut official poverty-line (depending on child ages).	High. Income-tested and strongly concentrated among lower-income households. Households in the bottom 30% received an estimated 63% of child benefits.**	Moderate. Requires tax filing and child-related documentation such as birth certificate and proof of primary responsibility for care. Other documents may also be required.

* Based on Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). Welfare in Canada, 2024. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

** Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada [Manuscript].

*** Pelletier, J. (2026, June 15) MLAs approve doubling Nunavut Child Benefit payments. Nunatsiaq News. https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/mlas-approve-doubling-nunavut-child-benefit-payments/

Policy mechanism	Level of benefit	Universality	Flexibility	Sufficiency	Progressivity	Ease of access
4. Income Assistance / Basic Social Assistance	Up to about $1,939/month for a family of four living in social housing in Iqaluit.* Actual benefit varies by community zone, household income, expenses, and assessed need.	Moderate. Available to low-income households that meet income and asset rules.	Low. Cash is flexible, but the program's income, asset, and reporting rules limit household flexibility and restrict ability to combine assistance with other sources of income.	Low. Nunavut welfare income is much less sufficient than in the other northern territories; 25% of the official poverty line is covered compared to 56-58% in Northwest Territories and Yukon.*	High Targeted to low-income households and assessed against needs such as rent and utilities.	Low. Requires extensive documentation, including identity documents for household members, housing and utility documents, employment/benefit information, pay stubs, employer contact information, and sometimes school attendance records.
5. Universal Basic Income (UBI) (potential future program)	Design-dependent. Amount would depend on the model adopted.	Design dependent. Could reach all adults or all residents in a defined group, depending on design.	High. Cash transfer, so families can use it according to their own priorities.	Design-dependent. Would depend on whether the model is national, territorial, Inuit-specific, or adjusted for northern living costs.	Design-dependent. A universal benefit with a progressive tax-back or income threshold could be progressive, but this depends on the final model.	Moderate. Administrative burden would depend on whether eligibility is automatic, tax-based, or application-based.

* Based on Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). Welfare in Canada, 2024. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

Policy mechanism	Level of benefit	Universality	Flexibility	Sufficiency	Progressivity	Ease of access
6. Nutrition North Canada (NNC) subsidy	An estimated average value of about $533/month for the example family, but the actual benefit depends on what households buy and how much of the subsidy is passed through to prices.**	High. Available to anyone who buys NNC-subsidized products in eligible communities.	Low. Benefit is attached to specific eligible products and depends on store prices and household purchases.	Moderate. NNC is specifically designed for remote communities and can reduce prices of eligible foods, but current subsidy levels are not directly tied to actual freight costs. On average, 7% of the official poverty line is covered.	Low. Benefit is tied to consumption and less progressive than child benefits or HFV. Households in the bottom 30% received an estimated 18% of NNC benefits, while the top 30% received 40%.**	High. Automatically incorporated into grocery-store prices; no family application is required.
7. School food programs	In-kind benefit of meals, snacks, or food at school. Dollar value varies by school and program model.	Moderate. Reaches children who are registered in and present at school; does not typically operate in the summer or reach younger children, out-of-school youth, or adult household members.	Low. Usually prepared meals or snacks served at school. Some schools may send food home, but families generally cannot decide how to use the benefit.	Unknown. Expanded National School Food Program funding may improve comparability across communities, but implementation varies by school and community. As this is an in-kind benefit, it is difficult to compare with monthly household income supports.	Unknown. Reaches many children regardless of household income but is not necessarily targeted to the households with the greatest need.	High. Easy for children present at school, though some programs have required a note saying there is no food at home.

** Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada [Manuscript].

Policy mechanism	Level of benefit	Universality	Flexibility	Sufficiency	Progressivity	Ease of access
8. Individual Grocery Supports	Typically $500/month per child when approved, but approval length varies from about 1 month to 1 year.	Low. Limited to selected Inuit children whose families apply and are approved.	Moderate. Usually grocery credit that can be used to buy food, with some restrictions. More flexible than school meals, less flexible than cash.	Unknown. For children who receive discretionary, case-specific approvals, monthly amount is comparable to HFV, but number of months approved is generally low. About 1%–13% of the Nunavut official poverty-line depending on whether support is approved for one month or a full year.	Unknown. Targeted by need in principle, but actual access depends on awareness, service-provider support, documentation, discretionary review, and shifting standards.	Low. High administrative burden, shifting requirements, delays, denials, and need for support letters that match current standards.

References

1 Statistics Canada. (2021). *Census profile, 2021 census of population* (Profile table). https://www12.statcan.gc.ca/census-recensement/2021/dp-pd/prof/details/page.cfm

Qikiqtaani Inuit Association. (2019). *Food sovereignty and harvesting.* https://www.qia.ca/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/Food-Sovereignty-and-Harvesting.pdf

2 Statistics Canada. (2024). *Food security status of First Nations people living off reserve, Métis and Inuit by age group.* https://doi.org/10.25318/4110006301-eng

3 Statistics Canada. (2024). *Food security status of First Nations people living off reserve,* Métis and Inuit by age group. https://doi.org/10.25318/4110006301-eng

4 Statistics Canada. (2025, May 1). *Canadian Income Survey, 2023.* https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/n1/daily-quotidien/250501/dq250501b-eng.htm

5 Brockington, M., Kenney, T.-A., Fediuk, K., Chan, L., & Little, M. (2025). Food insecurity and coping strategies in Qikiqtarjuaq, Nunavut: A community-based survey. In *Fishing for sovereignty: Strengthening food security and Inuit wellbeing through fish and seafood* (Doctoral dissertation, University of Guelph). University of Guelph Atrium Repository. https://atrium.lib.uoguelph.ca/server/api/core/bitstreams/ed36769d-2bef-459f-a8fd-d759150cb5b2/content

6 Hanson, L. (2025). *The JP food voucher program: A band-aid for Inuit child food security in Pangnirtung* [Report prepared for the Hamlet of Pangnirtung, Nunavut].

7 Gilbert, S. Z., Jessri, M., Turner, L., Fawehinmi, T. O., Caughey, A., Stadnyk, S., Kaminsky, L., Ford, J. D., Pérez-Escamilla, R., Hawley, N. L., & Dubrow, R. (2025). Seasonal and community size-related patterns of population dietary energy, macronutrients, and fiber purchased in grocery stores across Nunavut, Canada. *Food and Nutrition of Indigenous Peoples, 9*(12), 107558 https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cdnut.2025.107558

8 Gilbert, S. Z., Jessri, M., Turner, L., Fawehinmi, T. O., Caughey, A., Stadnyk, S., Kaminsky, L., Ford, J. D., Pérez-Escamilla, R., Hawley, N. L., & Dubrow, R. (2025). Seasonal and community size-related patterns of population dietary energy, macronutrients, and fiber purchased in grocery stores across Nunavut, Canada. *Current Developments in Nutrition, 9*(12). https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cdnut.2025.107558

9 Kenny, T. A., Fillion, M., Simpkin, S., Wesche, S. D., & Chan, H. M. (2018). Caribou (Rangifer tarandus) and Inuit nutrition security in Canada. *EcoHealth, 15*(3), 590–607. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10393-018-1348-z

10 Kenny, T. A., Hu, X. F., Jamieson, J. A., Kuhnlein, H. V., Wesche, S. D., & Chan, H. M. (2019). Potential impact of restricted caribou (Rangifer tarandus) consumption on anemia prevalence among Inuit adults in northern Canada. *BMC Nutrition, 5*, 30. https://doi.org/10.1186/s40795-019-0292-9

11 Banerji, A. Pelletier, V.A., Haring, R., Bresnahan, A., & Lavallee, B. (2023). Food insecurity and its consequences in indigenous children and youth in Canada. *PLOS Global Public Health, 4*(7). https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pgph.0002406

Cook, J.T. & Frank, D.A. (2008). Food Security, poverty, and human development in the United States. *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences, 1136*: 193-209. https://doi.org/10.1196/annals.1425.001

Gallegos, D., Eivers, A., Sondergeld, P., & Pattinson, C. (2021). Food insecurity and child development: A state-of-the-art review. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health, 18*(17). https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph18178990

Johnson, A.D. & Markowitz, A.J. (2018). Food insecurity and family well-being outcomes among households with young children. *The Journal of Pediatrics, 196*, 275 – 282. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpeds.2018.01.026

Pourmotabbed, A., Moradi, S., Babaei, A., Ghavami, A., Mohammadi, H., Jalili, C., Symonds, M. E., & Miraghajani, M. (2020). Food insecurity and mental health: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *Public Health Nutrition, 23*(10), 1778–1790. https://doi.org/10.1017/S136898001900435X

Shankar P, Chung R, Frank DA. (2017) Association of food insecurity with children's behavioral, emotional, and academic outcomes: A systematic review. *Journal of Developmental and Behavioral Pediatrics, 38*(2),135-150. https://doi.org/10.1097/DBP.0000000000000383

Simonovich, S. D., Pineros-Leano, M., Ali, A., Awosika, O., Herman, A., Withington, M. H. C., Loiacono, B., Cory, M., Estrada, M., Soto, D., & Buscemi, J. (2020). A systematic review examining the relationship between food insecurity and early childhood physiological health outcomes. *Translational Behavioral Medicine, 10*(5), 1086–1097. https://doi.org/10.1093/tbm/ibaa021

Thomas, M. M. C., Miller, D. P., & Morrissey, T. W. (2019). Food insecurity and child health. *Pediatrics*, 144(4), e20190397. https://doi.org/10.1542/peds.2019-0397

[12] Caughey, A., Harper, S. L., Sanguya, I., Sargeant, J. M., Miners, A., Doucette, M., Koonoo, T., Weiler, H., Allen, J., MacRury, A., Akearok, G. H., Moller, H., Aylward, B., Lema, J. G., & Arbour, L. (2025). Early life nutrition in Nunavut, Canada: A retrospective descriptive study of food security, vitamin D and rickets. *International Journal of Circumpolar Health, 84*(1), 2580100. https://doi.org/10.1080/22423982.2025.2580100

[13] Government of Nunavut, Department of Health. (2015). *Protocol for identifying and treating iron deficiency anemia in infants and young children.* https://www.gov.nu.ca/sites/default/files/documents/2021-11/nunavut_protocol_for_ida_approved_2015_may_20_0.pdf

[14] Indigenous Services Canada, & Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2024, March 24). *Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami and Indigenous Services Canada working to eliminate tuberculosis in Inuit Nunangat by 2030* [News release]. https://www.canada.ca/en/indigenous-services-canada/news/2024/03/inuit-tapiriit-kanatami-and-indigenous-services-canada-working-to-eliminate-tuberculosis-in-inuit-nunangat-by-2030.html

[15] Banerji, A., Bell, A., Mills, E. L., McDonald, J., Subbarao, K., Stark, G., Eynon, N., & Loo, V. G. (2001). Lower respiratory tract infections in Inuit infants on Baffin Island. *CMAJ, 164*(13), 1847-1850.

[16] Hajizadeh, M., Bombay, A., & Asada, Y. (2019). Socioeconomic inequalities in psychological distress and suicidal behaviours among Indigenous peoples living off-reserve in Canada. *CMAJ : Canadian Medical Association journal = journal de l'Association medicale canadienne, 191*(12), E325–E336. https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.181374

Chai, L. Food insecurity as a mediator and moderator in the association between residential mobility and suicidal ideation among Indigenous adults in Canada. *Soc Psychiatry Psychiatr Epidemiol 59*, 1073–1085 (2024). https://doi.org/10.1007/s00127-023-02562-5

Bradette-Laplante, M., Courtemanche, Y., Desrochers-Couture, M., Forget-Dubois, N., Bélanger, R. E., Ayotte, P., ... Muckle, G. (2020). Food insecurity and psychological distress in Inuit adolescents of Nunavik. *Public Health Nutrition, 23*(14), 2615–2625. doi:10.1017/S1368980020000117

[17] Frank, M., Daniel, L., Hays, C. N., Shanahan, M. E., Naumann, R. B., McNaughton Reyes, H. L., & Austin, A. E. (2024). Association of food insecurity with multiple forms of interpersonal and self-directed violence: A systematic review. *Trauma, Violence, & Abuse, 25*(1), 828-845. https://doi.org/10.1177/15248380231165689

Helton, J. J., Jackson, D. B., Boutwell, B. B., & Vaughn, M. G. (2019). Household food insecurity and parent-to-child aggression. *Child Maltreatment*, *24*(2), 213–221.

McKay, F. H., & Bennett, R. (2025). Examining the relationship between food insecurity and family violence: A systematic narrative review. *Journal of Family Violence*, 40, 369–382. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10896-023-00624-5

Reck, A. (2024). *Neurocognitive and protective pathways linking food insecurity to impulsivity among adolescents* (Doctoral dissertation, University of Georgia).

Turner, V. E., Demissie, Z., Sliwa, S. A., & Clayton, H. B. (2022). Food insecurity and its association with alcohol and other substance use among high school students in the United States. *Journal of School Health*, 92(2), 177–184. https://doi.org/10.1111/josh.13118

Vaughn, M. G., Salas-Wright, C. P., Naeger, S., Huang, J., & Piquero, A. R. (2016). Childhood reports of food neglect and impulse control problems and violence in adulthood. International *Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, *13*(4), 389. https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph13040389

[18] Statistics Canada. (2024, September 27). *Harvesting activities by First Nations people living off reserve, Métis and Inuit, age group and gender* (Table 41-10-0072-01). https://doi.org/10.25318/4110007201-eng

[19] Warltier, D. W., Landry-Cuerrier, M., & Humphries, M. M. (2021). Valuation of country food in Nunavut based on energy and protein replacement. *Arctic, 74*(3), 355-71. https://www.jstor.org/stable/27088589

[20] Newell , S. L., Doubleday , N. C., & Nunavut , & C. of C. I. (2020). Sharing country food: connecting health, food security and cultural continuity in Chesterfield Inlet, Nunavut. *Polar Research, 39*. https://doi.org/10.33265/polar.v39.3755

Caughey, A., Kilabuk, P., Koonoo, T. (2024) "We call it soul food": Inuit women and the role of country food in health and well-being in Nunavut. *Arctic Science, 10*(2) 321-331. https://doi.org/10.1139/as-2023-0038

Gilbert, S.Z., Walsh, D.E., Levy, S.N. et al. Determinants, effects, and coping strategies for low-yield periods of harvest: a qualitative study in two communities in Nunavut, Canada. *Food Sec. 13*, 157–179 (2021). https://doi.org/10.1007/s12571-020-01112-0

21 Action Canada. (2021). Hunger in Nunavut: Local food for healthier communities. https://www.actioncanada.ca/wp-content/uploads/2021/06/TF-3-Hunger-in-Nunavut-EN.pdf

22 Action Canada. (2021). Hunger in Nunavut: Local food for healthier communities. https://www.actioncanada.ca/wp-content/uploads/2021/06/TF-3-Hunger-in-Nunavut-EN.pdf

Newell, S. L., Doubleday, N. C. (2020). Sharing country food: Connecting health, food security and cultural continuity in Chesterfield Inlet, Nunavut. *Polar Research, 39*, 3755. https://doi.org/10.33265/polar.v39.3755

Huet, C., Rosol, R., & Egeland, G. M. (2012). The prevalence of food insecurity is high and the diet quality poor in Inuit communities. *The Journal of Nutrition, 142*(3), 541–547. https://doi.org/10.3945/jn.111.149278

23 Pal, S., Haman, F., & Robidoux, M. A. (2013). The costs of local food procurement in two northern Indigenous communities in Canada. *Food and Foodways, 21*(2), 132-152. https://doi.org/10.1080/07409710.2013.792193

24 Nunavut Food Security Coalition. (2014). *Nunavut food security strategy.* https://www.nunavutfoodsecurity.ca/sites/default/files/files/Resources/Strategy/NunavutFoodSecurityStrategy_ENGLISH.pdf

25 Gilbert, S. Z., Walsh, D. E., Levy, S. N., Maksagak, B., Milton, M. I., Ford, J. D., Hawley, N. L., & Dubrow, R. (2021). Determinants, effects, and coping strategies for low-yield periods of harvest: A qualitative study in two communities in Nunavut, Canada. *Food Security, 13*, 157-179. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12571-020-01112-0

26 Beaumier, M. C., & Ford, J. D. (2010). Food insecurity among Inuit women exacerbated by socio-economic stresses and climate change. *Canadian Journal of Public Health, 101*(3), 196–201. https://doi.org/10.1007/BF03404373

27 Iorwerth, A. A., & Pardy, T. (2023). *Northern housing report 2023*. Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation. https://publications.gc.ca/collections/collection_2024/schl-cmhc/NH12-321-2023-eng.pdf

Laidley, J., & Tabbara, M.-D. (2024). *Welfare in Canada, 2023*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2023.pdf

Nunavut Housing Corporation. (2024). *Nunavut housing needs study*. https://different-basket-89cd87b086.media.strapiapp.com/Housing_Needs_Study_0604_Final_1a7959de04.pdf

Nunavut Tunngavik Inc. (2020). *Nunavut's infrastructure gap*. https://www.tunngavik.com/files/2020/10/2020.10.20-Nunavuts_Infrastructure_Gap_Report_vf.pdf

The Conference Board of Canada. (2024). *Learning from one another: Labour markets in Nunavut.* Future Skills Centre. https://fsc-ccf.ca/wp-content/uploads/2025/04/labour-markets-in-nunavut-2024.pdf

St-Germain, A.-A. F., Galloway, T., & Tarasuk, V. (2019). Food insecurity in Nunavut following the introduction of Nutrition North Canada. *CMAJ, 191*(20), E552–E558. https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.181617

28 Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

Galloway, T., & Li, N. (2023). Pass-through of subsidies to prices under limited competition: Evidence from Canada's Nutrition North program. *Journal of Public Economics, 225*, 104971. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2023.104971

29 Healy, G. (2016) (Re)settlement, Displacement, and Family Separation: Contributors to Health Inequality in Nunavut. *The Northern Review 42* (2016): 47–68; p.49. https://doi.org/10.22584/nr42.2016.004

30 Healy, G. (2016) (Re)settlement, Displacement, and Family Separation: Contributors to Health Inequality in Nunavut. *The Northern Review 42* (2016): 47–68; p.49. https://doi.org/10.22584/nr42.2016.004

31 Healy, G. (2016) (Re)settlement, Displacement, and Family Separation: Contributors to Health Inequality in Nunavut. *The Northern Review 42* (2016): 47–68. https://doi.org/10.22584/nr42.2016.004

Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada. (2015). *Residential schools: The Inuit and Northern experience* (Final report of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada, Vol. 2). McGill–Queen's University Press. https://ehprnh2mwo3.exactdn.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/01/Volume_2_Inuit_and_Northern_English_Web.pdf

32 Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2021). *Inuit Nunangat Food Security Strategy*. Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. https://www.itk.ca/wp-content/uploads/2021/07/ITK_Inuit-Nunangat-Food-Security-Strategy_English.pdf

33 Kuhnlein, H. V., & Receveur, O. (2007). Local cultural animal food contributes high levels of nutrients for Arctic Canadian Indigenous adults and children. *The Journal of Nutrition, 137*(4), 1110-1114. https://doi.org/10.1093/jn/137.4.1110

Lambden, J., Receveur, O., & Kuhnlein, H. V. (2007). Traditional food attributes must be included in studies of food security in the Canadian Arctic. *International Journal of Circumpolar Health, 66*(4), 308–319. https://doi.org/10.3402/ijch.v66i4.18272

Lawn, J., & Harvey, D. (2001). *Change in nutrition and food security in two Inuit communities, 1992 to 1997.* Department of Indian Affairs and Northern Development.

Lawn, J., & Harvey, D. (2003). *Nutrition and food security in Kugaaruk, Nunavut: Baseline survey for the Food Mail Pilot Project.* Department of Indian Affairs and Northern Development.

[34] Ford, J. D., Clark, D., & Naylor, A. (2019). Food insecurity in Nunavut: Are we going from bad to worse? *CMAJ, 191*(20), E550–E551. https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.190497

Ford, J. D. (2009). Vulnerability of Inuit food systems to food insecurity as a consequence of climate change: A case study from Igloolik, *Nunavut. Regional Environmental Change, 9*, 83-100. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10113-008-0060-x

[35] Inutiq, K. S. (2022). Hungry days in Nunavut: The façade of Inuit self-determination. *Yellowhead Institute*. https://yellowheadinstitute.org/2022/hungry-days-in-nunavut-the-facade-of-inuit-self-determination/

Shafiee, M., Keshavarz, P., Lane, G., Pahwa, P., Szafron, M., Jennings, D., & Vatanparast, H. (2022). Food security status of Indigenous Peoples in Canada according to the 4 pillars of food security: A scoping review. *Advances in Nutrition, 13*(6), 2537–2558. https://doi.org/10.1093/advances/nmac081

Newell, S. L., Dion, M. L., & Doubleday, N. C. (2020). Cultural continuity and Inuit health in Arctic Canada. *Journal of Epidemiology & Community Health, 74*(1), 64–70. https://doi.org/10.1136/jech-2018-211856

Qikiqtani Inuit Association. (2019). *Food sovereignty and harvesting*. https://www.qia.ca/wp-content/uploads/2020/02/food-sovereignty-and-harvesting_final_english_2019-03_low.pdf

[36] Nunavut Tunngavik Inc. (2020). *Nunavut's infrastructure gap*. https://www.tunngavik.com/files/2020/10/2020.10.20-Nunavuts_Infrastructure_Gap_Report_vf.pdf

[37] Gerlach, A. J., Browne, A. J., Sinha, V., & Elliott, D. (2017). Navigating structural violence with Indigenous families: The contested terrain of early childhood intervention and the child welfare system in Canada. *International Indigenous Policy Journal, 8*(3), 1-23. https://www.jstor.org/stable/48767257

[38] Nunavut Tunngavik Inc. (2020). *Nunavut's infrastructure gap*. https://www.tunngavik.com/files/2020/10/2020.10.20-Nunavuts_Infrastructure_Gap_Report_vf.pdf

[39] Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

[40] National Advisory Council on Poverty. (2025). *We can do better: It is not a safety net if the holes are this big - the 2025 report of the National Advisory Council on Poverty*. Employment and Social Development Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/employment-social-development/programs/poverty-reduction/national-advisory-council/reports/2025-annual.html

[41] National Advisory Council on Poverty. (2025). *We can do better: It is not a safety net if the holes are this big-the 2025 report of the National Advisory Council on Poverty*. Employment and Social Development Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/employment-social-development/programs/poverty-reduction/national-advisory-council/reports/2025-annual.html

[42] Nunavut Bureau of Statistics. (2024). *Annual labour force stats update, 2023. Government of Nunavut.* https://www.gov.nu.ca/sites/default/files/documents/2024-11/Annual_Labour_Force_StatsUpdate_2023.pdf

[43] Indigenous Services Canada. (2023). An update on the socio-economic gaps between Indigenous Peoples and the non-Indigenous population in Canada: Highlights from the 2021 Census. Government of Canada. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1690909773300/1690909797208

[44] Government of Nunavut. (2024). *GN announces significant salary increase for NEU excluded and senior management employees* [News release]. https://www.gov.nu.ca/en/newsroom/gn-announces-significant-salary-increase-neu-excluded-and-senior-management-employees-2024

Government of Nunavut. (2025, July 8). *Minimum wage rise: 1975 formula introduced to adjust minimum wage annually* [News release]. https://www.gov.nu.ca/en/newsroom/minimum-wage-rise-1975-formula-introduced-adjust-minimum-wage-annually-2025-07-08

Government of Nunavut, Department of Human Resources. (2024, February). *HRM 1514: Northern allowance*. https://www.gov.nu.ca/sites/default/files/documents/2024-02/HRM%201514%20Northern%20Allowance.pdf

Government of Nunavut. (n.d.). *Household allowance*. https://www.gov.nu.ca/en/staff-resources/household-allowance

[45] Tedds, L. M., Cameron, A., & Atherly, A. (2021). *Assessing the state and nature of poverty in Nunavut: A multi-dimensional analysis*. School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. Poverty and Wellbeing in Nunavut Final Oct 21 2021.pdf

The Conference Board of Canada. (2024). *Learning from one another: Labour markets in Nunavut*. Future Skills Centre. https://fsc-ccf.ca/wp-content/uploads/2025/04/labour-markets-in-nunavut-2024.pdf

[46] Nunavut Arctic College. (n.d.). *Locations*. https://www.arcticcollege.com/location

[47] Oschinsky, M. (2024) The current state of the Northern economy for Inuit in Nunavut. Chapter 3 in Inutiq, K., King, H. & Fox, S. (Eds) Pinasunniq: Reflections on a Northern Indigenous Economy. *Yellowhead institute*. https://yellowheadinstitute.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/11/YI-Pinasunniq-Northern-Economy-Report-FINAL.pdf

[48] Burke, A. (2018, May 4). *"Childcare is a chronic issue": Iqaluit parents quitting jobs, dropping out of training programs*. CBC News. https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/north/nunavut-daycare-shortage-unemployment-kindergarten-1.4646297

Employment and Social Development Canada. (2025, March 6). *Toward $10-a-day: An early learning and childcare backgrounder* [Backgrounder]. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/employment-social-development/news/2025/03/toward-10-a-day-an-early-learning-and-child-care-backgrounder0.html

O'Gorman, M., & Pandey, M. (2014). *Cultivating the Arctic's most valuable resource: An analysis of barriers to high school completion among youth in Nunavut.* Department of Economics, University of Winnipeg. http://www.csls.ca/events/cea2014/cea-papers-2014-pandey.pdf

Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated. (2020, October). *Nunavut's infrastructure gap.* https://www.tunngavik.com/files/2020/10/2020.10.20-Nunavuts_Infrastructure_Gap_Report_vf.pdf

[49] Ipeelie, M. (2025). *Improving access to quality health care for Inuit residents of Inuit Nunangat: A fact sheet for non-Inuit practitioners.* National Collaborating Centre for Indigenous Health. https://www.nccih.ca/495/quality-care-Inuit.nccih?id=10482

Young, T.K., Tabish, T., Young, S.K., Akearok, G.H. (2019) Patient transportation in Canada's northern territories: patterns, costs and providers' perspectives. *Rural and Remote Health*; 19: 5113. https://doi.org/10.22605/RRH5113

Radhaa, M., Leason, J., Twalibu, A., Davis, E., Fletcher, C. D., Lawford, K., Darling, E., Wylie, L., Couchie, C., Simon, D., & John-Baptiste, A. (2025). Costs of medical evacuation and transportation of First Nations Peoples and Inuit who travel for medical care in Canada: A systematic review. *Canadian journal of public health = Revue canadienne de sante publique, 116*(1), 5–25. https://doi.org/10.17269/s41997-024-00945-y

Jull, J., Sheppard, A. J., Hizaka, A., Inuit Medical Interpreter Team, Barton, G., Doering, P., Dorschner, D., Edgecombe, N., Ellis, M., Graham, I. D., Habash, M., Jodouin, G., Kilabuk, L., Koonoo, T., Roberts, C., & Mamisarvik Healing Centre Team (2021). Experiences of Inuit in Canada who travel from remote settings for cancer care and impacts on decision making. *BMC health services research, 21*(1), 328. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12913-021-06303-9

Brubacher, L. J., Tatty, N., Harper, S. L., Cunsolo, A., Healey Akearok, G. K., Humphries, S., & Dewey, C. E. (2024). Inuit birthing in the Qikiqtaaluk Region of Nunavut: A place-based inquiry of maternity care systems. *Health & Place, 90*, 103355. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.healthplace.2024.103355

[50] Nunatsiaq News. (2023, April 12). *GN raises income assistance to help with rising food costs.* https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/gn-raises-income-assistance-to-help-with-rising-food-costs/

[51] Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024.* Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

[52] Nunavut. (1990). *Income Assistance Regulations, R.R.N.W.T. (Nu) 1990, c. S-16.* https://www.canlii.org/en/nu/laws/regu/rrnwt-nu-1990-c-s-16/latest

[53] Nunavut Housing Corporation. (n.d.). *Public housing.* https://www.nunavuthousing.ca/programs/public-housing#eligibility

[54] Nunavut Housing Corporation. (2024). *Nunavut housing needs study.* https://different-basket-89cd87b086.media.strapiapp.com/Housing_Needs_Study_0604_Final_1a7959de04.pdf

[55] Iorwerth, A. A., & Pardy, T. (2023). *Northern housing report 2023*. Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation. https://publications.gc.ca/collections/collection_2024/schl-cmhc/NH12-321-2023-eng.pdf

[56] Naylor, J., Deaton, B. J., & Ker, A. (2020). Assessing the effect of food retail subsidies on the price of food in remote Indigenous communities in Canada. *Food Policy, 93*, 101889. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.foodpol.2020.101889

[57] Galloway, T., & Li, N. (2023). Pass-through of subsidies to prices under limited competition: Evidence from Canada's Nutrition North program. *Journal of Public Economics, 225*, 104971. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2023.104971

[58] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[59] Galloway, T. & Li, N. (2023) Pass-through of subsidies to prices under limited competition: Evidence from Canada's Nutrition North program. *Journal of Public Economics, 225*. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2023.104971.

[60] Li, N., Daley, A., & Watson, B. (2025). Give and take? Child benefits and prices in Northern Canada. *Canadian Journal of Economics/Revue canadienne d'économique, 58*(3), 831–859. https://doi.org/10.1111/caje.70021

[61] St-Germain, A.-A.F., Galloway, T. & Tarasuk. (2019). Food insecurity in Nunavut following the introduction of Nutrition North Canada. *CMAJ,191*(20). https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.181617

Galloway, T. & Li, N. (2023). Pass-through of subsidies to prices under limited competition: Evidence from Canada's Nutrition North program. *Journal of Public Economics, 225*. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2023.104971.

Deaton, B. J., & Scholz, A. (2022). Food security, food insecurity, and Canada's national food policy: Meaning, measures, and assessment. *Outlook on Agriculture, 51*(3), 303-312. https://doi.org/10.1177/00307270221113601

Burnett, K., Skinner, K. & LeBlanc, J. (2015). From Food Mail to Nutrition North Canada: Reconsidering federal food subsidy programs for northern Ontario. *Canadian Food Studies/La Revue canadienne des études sur l'alimentation, 2*(1), 141–156. https://doi.org/10.15353/cfs-rcea.v2i1.62

[62] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, May 23). *Supporting Inuit children*. Government of Canada https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1536348095773/1536348148664

[63] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, May 23). *Supporting Inuit children*. Government of Canada https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1536348095773/1536348148664

[64] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, May 23). *Supporting Inuit children*. Government of Canada https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1536348095773/1536348148664

Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2022). ATUAGAQ: *A guide for families navigating the Inuit Child First Initiative*. Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. https://www.itk.ca/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/Inuit-Child-First-Initiative-Guide-Atuagaq-English.pdf

[65] Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2018, September 10). *Federal Government and ITK announce the development of a new Inuit-specific Child First Initiative*. [Press release]. https://www.itk.ca/federal-government-and-itk-announce-the-development-of-a-new-inuit-specific-child-first-initiative/

[66] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, May 23). *Supporting Inuit children*. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1536348095773/1536348148664

Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, December 2). *Jordan's Principle*. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1568396042341/1568396159824

[67] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, December 2). *Jordan's Principle*. Government of Canada. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1568396042341/1568396159824

[68] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, February 10). *Jordan's Principle Operational Bulletin*. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1739222520301/1739222546551

[69] *Canadian Human Rights Act* (R.S.C., 1985, c. H-6) I,5; I,3(1)

[70] Sinha, V., Sheppard, C., Chadwick, K., Gunnarsson, M., & Jamieson, G. (2021). Substantive Equality and Jordan's Principle: Challenges and Complexities. *Journal of Law and Social Policy, 35*, 21-43. https://doi.org/10.60082/0829-3929.1422

[71] *First Nations Child & Family Caring Society of Canada et al. v. Attorney General of Canada,* Tribunal File No. T1340/7008 (Canadian Human Rights Tribunal Nov. 21, 2024).

First Nations Child & Family Caring Society of Canada et al. v. Attorney General of Canada et al., 2025 CHRT 6, Tribunal File No. T1340/7008 (Canadian Human Rights Tribunal Jan. 29, 2025).

[72] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, December 2). *Jordan's Principle*. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1568396042341/1568396159824

Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, May 23). *Supporting Inuit children*. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1536348095773/1536348148664

[73] Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2022). A*TUAGAQ: A Guide for Families Navigating the Inuit Child First Initiative* (p.6). https://www.itk.ca/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/Inuit-Child-First-Initiative-Guide-Atuagaq-English.pdf

[74] Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2018, September 10). *Federal Government and ITK announce the development of a new Inuit-specific Child First Initiative*. [Press release]. https://www.itk.ca/federal-government-and-itk-announce-the-development-of-a-new-inuit-specific-child-first-initiative/

[75] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025). *Statement by Minister Hajdu on extension of the Inuit Child First Initiative*. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/indigenous-services-canada/news/2025/03/statement-by-minister-hajdu-on-extension-of-the-inuit-child-first-initiative.html

Department of Finance Canada. (2019). *Investing in the middle class: Budget 2019*. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/revenue-agency/programs/about-

canada-revenue-agency-cra/federal-government-budgets/budget-2019-investing-middle-class.html

[76] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[77] Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2024, April 16). *ITK encouraged by Budget 2024 investments in Inuit housing, infrastructure and food security.* https://www.itk.ca/itk-encouraged-by-budget-2024-investments-in-inuit-housing-infrastructure-and-food-security/

Indigenous Services Canada. (2025). *Statement by Minister Hajdu on extension of the Inuit Child First Initiative*. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/indigenous-services-canada/news/2025/03/statement-by-minister-hajdu-on-extension-of-the-inuit-child-first-initiative.html

[78] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[79] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[80] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[81] Pugliese, K. (2025, March 7). 'If Mason didn't have hockey, I don't know if I'd have a son': The kids and communities caught in Jordan's Principle fiasco. *APTN News.* https://www.aptnnews.ca/national-news/jordans-principle-kitigan-zibi-indigenous-services-federal-government/

[82] *First Nations Child & Family Caring Society of Canada et al. v. Attorney General of Canada,* Tribunal File No. T1340/7008 (Canadian Human Rights Tribunal Nov. 21, 2024). https://fncaringsociety.com/sites/default/files/2025-04/20250415%20Factum%20of%20Interested%20Party%2C%20Our%20Children%20Our%20Way.pdf

First Nations Child & Family Caring Society of Canada et al. v. Attorney General of Canada et al., 2025 CHRT 6, Tribunal File No. T1340/7008 (Canadian Human Rights Tribunal Jan. 29, 2025). https://fncaringsociety.com/sites/default/files/2025-04/20250415%20Factum%20of%20Interested%20Party%2C%20Our%20Children%20Our%20Way.pdf

[83] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[84] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, February 10). *Jordan's Principle Operational Bulletin.* https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1739222520301/1739222546551

[85] Employment and social development Canada. (February 28, 2025). *More healthy meals for kids in Nunavut*. [News release]. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/employment-social-development/news/2025/02/more-healthy-meals-for-kids-in-nunavut.html

[86] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025). *Statement by Minister Hajdu on extension of the Inuit Child First Initiative*. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/indigenous-services-canada/news/2025/03/statement-by-minister-hajdu-on-extension-of-the-inuit-child-first-initiative.html

[87] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[88] House of Commons of Canada. (2026, March 11). *Response to written question Q-759*. https://www.ourcommons.ca/written-questions/45-1/q-759/13960239?showQuestion=true&section=all

[89] Indigenous Services Canada. (2026, February 19). *Minister Gull-Masty announces new support to empower Inuit and strengthen northern communities* [News release]. Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/indigenous-services-canada/news/2026/02/minister-gull-masty-announces-new-support-to-empower-inuit-and-strengthen-northern-communities.html

[90] Indigenous Service Canada (2025) Grocery Requests, Inuit Child First Initiative (Part 1) shared by ISC.

[91] Author's calculations based on ISC data: Indigenous Service Canada (2025) Grocery Requests, Inuit Child First Initiative (Part 1) shared by ISC.

[92] McInnis, O. (2025, July 26) National School Food Program Funding. Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated Briefing Note

[93] Sarkisian, A. (2024, November 20). NTI to 'audit' grocery prices as Jordan's Principle funding pours in. *Nunatsiaq News*. https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/nti-to-audit-grocery-prices-as-jordans-principle-funding-pours-in/

[94] Antunes, J. (2025, April 24). No more approvals for Inuit Child First Initiative food voucher program applications: Official. Nunatsiaq News. https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/no-more-approvals-for-inuit-child-first-initiative-food-voucher-program-applications-official/

[95] Author's calculations based on ISC data: Indigenous Service Canada (2025) Grocery Requests, Inuit Child First Initiative (Part 1) shared by ISC.

[96] Key informant interview

[97] Wright, T. (2023, August 22). "They can't afford food": Feds urged to speed up Inuit applications for aid. *APTN News*. https://www.aptnnews.ca/national-news/inuit-child-first-initiative-provides-everything-from-food-to-beds/

[98] Author's calculation based on available government documents and media reports.

[99] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025). Inuit Child First Operational Bulletin: Updates to the implementation of the Inuit Child First Initiative. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1740416957763/1740416986002

Pugliese, K. (2025, March 7). 'If Mason didn't have hockey, I don't know if I'd have a son': The kids and communities caught in Jordan's Principle fiasco. *APTN News*. https://www.aptnnews.ca/national-news/jordans-principle-kitigan-zibi-indigenous-services-federal-government/

[100] Sarkisian, A. (2024, November 20). NTI to 'audit' grocery prices as Jordan's Principle funding pours in. *Nunatsiaq News*. https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/nti-to-audit-grocery-prices-as-jordans-principle-funding-pours-in/

[101] Indigenous Services Canada (2025) Inuit Child First Operational Bulletin. https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1740416957763/1740416986002

[102] CBC News. (2025, April 27). The children are eating less now: Nunavummiut protest the end of the food voucher program. https://www.cbc.ca/lite/story/1.7519191?feature=related-link

[103] Wat, S. (2026, February 20). Northerners want changes to programs across Inuit Nunangat-not just more federal money. *CBC News*. https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/north/mandy-gull-masty-funding-inuit-nunangat-9.7098445

Antunes, J (2026, January 22). 'It's been a struggle': Iqaluit mom waits 6 months for answers on food support. *Nunatsiaq News*. https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/its-been-a-struggle-iqaluit-mom-waits-6-months-for-answers-on-food-support/

[104] Quotations from an anonymized ICFI grocery supports approval letter shared by Qupanuaq.

[105] *First Nations Child & Family Caring Society of Canada et al. v. Attorney General of Canada*, Tribunal File No. T1340/7008 (Canadian Human Rights Tribunal Nov. 21, 2024).

First Nations Child & Family Caring Society of Canada et al. v. Attorney General of Canada et al., 2025 CHRT 6, Tribunal File No. T1340/7008 (Canadian Human Rights Tribunal Jan. 29, 2025).

[106] Gilbert, S. (2025, September 26). *Surging food insecurity crisis* [Press conference presentation]. Press conference hosted by Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre and Arctic Children & Youth Foundation, Iqaluit, NU, Canada.

Varela, W. K. (2025, October 2). Iqaluit food bank says it feeds 8 per cent of the city, wants to double staff. *Nunavut News*. https://nunavutnews.com/2025/10/02/iqaluit-food-bank-says-it-feeds-8-per-cent-of-the-city-wants-to-double-staff/

[107] Staniforth, J. (2025, November 26). 'People are having a hard time now getting food': Nunavut hunger crisis continues. *APTN News*. https://www.aptnnews.ca/featured/people-are-having-a-hard-time-now-getting-food-nunavut-hunger-crisis-continues/

Statistics Canada. (2022). *Indigenous population profile, 2021 Census of Population: Cambridge Bay, Hamlet (Census subdivision), Nunavut.* Government of Canada. https://www12.statcan.gc.ca/census-recensement/2021/dp-pd/ipp-ppa/details/page.cfm

[108] Hanson, L. (2025). *The JP food voucher program: A band-aid for Inuit child food security in Pangnirtung* [Report prepared for the Hamlet of Pangnirtung, Nunavut].

[109] Daley, A., Pandey, S., Phipps, S., & Watson, B. (2024). From the Food Mail Program to Nutrition North Canada: The impact on food insecurity among Indigenous and non-Indigenous families with children. *Canadian Journal of Economics/Revue canadienne d'économique, 57*(4), 1348–1379. https://doi.org/10.1111/caje.12688

[110] Christofides A, Schauer C, Zlotkin SH.(2005) Iron deficiency and anemia prevalence and associated etiologic risk factors in First Nations and Inuit communities in northern Ontario and Nunavut. *Canadian Journal of Public Health*, 96:304-7

[111] Nunavut Department of Health (2015) Protocol for Identifying and Treating Iron Deficiency Anemia in Infants and Young Children.I https://www.gov.nu.ca/sites/default/files/documents/2023-10/nunavut_protocol_for_ida_approved_2015_may_20_0.pdf

[112] Zipper, R. et al (2025) Morbidity and mortality in 128 otherwise healthy Canadian children with severe iron deficiency anemia in the setting of ongoing bottle use and excessive cow's milk intake: A massive preventable problem demanding action. *Blood, 146* (Supplement 1): 2903. doi: https://doi.org/10.1182/blood-2025-2903

[113] Maslow, A. H. (1943). A theory of human motivation. *Psychological Review, 50*(4), 370–396. https://doi.org/10.1037/h0054346

[114] Hanson, L. (2025). *The JP food voucher program: A band-aid for Inuit child food security in Pangnirtung* [Report prepared for the Hamlet of Pangnirtung, Nunavut].

[115] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[116] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[117] Sarkisian, A. (2024, November 20). NTI to "audit" grocery prices as Jordan's Principle funding pours in. *Nunatsiaq News.* https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/nti-to-audit-grocery-prices-as-jordans-principle-funding-pours-in/

[118] Daley, A., Pandey, S., Phipps, S., & Watson, B. (2024). From the Food Mail Program to Nutrition North Canada: The impact on food insecurity among Indigenous and non-Indigenous families with children. *Canadian Journal of Economics/Revue canadienne d'économique, 57*(4), 1348–1379. https://doi.org/10.1111/caje.12688

[119] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[120] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[121] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[122] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[123] Li, N., Morgan,R. Wheatley, D., Sinha, V. & Morrison, M. (2026) Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/2p92nxr2

[124] CBC News. (2025, April 27). "The children are eating less now": Nunavummiut protest the end of the food voucher program. https://www.cbc.ca/lite/story/1.7519191?feature=related-link

[125] Nunavut. (2021). *Income Assistance Regulations, R.R.N.W.T. 1990, c. S-16* (current to August 16, 2021). https://www.nunavutlegislation.ca/en/consolidated-law/income-assistance-regulations-consolidation

[126] Sinha, V., Sangster, M., Arbati, K., Gerlach, A. J., Bennett, M., Hart, J., Folster, S., Lavoie, J. G., & Lach, L. (2021). *The implementation of Jordan's Principle in Manitoba: Interim report.* Assembly of Manitoba Chiefs.

Sinha, V., Sangster, M., Gerlach, A. J., Bennett, M., Lavoie, J. G., Lach, L., Balfour, M., & Folster, S. (2022). *The implementation of Jordan's Principle in Manitoba: Final report.* Assembly of Manitoba Chiefs.

Sangster, M., Gad, S., & Sinha, V. (2021). *Nikan Kakike Awasisak (Children Always First): Implementing Jordan's Principle in the Kee Tas Kee Now Member Nations.* Kee Tas Kee Now Health Administration.

Sinha, V., Vives Gonzalez, L., & Gerlach, A. J. (Eds.). (2018). *Implementing Jordan's Principle service coordination in the Alberta region.* First Nations Health Consortium.

[127] Sinha, V. & Lavoie, J. G. (2024). Substantive equality, self-determination, administrative discretion: Lessons from the implementation of Jordan's Principles in two provinces. *Health Reform Observer. 11*(3). https://doi.org/10.13162/hro-ors.v11i3.5740

[128] Pugliese, K. (2025, March 7). "If Mason didn't have hockey, I don't know if I'd have a son": The kids and communities caught in Jordan's Principle fiasco. *APTN News.* https://www.aptnnews.ca/national-news/jordans-principle-kitigan-zibi-indigenous-services-federal-government/

Wright, T. (2023, August 22). "They can't afford food": Feds urged to speed up Inuit applications for aid. *APTN News.* https://www.aptnnews.ca/national-news/inuit-child-first-initiative-provides-everything-from-food-to-beds/

[129] Blackstock, C. (2025). *Honouring Jordan's Principle* [Keynote presentation]. 11th International Meeting on Indigenous Child Health, Winnipeg, MB, Canada. https://cps.ca/uploads/imich/Keynote-Blackstock.pdf

[130] Herd, P., Hoynes, H., Michener, J., & Moynihan, D. (2023). Introduction: Administrative burden as a mechanism of inequality in policy implementation. *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences, 9*(4), 1–18. https://www.rsfjournal.org/content/rsfjss/9/4/1.full.pdf

[131] Indigenous Services Canada. (2025, September 4). *Question period note: The Inuit Child First Initiative* (Reference No. ISC-2025-QP-00800). Government of Canada. https://search.open.canada.ca/qpnotes/record/isc-sac%2CISC-2025-QP-00800

[132] Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). *Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada* [Manuscript]. https://www.arts.ryerson.ca/economics/repec/pdfs/wp101.pdf

[133] Burnett, K., & Hay, T. (2023). *Plundering the North: A history of settler colonialism, corporate welfare, and food insecurity*. University of Manitoba Press.

[134] Wat, S. (2024, August 19). Hamlet of Arctic Bay, Nunavut, warns people against misusing Jordan's Principle program: Some people are reportedly reselling items purchased with the JP fund - for cash. *CBC News*. https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/north/arctic-bay-jordan-s-principle-program-1.7283043

[135] Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). *Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada.* https://static1.squarespace.com/static/60a2779da6164d69e391f496/t/69f3585c4082fd15c52d786a/1777555548979/Manuscript+NNC+CCB.pdf

[136] Sinha, V., Li, N., Wheatley, D., Hoang, N, Mitchell, K., Reddy, D., Govindapillai, Galloway, T., S., Khan, M.N., Morgan, R., Penney, J. (2025) *Preliminary findings from an evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Qikiqtaaluk.* Qupanuaq. https://icfi-evaluation.ca/yc7bfdr8

[137] Gilbert, S. (2025, September 26) "Surging Food Insecurity Crisis." Press conference hosted by Qajuqturvik Community Food Centre with Arctic Children & Youth Foundation. Iqaluit, Nunavut, Canada.

[138] Galloway, T., Li, N., Roher, S., Monteith, H., Fairman, K., Ulikatalik, J., & Zoe, J. B. (n.d.). Learning about Indigenous concepts relevant to food security intervention in northern communities (Nutrition North Canada Food Security Research Grant, Phase I).

[139] Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). *Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada* [Manuscript]. https://static1.squarespace.com/static/60a2779da6164d69e391f496/t/69f3585c4082fd15c52d786a/1777555548979/Manuscript+NNC+CCB.pdf

[140] Canada Revenue Agency. (n.d.). *Canada child benefit (CCB): How much you can get.* Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/revenue-agency/services/child-family-benefits/canada-child-benefit-overview/canada-child-benefit-how-much.html

Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

141 Daley, A., Galloway, T., Li, N., & Watson, B. (n.d.). *Evaluating policies to improve food affordability, nutrition, and food security in remote communities in Northern Canada* [Manuscript]. https://static1.squarespace.com/static/60a2779da6164d69e391f496/t/69f3585c4082fd15c52d786a/1777555548979/Manuscript+NNC+CCB.pdf

142 Canada Revenue Agency. (n.d.). *Canada child benefit (CCB): How much you can get.* Government of Canada. https://www.canada.ca/en/revenue-agency/services/child-family-benefits/canada-child-benefit-overview/canada-child-benefit-how-much.html

143 Nunavut. (n.d.). *Nunavut child benefit (NUCB).* https://www.gov.nu.ca/en/social-supports/nunavut-child-benefit-nucb

144 Pelletier, J. (2026, June 15) MLAs approve doubling Nunavut Child Benefit payments. *Nunatsiaq News.* https://nunatsiaq.com/stories/article/mlas-approve-doubling-nunavut-child-benefit-payments/

145 Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024*. Maytree Foundation. https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

146 Tedds, L. M., Petit, G., Perrin, D., & Harrington, M. (2023). *Basic income simulations in Nunavut.* School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. https://inclusiecon.ca/Simulations%20of%20Basic%20Income%20in%20Nunavut%20Final%20January%202023.pdf

147 Nunavut. (1990). *Income Assistance Regulations, R.R.N.W.T. (Nu) 1990, c. S-16.* CanLII. https://www.canlii.org/en/nu/laws/regu/rrnwt-nu-1990-c-s-16/latest

Tedds, L. M., Petit, G., Perrin, D., & Harrington, M. (2023). *Basic income simulations in Nunavut.* School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. https://inclusiecon.ca/Simulations%20of%20Basic%20Income%20in%20Nunavut%20Final%20January%202023.pdf

Laidley, J., & Oliveira, T. (2025). *Welfare in Canada, 2024.* Maytree Foundation.https://maytree.com/wp-content/uploads/Welfare_in_Canada_2024.pdf

148 Tedds, L. M., Petit, G., Perrin, D., & Harrington, M. (2023). *Basic income simulations in Nunavut.* School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. https://inclusiecon.ca/Simulations%20of%20Basic%20Income%20in%20Nunavut%20Final%20January%202023.pdf

149 Tedds, L.M., Petit, G., Perin, D. & Harrington, M. (2023). *Basic income simulations in Nunavut.* School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. https://inclusiecon.ca/Simulations%20of%20Basic%20Income%20in%20Nunavut%20Final%20January%202023.pdf

Tedds, L., Petit, G., Perin, D. & Harrington, M. (2023). *Basic income design options for modelling: Modelling options for a basic income to support Nunavummiut.* School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. https://inclusiecon.ca/GBI%20Design%20Options%20Final%20January%202023.pdf

Cameron, A., Petit, G., & Tedds, L. M. (2024). A basic income for Nunavut: Addressing poverty in Canada's North. *Canadian Public Policy, 50*(3), 311–328. https://utppublishing.com/doi/10.3138/cpp.2023-045

150 Cameron, A., Petit, G., & Tedds, L. M. (2024). A basic income for Nunavut: Addressing poverty in Canada's North. Canadian *Public Policy, 50*(3), 311–328. https://utppublishing.com/doi/10.3138/cpp.2023-045

151 Galloway, T. & Li, N. (2023) Pass-through of subsidies to prices under limited competition: Evidence from Canada's Nutrition North program. *Journal of Public Economics, 225.* https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpubeco.2023.104971.

152 Cameron, A., Petit, G., & Tedds, L. M. (2024). A basic income for Nunavut: Addressing poverty in Canada's North. *Canadian Public Policy, 50*(3), 311–328. https://utppublishing.com/doi/10.3138/cpp.2023-045

153 Gaspard, H. (2022). D*ata assessment and framing of an analysis of substantive equality through the application of Jordan's Principle*. Institute of Fiscal Studies and Democracy, University of Ottawa. https://ifsd.ca/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/ifsd-report-2022-09-data-assessment-and-framing-analysis-of-substantive-equality-through-the-application-of-jordans-principle.pdf

Jordan's Principle Working Group (2015). *Without denial, delay, or disruption: Ensuring First Nations children's access to equitable services through Jordan's Principle*. Ottawa, ON: Assembly of First Nations. https://cwrp.ca/publications/without-denial-delay-or-disruption-ensuring-first-nations-childrens-access-equitable

154 Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami. (2021). *Inuit Nunangat food security strategy*. https://www.itk.ca/wp-content/uploads/2021/07/ITK_Inuit-Nunangat-Food-Security-Strategy_English.pdf

155 Qikiqtani Inuit Association. (2019). *Food sovereignty and harvesting.* https://www.qia.ca/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/Food-Sovereignty-and-Harvesting.pdf

156 Qikiqtani Inuit Association. (2019). *Food sovereignty and harvesting.* https://www.qia.ca/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/Food-Sovereignty-and-Harvesting.pdf

157 The Nunavut Roundtable for Poverty Reduction. (2016). *The Makimaniq plan 2: A shared approach to poverty reduction.* https://www.gov.nu.ca/en/media/4911




ᖁᑯᓂᖅ
Qupanuaq